

Aokigahara by Century

Century-specific answers from the 7th century to the 19th century

Compiled from the century-by-century responses in this chat, with the answer prose preserved and presented as a single reading document.

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7th Century

Seventh century only — 600—699 — gives the most austere answer so far:

Aokigahara still does not exist. Fuji is not yet securely visible in dated eruption records. The later Aokigahara site is still part of a pre-Jōgan north-foot lake/volcano world, while the clearest seventh-century evidence belongs not to the forest but to settlement, tombs, local elites and early state formation around Fuji's southern foot.

So the seventh-century layer is not suicide, not pilgrimage, not Aokigahara, not even the *Man' yōshū* Fuji-poem world of the eighth century. It is:

pre-Aokigahara, pre-recorded-eruption Fuji; a mountain already imposing itself on settlement and identity, but not yet captured in the surviving written record as the later fire-god/pacification system.

The important negative finding is brutal: if we stay inside 600—699, almost every famous Aokigahara/Fuji layer is still unavailable.

1. Hard boundary: Aokigahara does not exist in the seventh century

Aokigahara is created by the 864—866 Jōgan eruption, more than 160 years after the seventh century ends. JMA records that eruption as a major north-west flank eruption: lava from around Nagao-yama flowed out as Aokigahara lava, reached Motosuko, split the older Seno-umi / せのうみ into Shōjiko and Saiko, buried homes, and damaged lake fish. ([data.jma.go.jp](https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html))

That means in 600—699, there is no Aokigahara lava field and no Aokigahara forest in the later sense. The maps above show the later Jōgan lava footprint; they are useful precisely because the seventh century is the world before that footprint existed.

The correct seventh-century object is therefore not “Aokigahara”. It is the pre-Aokigahara north-west Fuji foot: old lake, older ground, settlement zones, forested slopes, and a volcano whose later recorded activity will violently remake the area.

2. There is no seventh-century “suicide forest” evidence — not even close

For 600—699, there is no reliable evidence for:

Aokigahara as a suicide destination; Aokigahara as a “tree sea”; Aokigahara as a no-return forest; Aokigahara as an ubasute place; Saiko/Shōjiko as the modern separated lake-pair; Fuji-kō; Matsudai Shōnin; Hitoana as recorded underworld cave; organised Fuji ascent; Matsumoto-style literary disappearance.

Those layers arrive much later. The first dated eruption in JMA's historical list is 781, not the seventh century, and the Aokigahara-making eruption is 864—866. ([data.jma.go.jp](https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html))

So the seventh-century answer has to be a reconstruction of the preconditions, not a fake early origin story.

3. The key seventh-century evidence is archaeological, not literary

The best seventh-century evidence comes from the Fuji southern foot, especially the Tōdaira site / 東平遺跡 around present Fuji City/Fujinomiya' s wider historical zone.

Fujinomiya City' s discussion of the Tōdaira site says a large settlement appeared there in the first half of the seventh century and continued until around the tenth century. It also says the area had earlier tombs, and that in the seventh century new land development and planned village management began. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/3010400000/p001937.html))

This is not Aokigahara. It is on the southern/SW Fuji-foot side. But it is the strongest seventh-century window into the human world around Fuji.

It tells us that before Fuji becomes visible in eruption records and before Aokigahara is born, the Fuji region already has:

planned settlement; local elites; burial landscapes; land development; early administrative integration; proto-ritual/social centres.

That is the seventh-century reality: human ordering around the mountain, not death-forest mythology.

4. Tomb culture: the Fuji foot is already a social hierarchy landscape

Fuji City' s Kofun-period page says the Kofun period runs from the mid-third century to the early eighth century, and that in the Fuji City area many tombs were built. It states that in the sixth to seventh centuries even local powerful people below the highest elite level were building smaller tombs, and horizontal stone chambers became common, allowing repeated burial. ([city.fuji.shizuoka.jp](https://www.city.fuji.shizuoka.jp/4005230000/miryoku/p007622.html))

This matters because it gives us the seventh-century death layer.

The seventh-century “death” around Fuji is not suicide or disappearance. It is burial order: tombs, local hierarchy, repeated interment, family/lineage memory, stone chambers.

That is crucial.

Modern Aokigahara death is anti-social: solitary entry, no grave, no public body, no place in lineage.

Seventh-century Fuji-foot death is social: tomb, chamber, lineage, local status, repeated burial, community memory.

So the deepest contrast is:

7th century: death is placed into stone and lineage. Modern Aokigahara: death is imagined as escape from placement.

That is the inversion.

5. The Fuji south-foot settlement is not marginal wilderness

Tōdaira is described as a settlement over 1 km east-west and north-south, with surrounding contemporary sites forming a broad site cluster. Later, in the eighth century, it becomes connected to the Fuji district government office / 富士郡衙, public buildings, temples and the ancient Tōkaidō route, but the important point for the seventh century is that the settlement itself appears in the first half of the century and reflects planned development. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/3010400000/p001937.html))

This gives a hard correction to any fantasy of Fuji's whole perimeter as wild sacred emptiness.

By the seventh century, at least on the southern foot, Fuji is already within a humanising process: settlement expansion, elite tombs, road/state integration beginning, and planned land use.

Again, not Aokigahara. But it tells you what kind of world the mountain is embedded in before the later Asama eruption-pacification system hardens.

6. The mountain is present before it is textually explicit

The Tōdaira article later discusses an eighth-century ink-inscribed pottery reading 布自 / Fuji, but that artefact is outside our seventh-century boundary. It matters only as a warning: the name Fuji becomes administratively/materially visible in the following century, while the settlement that will produce that world already begins in the seventh. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/3010400000/p001937.html))

So the seventh-century Fuji is archaeologically present before it is cleanly textually named in the surviving Fuji-faith record.

That is a subtle but important point. The mountain was obviously there; communities lived under it; elites buried dead around it; routes and settlements developed. But the surviving named religious-literary Fuji system is not yet fully visible.

7. No recorded Fuji eruption yet — but that does not mean no volcanic awareness

JMA's historical chronology begins its dated Fuji eruption list at 781, with ashfall; the next major entries are 800—802 and 864—866. ([data.jma.go.jp](https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html))

For the seventh century, therefore, we do not have a dated written eruption record. That does not mean Fuji was culturally neutral. Fujinomiya's official faith history says that from ancient times Fuji's repeated eruptions and lava flows made it a fearful and mysterious mountain, worshipped from afar; only after the ancient state system developed, especially from the late eighth century onward, was Fuji or its indwelling deity worshipped as Asama Ōkami in state-linked pacification form. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001611.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So seventh century is a pre-documentary/pre-systematised phase. The mountain may well have been feared and worshipped, but the surviving institutional sources do not yet give us the later clean Asama shrine framework.

The honest formulation is:

Seventh-century Fuji is before the first dated eruption record and before the explicit late-eighth-century state-pacification system, but not before human awe.

8. The religious mode is probably remote awe, not ascent

Later official summaries describe the early form of Fuji worship as 遙拝 / worship from afar, looking up from the foot of the mountain, before later 登山 / climbing worship develops when eruptions quieten. The Yamanashi World Heritage Centre says the oldest recorded eruption disasters go back to the eighth century and that in that period Fuji faith took the form of worship from the foot, with prayers to the fire deity Asama Ōkami to calm eruptions. ([fujisan-whc.jp](https://www.fujisan-whc.jp/about/feature.ht

ml?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That is eighth-century-plus wording, but it helps constrain the seventh century: if even the eighth-century religious structure is mainly remote/pacifying, the seventh century is certainly not yet the later mountain-entry or Aokigahara-entry world.

The likely seventh-century directionality is:

settlement below → mountain above → awe/fear/visibility.

Not:

forest edge → inward entry → disappearance.

9. Pre-Aokigahara north foot: the intact lake-world

The seventh-century north-west foot must be understood through what the ninth century later destroys. JMA says the 864—866 lava split Seno-umi into Shōjiko and Saiko; therefore before 864, including the seventh century, the old lake still existed in some form.

([data.jma.go.jp](https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html))

This is one of the strongest seventh-century conclusions we can draw, because it follows from the later eruption record.

So the seventh-century Aokigahara-site is not forest but pre-split lake-margin. The later “sea of trees” is, at this stage, a lake-world and surrounding land.

That is the deepest geographic fact:

before 樹海, there is 海.

Before the sea of trees, a real water-world.

10. The seventh-century landscape colour is water/soil/settlement, not lava-green forest

In the ninth century, the Jōgan eruption will produce red fire, black lava, boiling water and eventually green forest. In the seventh century, the landscape is pre-catastrophe.

So the future Aokigahara site should be imagined as:

Seno-umi lake surface; Motosu and older lake margins; pre-864 forests and slopes; settlement/ecology around water; Fuji’s north-west foot before the lava wound.

That is necessarily partly inferential, but it is anchored by the 864 record that later changes it. We must not visualise seventh-century Aokigahara as modern Aokigahara. It is the wrong landscape.

11. The seventh-century “death” field: tombs, not lava or forest

The best seventh-century death evidence is not at Aokigahara but in the broader Fuji region’s Kofun-to-Asuka transition.

Fuji City says local tomb building continued into the sixth and seventh centuries, with smaller tombs for local powerful people and horizontal stone chambers permitting repeated burial.

([city.fuji.shizuoka.jp](https://www.city.fuji.shizuoka.jp/4005230000/miryoku/p007622.html))

This gives a precise death-culture contrast.

Seventh-century death near Fuji is:

materialised; buried; communal; lineage-bearing; socially marked; stone-chambered.

Modern Aokigahara death is imagined as:

unmarked; unfound; unlineaged; unritualised or anti-ritual; outside family/social placement.

So if we are tracking the deepest long history, the seventh century gives the opposite of Aokigahara: the body is not meant to disappear into forest; it is meant to be placed in an inherited chamber-world.

12. The state is forming; the forest of disappearance is not

Tōdaira becomes especially important because it sits at the transition from local settlement to later district-level administration. The Fujinomiya article says the site appeared in the first half of the seventh century and later, under the eighth-century ritsuryō system, became associated with Fuji district government, public facilities, temples and the ancient Tōkaidō.

([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/3010400000/p001937.html))

This sequence matters because the seventh century is a state-formation century around Fuji. Bodies, land, roads, settlements and offices are becoming more legible to power.

Again, this is the opposite of the later Aokigahara fantasy. The later fantasy is to exit the ledger. The seventh-century structure is the ledger being built.

That is the cleanest political reading:

the century before Aokigahara is not a century of disappearance; it is a century of inscription.

13. The word-world: no 青木ヶ原, no 樹海, probably not yet the literary Fuji of *Man' yōshū*

The eighth century has *Man' yōshū* Fuji: fire, snow, Seno-umi, divine awe. The ninth has Jōgan's eruption reports. The seventh does not give us a comparable surviving Fuji text that can be used directly for Aokigahara.

So the seventh-century word-world is mostly absent or archaeological rather than literary:

settlement; tomb; pre-Fuji-district formation; future Tōkaidō; pre-Aokigahara lake-world; mountain visible but not yet richly textualised.

That silence should not be padded. It is the evidence.

14. Why this century still matters

The seventh century matters because it is the last fully pre-recorded, pre-Aokigahara, pre-Asama-system Fuji world.

Eighth century: Fuji enters dated eruption record and *Man' yōshū* fire/snow/god poetry. Ninth century: Aokigahara is born through the Jōgan lava catastrophe. Twelfth century: ascetics begin

entering Fuji's summit-world. Thirteenth century: Hitoana gives the cave-underworld record. Twentieth century: Aokigahara becomes the suicide/disappearance forest.

Seventh century is before all of that. It is the baseline.

Its value is that it strips away the later accretions and shows Fuji's world as:

human settlement; elite burial; pre-ritsuryō development; lake-world before lava; mountain awe before explicit Asama state cult.

15. The deepest seventh-century thesis

The seventh century's deepest meaning is not death as disappearance, but death and land as social order.

The Fuji region is being settled, planned, buried, ranked, and eventually made administratively legible. The later Aokigahara site remains a pre-lava lake-margin, not a forest. Fuji is present as enormous natural dominance, but the surviving record has not yet turned it into the full literary/religious volcano of the eighth and ninth centuries.

So the exact answer is:

In the seventh century, Aokigahara is not yet born. The future death-forest is still a lake-world under Fuji. The human evidence around Fuji points to planned settlement and tomb culture, not disappearance. The later fantasy of leaving the social ledger is absent because the seventh-century Fuji-foot world is busy creating the ledger: villages, tombs, elites, roads, offices, and the first structures that will later let Fuji become a state-recognised sacred volcano.

In one line:

Seventh-century Aokigahara is not a forest of vanishing; it is the not-yet-forest beneath a mountain around which society is learning to organise itself.

8th Century

Eighth century only — 700—799 — gives a very precise answer:

Aokigahara does not yet exist. Not as forest, not as suicide-place, not as “樹海”, not even as the Saiko/Shōjiko landscape we now recognise. The eighth-century object is Fuji before Aokigahara: a burning/smoking god-mountain, with a large lake called Seno-umi / 石花海・剗の海 at its north foot, and with the first historically dated Fuji eruption recorded in 781.

So the eighth-century layer is not “death forest”. It is:

Fuji as fire-god; Seno-umi as the pre-Aokigahara lake; ashfall as first dated eruption; state religion beginning to frame the mountain through remote worship and pacification.

1. Hard boundary: in the eighth century, Aokigahara is not there

This has to be said first. The later Aokigahara lava field is created by the 864—866 Jōgan eruption, not in the eighth century. JMA’s eruption history says the Aokigahara lava flowed from the north-west flank in 864—66, reached Motosuko, divided “せのうみ” into Shōjiko and Saiko, buried homes and harmed lake fish. That is ninth century, not eighth. ([data.jma.go.jp](https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So from 700 to 799, there is no Aokigahara forest in the later sense. The land that will become Aokigahara is still part of the older north-foot lake/landscape system. The key pre-Aokigahara object is Seno-umi, the large lake later split by the 864 lava. Kokugakuin’s entry defines Seno-umi as a large lake thought to have existed at Fuji’s north foot and says *Sandai Jitsuroku* confirms that the 864 Aokigahara lava split it into modern Saiko and Shōjiko. ([jmapps.ne.jp](https://jmapps.ne.jp/kokugakuin/det.html?data_id=32072&utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is the most important eighth-century correction: Aokigahara’s later darkness begins from the destruction of a lake that, in the eighth century, still existed.

2. The strongest eighth-century cultural source is not a chronicle — it is *Man’ yōshū*

Before the 781 eruption record, the major eighth-century cultural witness is the *Man’ yōshū* poem on Fuji, attributed to Takahashi no Mushimaro’s song tradition. The Nara Prefectural Man’ yō Culture Centre gives the poem text: Fuji stands between Kai and Suruga; clouds hesitate before it; birds cannot fly over it; burning fire is quenched by snow and falling snow is quenched by fire; Fuji is a mysterious, awe-commanding god; and Seno-umi is described as the lake held or enclosed by the mountain. ([manyō-hyakka.pref.nara.jp](https://manyō-hyakka.pref.nara.jp/db/detailLink?cls=db_manyō&pkey=319&utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That poem is absolutely central. It proves that before Aokigahara existed, the north-foot lake already belonged to Fuji’s sacred imagination. The poem does not say “forest”. It says mountain, fire, snow, god, lake, river, national guardian.

So the eighth-century symbolic field is:

Fuji = divine/mysterious mountain. Fire and snow = impossible coexistence. Seno-umi = lake contained by Fuji. Fuji River = water force from Fuji. Japan/Yamato = protected or stabilised by Fuji.

Nothing in this register is suicide. It is cosmic geography.

3. The emotional grammar is fire/snow, not forest/darkness

The poem's most important image is the clash of fire and snow. The Nara Man'yō source translates the poem as saying that Fuji's summit fire is put out by snow, and falling snow is put out by fire. ([manyō-hyakka.pref.nara.jp] (https://manyō-hyakka.pref.nara.jp/db/detailLink?cls=db_manyo&pkey=319&utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That is the eighth-century deep structure. Fuji is not yet the quiet green background of a later forest. It is a contradiction:

fire under snow; snow over fire; beauty with threat; divinity with physical danger.

Modern Aokigahara later works through silence and absorption. Eighth-century Fuji works through visible contradiction. The mountain is terrifying because it openly contains opposites.

4. Seno-umi is the hidden prehistory of Aokigahara

The Seno-umi line is the most valuable for your larger project.

Kokugakuin's entry says Takahashi Mushimaro's Fuji poem praises Seno-umi as the lake "contained" or enclosed by Fuji. It also explains that this was the large lake at Fuji's north foot later divided by the 864 lava into Saiko and Shōjiko. ([jmapps.ne.jp] (https://jmapps.ne.jp/kokugakuin/det.html?data_id=32072&utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So the eighth-century Aokigahara site is not a forest but a lake-world.

That changes the whole long history. The later "sea of trees" replaces an earlier "sea/lake" that Fuji held. The transformation is almost too neat:

8th century: Seno-umi — water held by Fuji. 9th century: lava enters and breaks the lake.
Later: forest grows over the lava. Modernity: the forest becomes the "sea of trees".

So before the 樹海, there is literally the 海.

5. Takahashi Mushimaro: useful, but date cautiously

Takahashi no Mushimaro is an early Nara poet, with unclear birth/death dates. Kotobank says he was active in the early Tenpyō period, 729—749, and that much of his *Man'yōshū* material comes from the *Takahashi no Mushimaro Kashū*. ([kotobank.jp] (https://kotobank.jp/word/%E9%AB%98%E6%A9%8B%E8%99%AB%E9%BA%BB%E5%91%82-92717?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That means the Fuji poem belongs to the eighth-century cultural horizon, even if exact composition date and textual transmission are not clean in the way a dated government chronicle is.

The safe claim is: by the eighth-century Man'yō world, Fuji is already imagined as fire, snow, god and container of Seno-umi.

That is strong enough.

6. 781: the first historically dated Fuji eruption

The hard dated event is 781 / Ten'ō 1.

JMA lists 781 as Fuji's first historically recorded eruption, with ashfall in August.
([data.jma.go.jp](https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com)) Koyama's volcanological transcription gives the *Shoku Nihongi* entry more precisely: Suruga province reported on Ten'ō 1, seventh month, sixth day — 31 July 781 in Gregorian conversion — that ash fell below Fuji and, where the ash reached, tree leaves withered. Koyama notes that beyond this, the scale and detailed eruption style are unknown.
([sakuya.vulcania.jp](https://sakuya.vulcania.jp/koyama/public_html/Fuji/fujid/781.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That is the first dated Fuji eruption in the written record.

The source is small, but it is extremely important:

ash falls; leaves wither; Suruga reports to the court; Fuji becomes administratively visible as a volcanic hazard.

7. The 781 source is not dramatic, but that is exactly why it matters

The 781 record is not like the 864 Jōgan eruption. It does not give lava entering lakes, boiling water, dead fish, buried houses, or ritual orders. It gives a brief ashfall report.

But its restraint is useful. It shows the early state record catching Fuji not as mythic scenery but as environmental damage: ash reaches the foothills, and leaves wither.

([sakuya.vulcania.jp](https://sakuya.vulcania.jp/koyama/public_html/Fuji/fujid/781.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So the first historically dated Fuji eruption is not recorded through human death. It is recorded through vegetation injury.

That is a striking micro-point. The first written sign of Fuji's eruptive harm is ecological: leaves fail. The mountain's fire appears as ash on plants.

8. The eighth-century death-relation is not suicide. It is vegetal damage, divine danger, and volcanic fear

If we are asking about "death" in relation to the future Aokigahara field, the eighth century gives no suicide evidence. It gives:

withering leaves in 781; Fuji as burning god in *Man'yōshū*; the huge Seno-umi lake still intact before later destruction; emerging need to pacify Fuji's fire-god.

No body. No self-erasure. No disappearance. No "no return". No forest.

The eighth-century death relation is pre-human and ecological: fire, ash, snow, withering leaves, divine fear.

9. The state-religious frame begins in the late eighth century

Fujinomiya's official Fuji-faith page says that from the late eighth century, once Japan's ancient state system had largely developed, repeated eruptions were addressed by worshipping Fuji itself or the deity seated in Fuji as Asama Ōkami, and Asama shrines were built as remote-worship/pacification sites within state religious policy. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/101515000/p001611.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

The Yamanashi World Heritage Centre makes the same large-scale point: the oldest eruption records go back to the eighth century; at this stage Fuji faith took the form of 遙拝 — worship from the foot, looking up at the mountain — and people prayed to the fire deity Asama Ōkami for the calming of eruptions. ([fujisan-whc.jp](https://www.fujisan-whc.jp/about/feature.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That is the eighth-century religious frame. It is not pilgrimage into the mountain. It is remote worship.

People do not yet climb Fuji as a mass religious practice. They look up at the dangerous mountain and seek to calm it.

10. Directionality: in the eighth century, the movement is gaze upward, not entry inward

This is the cleanest conceptual distinction.

Modern Aokigahara:

road → forest edge → inward entry → disappearance.

Eighth-century Fuji:

foothill/world → gaze upward → fire/snow/god → appeasement.

The direction is opposite. The eighth-century person does not enter Aokigahara — it does not exist. The cultural act is to look up at Fuji, register its terrifying fire, and place it inside divine/state order.

So the eighth century gives remote vertical fear, not horizontal forest entry.

11. The word-world: 不尽 / 富士 / 石花海, not 青木ヶ原

The eighth-century word-world matters.

The *Man' yōshū* poem uses 不尽 / Fuji, 石花海 / Seno-umi, fire, snow, river, god. ([manyō-hyakka.pref.nara.jp](https://manyō-hyakka.pref.nara.jp/db/detailLink?cls=db_manyo&pkey=319&utm_source=chatgpt.com)) The named objects are mountain and lake, not forest.

The later word 青木ヶ原 belongs to the post-864 lava/forest world. The later word 樹海 is still much later as a modern landscape label. So if we ask what the eighth century “calls” the future Aokigahara space, the answer is: it does not. It calls the relevant lake Seno-umi.

That is the key lexical shift:

石花海 → lava rupture → 青木ヶ原 → 樹海.

The eighth century is the first term, not the last.

12. What the eighth century contributes to the later Aokigahara myth

It contributes four deep preconditions.

First, Fuji is already a divine fire mountain. The *Man' yōshū* poem explicitly calls Fuji a mysterious god and imagines fire and snow contending at the summit.

([manyō-hyakka.pref.nara.jp](https://manyō-hyakka.pref.nara.jp/db/detailLink?cls=db_manyo&pkey=319&utm_

source=chatgpt.com))

Second, the north-foot lake exists as a named poetic-sacred object. Seno-umi is already part of Fuji's world before the 864 destruction. ([jmaps.ne.jp](https://jmaps.ne.jp/kokugakuin/det.html?data_id=32072&utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Third, the state begins to record Fuji eruption as damage. The 781 record is ash and withered leaves. ([sakuya.vulcania.jp](https://sakuya.vulcania.jp/koyama/public_html/Fuji/fujid/781.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Fourth, Fuji worship is still remote/pacifying. The official faith histories place this stage under 遙^{はるか} and Asama eruption-pacification, not mountain entry. ([fujisan-whc.jp](https://www.fujisan-whc.jp/about/feature.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Those four preconditions later combine into Aokigahara's long history. But in the eighth century itself, the death-forest is not there.

13. The eighth-century “psychological” layer: awe before a god that can damage the world

The psychological relation is not private despair. It is collective awe/fear.

Fuji is described in *Man'yōshū* as beyond naming, awe-commanding, divine, impossible even for clouds and birds. ([manyō-hyakka.pref.nara.jp](https://manyō-hyakka.pref.nara.jp/db/detailLink?cls=db_manyō&pk_ey=319&utm_source=chatgpt.com)) Then in 781, that divine mountain is not merely poetic: ash actually falls and leaves wither. ([sakuya.vulcania.jp](https://sakuya.vulcania.jp/koyama/public_html/Fuji/fujid/781.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That produces the eighth-century psychological field:

the mountain is beautiful; the mountain is impossible; the mountain is god; the mountain burns; the mountain damages vegetation; humans respond by looking up and pacifying.

Again: not suicide. Cosmic vulnerability.

14. The crucial pre-Aokigahara inversion: later forest hides, eighth-century Fuji exposes

Modern Aokigahara is about concealment. The forest hides bodies, paths, intentions.

Eighth-century Fuji is about exposure. The mountain's inner fire becomes visible: flame, snow/fire paradox, ashfall, withered leaves. The hidden heat of Fuji is on display.

That is the long inversion:

8th century: hidden fire becomes visible ash and poetry. Modernity: visible people become hidden in forest.

Aokigahara's later force partly comes from reversing Fuji's original expressive structure.

15. What we cannot honestly say about the eighth century

We cannot say Aokigahara existed as forest.

We cannot say there was a suicide association.

We cannot say there was an ubasute tradition.

We cannot say there were no-return legends.

We cannot say the forest was used as a death-place.

We cannot say Saiko and Shōjiko existed yet as the two modern lakes; the sources say the larger Seno-umi was divided by the 864 lava later. ([data.jma.go.jp](https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

We cannot say the later “sea of trees” image had begun.

The evidence does not allow any of that.

16. The best eighth-century source hierarchy

The core packet is small but strong.

1. *Man’ yōshū* poem 3-319, attributed to Takahashi no Mushimaro tradition. Best evidence for eighth-century Fuji as fire/snow/god/lake/cosmic geography. It names Seno-umi and frames it as a lake held by Fuji. ([manyō-hyakka.pref.nara.jp](https://manyō-hyakka.pref.nara.jp/db/detailLink?cls=db_manyo&pkey=319&utm_source=chatgpt.com))

2. Kokugakuin Digital Museum entry on Seno-umi. Best concise explanation of Seno-umi as the pre-864 north-foot lake later split into Saiko and Shōjiko by Aokigahara lava. ([jmapps.ne.jp](https://jmapps.ne.jp/kokugakuin/det.html?data_id=32072&utm_source=chatgpt.com))

3. *Shoku Nihongi* 781 eruption entry, via Koyama. Best hard dated event: Suruga reports ashfall under Fuji; where ash reaches, leaves wither; eruption scale unknown. ([sakuya.vulcania.jp](https://sakuya.vulcania.jp/koyama/public_html/Fuji/fujid/781.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

4. JMA Fuji eruption chronology. Best official volcanic chronology: 781 ashfall, then later 800—02 and 864—66; confirms Aokigahara lava belongs to ninth century, not eighth. ([data.jma.go.jp](https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

5. Fujinomiya / Yamanashi World Heritage faith histories. Best religious frame: from late eighth century, Fuji/Asama worship is part of pacifying repeated eruptions through remote worship, before later ascent practices. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001611.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Final eighth-century thesis

In the eighth century, Aokigahara is not yet the forest. It is not a suicide site, not a death destination, not a place of disappearance. The land that will become Aokigahara is still pre-Aokigahara: the north-western Fuji foot, centred on the large lake Seno-umi.

The eighth-century record gives two crucial things. First, the *Man’ yōshū* gives Fuji as an awe-commanding god where fire and snow contend, and Seno-umi as a lake held by the mountain. Second, *Shoku Nihongi* gives 781 as the first dated eruption report: ash falls, leaves wither, and Fuji becomes a state-recorded volcanic threat.

So the exact answer is:

The eighth-century root of Aokigahara is not forest, suicide or disappearance. It is Fuji as divine fire above an intact lake-world. The later sea of trees does not exist yet; what exists is Seno-umi, Fuji's burning summit, ash that withers leaves, and the beginnings of state-managed Asama pacification.

In one line:

Before Aokigahara was a forest that swallowed people, it was a lake-world under a god-mountain that burned.

9th Century

Ninth century only — 800—899 — is the first truly decisive century.

The answer is not “Aokigahara as suicide forest”. It is more fundamental:

In the ninth century, Aokigahara is born. Before 864, the later forest does not yet exist as the landscape we mean by Aokigahara. There is Fuji’s north-western foot, Motosu, the larger lake called Seno-umi / 鵜の海, and a volcano already known to erupt. Between 864 and 866, Fuji’s north-west flank opens, lava enters the lake-world, divides Seno-umi into Saiko and Shōjiko, damages settlements and fish, and creates the Aokigahara lava field. Only after that can the forest begin.

So the ninth-century root is not disappearance. It is catastrophic creation.

1. 800—802: the century opens with Fuji already dangerous

The ninth century does not begin with Aokigahara. It begins with Fuji as an active state-level volcanic problem.

The Enryaku eruption of 800—802 is the prelude. Fuji City summarises the old record: according to *Nihon Kiryaku*, Fuji erupted from 14 March to 18 April 800, with another eruption record on 8 January 802; the Ashigara route was temporarily closed and the Hakone route was used instead for a year. ([city.fuji.shizuoka.jp] (https://www.city.fuji.shizuoka.jp/1004050000/p000050.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com)) JMA gives the technical volcanic summary: 800 eruption, heavy ashfall, scoria fall, lava flow, north-east flank vent; renewed activity in 801, with heavy ash/sand/gravel, Ashigara road burial, and opening of the Hakone road in 802. ([data.jma.go.jp] (https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That matters because before Aokigahara exists, Fuji is already doing three things that will matter later:

It is physically destructive. It is administratively disruptive: roads are closed and rerouted. It is legible to the state: eruption is recorded, interpreted, and acted on.

So the ninth-century pre-Aokigahara world is not quiet nature. It is already a volcano-state problem.

2. 800—802 also shows the first key contrast: road interruption, not forest disappearance

The Enryaku eruption affects routes. Ashigara is closed; Hakone is substituted. ([city.fuji.shizuoka.jp] (https://www.city.fuji.shizuoka.jp/1004050000/p000050.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That is conceptually important. The later Aokigahara myth is about leaving the road and vanishing. The early ninth-century eruption record is about the opposite: the state trying to preserve movement after Fuji blocks a route.

So the century opens with:

Fuji interrupts passage; the state re-routes passage.

Not suicide. Not self-erasure. Movement, road, ash, administrative repair.

3. 826/827: possible eruption, but too weak to build on

JMA lists an eruption in 826 or 827, but marks it uncertain and gives no useful detail.

([data.jma.go.jp](https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This belongs in the chronology, but it cannot carry interpretive weight. The disciplined use is simple:

Between Enryaku and Jōgan, the official volcanic chronology preserves at least a weak signal of possible continued Fuji activity. But we cannot reconstruct landscape, affect, or Aokigahara meaning from it.

The real break comes in 864.

4. Before 864: Aokigahara as we mean it does not yet exist

This is the central point.

Before the Jōgan eruption, the later Aokigahara lava field was not there. The major geographical object was the older lake Seno-umi / 剱の海, lying north-east of Motosu. Shizuoka University's disaster archive says modern distribution surveys of the Aokigahara lava show that this now-vanished lake was split by the 864 lava into modern Shōjiko and Saiko.

([cnh.shizuoka.ac.jp](https://www.cnh.shizuoka.ac.jp/research/barchive/mtfuji/023-2/?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So, for 800—863, the correct object is not “Aokigahara forest”. It is:

Fuji's north-west foot; Motosu lake; Seno-umi lake; the pre-Aokigahara land surface; older settlements and lake ecology; a volcano with recent major eruption history.

That is why any claim about an “ancient Aokigahara death tradition” in the early ninth century collapses. The specific terrain later called Aokigahara is not yet born.

5. June/July 864: first report — fire, thunder, earthquake, stone-rain, lava into Motosu

The first strong record is in Nihon Sandai Jitsuroku.

Koyama Masato's volcanological page quotes the entry. On Jōgan 6, fifth month, twenty-fifth day — 2 July 864 in the Gregorian conversion — Suruga province reports that Fuji's Asama deity mountain is burning fiercely. The record describes a violently active eruption: high flames, sounds like thunder, repeated earthquakes, burning for over ten days, collapsing/falling rock, sand and stones raining down, smoke/clouds thick enough that people could not approach, and lava flowing into Motosu.

([sakuya.vulcania.jp](https://sakuya.vulcania.jp/koyama/public_html/Fuji/fujid/864.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is the ninth-century primal scene.

The later forest of silence begins as a world of:

fire; noise; earthquake; ash/stone fall; smoke; approach made impossible; lava entering water.

There is nothing quiet or absorptive here yet. Aokigahara's future silence is born out of noise.

6. The first report already gives the core direction: north-west

JMA says the 864 eruption occurred on Fuji's north-west flank, around Nagao-yama, and that the lava flowing north-west reached Motosu, while the Aokigahara lava divided Seno-umi into Shōji and Saiko. ([data.jma.go.jp](https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That is the exact geographic hinge. The ninth-century catastrophe is not generic Fuji eruption. It is the eruption that makes the north-western lake/forest world.

So if later Aokigahara feels uniquely charged, its hard origin is not vague sacredness. It is a precise flank eruption that re-engineered the lakes.

7. August 864: second report — lava enters Motosu and Seno-umi, water boils, fish die, homes are buried

The second report is even more important. Koyama quotes the Jōgan 6, seventh month, seventeenth day entry — 22 August 864 — from Kai province. It says violent fire suddenly came from Fuji; hills and ridges burned; grasses and trees were scorched; earth and stones flowed; lava buried Motosu and 剱の海 / Seno-umi; the water became hot like boiling water; fish died; homes and the lake were buried; some houses had no people, and the number was hard to record. It also says that before the lake burial, there was great earthquake, thunder, violent rain, dark cloud/fog, and mountain and field became hard to distinguish. ([sakuya.vulcania.jp](https://sakuya.vulcania.jp/koyama/public_html/Fuji/fujid/864.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That is the deepest ninth-century passage.

It gives the exact birth-trauma of Aokigahara:

water heated like a pot; fish killed; houses buried; lake swallowed; people missing or uncountable; mountain/field distinction erased by cloud/fog; fire crossing provincial boundaries.

This is not “death forest”. It is world-erasure by lava.

8. “Mountain and field became hard to distinguish” is the first true Aokigahara sentence

The most important phrase is not “lava”. It is the description that cloud/fog/darkness made it hard to distinguish 山野 — mountain and field.

That is astonishingly relevant to the later forest.

Later Aokigahara becomes famous as a place where ordinary distinctions fail: path/non-path, forest/rock, living/dead, found/unfound, exit/no exit.

But in 864, the first collapse of distinction is meteorological and volcanic: smoke, rain, cloud, darkness, earthquake. The world becomes unreadable because Fuji is erupting.

So the very first “Aokigahara” grammar is:

landscape legibility collapses.

Not psychologically, not symbolically yet — physically.

9. The ninth-century death relation: fish, homes, households, not suicide

The 864 report contains death, but not suicide.

The dead or harmed entities are:

fish in heated lakes; homes buried by lava; possibly people absent/unrecordable; settlements damaged; landscape distinction destroyed.

JMA also summarises that the 864–866 lava buried homes and caused lake-fish damage.

([data.jma.go.jp](https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So the ninth-century death relation is ecological and domestic. Water life dies. Homes disappear. The lake-world is split. Human habitation is damaged or buried.

This is the opposite of the modern Aokigahara script. Later, people go into the forest to vanish. In 864, the landscape comes for the people and their homes.

10. August/September 864: the court interprets the eruption ritually

The eruption is not treated only as geology. The court reads it as a problem of divine appeasement.

Koyama quotes the Jōgan 6, eighth month, fifth day entry — 9 September 864 — in which the court orders Kai province to worship and pacify Asama Myōjin, because the disaster is understood as connected with insufficient reverence or ritual attention.

([sakuya.vulcania.jp](https://sakuya.vulcania.jp/koyama/public_html/Fuji/fujid/864.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is the religious hinge.

Fuji's eruption is not just material destruction. It requires ritual correction. The volcano is a divine agent whose anger, neglect or insufficient worship must be addressed.

So the ninth-century meaning is:

catastrophe → report to court → ritual diagnosis → shrine/pacification response.

That is the base layer of Fuji religion around Aokigahara's birth.

11. 865: Kawaguchi Asama Shrine — the north-foot ritual answer

Kawaguchi Asama Shrine's official history says that after the 864 eruption, the following year, 865, an imperial order commanded that Asama Myōjin be officially enshrined in this place to pacify Fuji's eruption; it names Tomo no Atai Masatada and Tomo no Akiyoshi as ritual functionaries.

([asamajinja.or.jp](https://asamajinja.or.jp/about?utm_source=chatgpt.com)) The shrine's main site also states that its origin is in 865, when it was founded by imperial command to quiet Fuji's eruption. ([asamajinja.or.jp](https://asamajinja.or.jp/?utm_source=chatgpt.com)) Fuji-san Net summarises the same tradition: Kawaguchi Asama Shrine is said to have been established in 865 to calm the Jōgan eruption and is the first Asama shrine on the Yamanashi side. ([fujisan-net.jp](https://www.fujisan-net.jp/post_detail/2001618?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is a major finding. The first strong human-cultural response to Aokigahara's creation is not pilgrimage, not poetry, not suicide, not tourism. It is state-backed ritual pacification on the north foot.

The future “forest of disappearance” begins with an official attempt to stop the mountain burning.

12. 865/866: the eruption still has not simply stopped

Koyama’s reading of the later *Nihon Sandai Jitsuroku* entries is important. On Jōgan 7, twelfth month, ninth day — 30 December 865 — an order is issued to establish an Asama shrine in Kai’s Yatsushiro district and set up ritual observance; the text says the “strange fire” had not yet stopped. Eleven days later, on Jōgan 7, twelfth month, twentieth day — 10 January 866 — Kai is ordered to hold Asama Myōjin rites in Yamanashi district as well.

([sakuya.vulcania.jp](https://sakuya.vulcania.jp/koyama/public_html/Fuji/fujid/864.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So the Jōgan eruption is not a single moment. It has an administrative and ritual afterlife extending into late 865 / early 866.

Aokigahara’s birth is therefore stretched:

initial violent eruption; lava entering lakes; reports from Suruga and Kai; court ritual orders; new shrine/ritual institutions; continued “strange fire”.

The forest begins not after “an event”, but after a sustained crisis.

13. The lake transformation: Seno-umi becomes Saiko and Shōjiko

This is the geographic heart.

JMA says the 864 lava divided Seno-umi into Shōjiko and Saiko.

([data.jma.go.jp](https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com)) Shizuoka University’s disaster archive says the only reliable written report is *Nihon Sandai Jitsuroku*, and that distributional studies of the Aokigahara lava confirm the old Seno-umi lake existed north-east of Motosu and was split into the two modern lakes by the lava.

([cnh.shizuoka.ac.jp](https://www.cnh.shizuoka.ac.jp/research/barchive/mtfuji/023-2/?utm_source=chatgpt.com)) Fuji City gives the same summary: lava from Fuji’s north-west slope flowed into the large old lake Seno-umi, dividing it into Saiko and Shōjiko, while the broad lava spread became the Aokigahara lava on which today’s forest lies. ([city.fuji.shizuoka.jp](https://www.city.fuji.shizuoka.jp/10040500/p000050.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is the most important physical fact in the whole history.

Aokigahara is not beside death. It is beside a broken lake.

The later forest’s emotional power depends on that hidden fact: the ground is a hardened interruption in a former water-world.

14. “Fire buries water”: the ninth-century image before the tenth-century formula

The exact phrase “divine fire buries water” belongs to the 937 tenth-century record, not the ninth. But the event pattern begins in 864.

In 864, lava enters Motosu and Seno-umi; water becomes hot like boiling water; fish die; lake and homes are buried. ([sakuya.vulcania.jp](https://sakuya.vulcania.jp/koyama/public_html/Fuji/fujid/864.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So the ninth-century physical image is:

fire enters water and makes land.

That is the first deep Aokigahara image.

Not trees. Not bodies. Fire into water. Lava into lake. Death of fish. Burial of homes. Then, later, forest.

15. The first Aokigahara is not green; it is black/red/white/grey

Modern Aokigahara is green: moss, trees, roots, shade.

The ninth-century Aokigahara is not green. It begins as:

red/orange lava; black cooling rock; grey ash/sand/stone; white steam from heated lake water; dark volcanic cloud; burned grasses and trees; possibly exposed lava tubes and collapsed surfaces.

That reconstruction follows from the *Nihon Sandai Jitsuroku* descriptions of fire, burned vegetation, stone/sand fall, smoke/clouds, lava entering lakes, and water heated like boiling water. ([sakuya.vulcania.jp](https://sakuya.vulcania.jp/koyama/public_html/Fuji/fujid/864.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So the emotional register of the ninth century is not woodland melancholy. It is thermal violence.

16. Ecological succession: the forest begins after devastation

Modern sources describe today's Aokigahara as forest on the 864 lava, with thin soil and roots running over rock. ([asamajinja.or.jp](https://asamajinja.or.jp/about?utm_source=chatgpt.com)) The ninth-century implication is straightforward but must be stated carefully: immediately after the lava flow, there is no mature forest. There is new lava, ash, killed vegetation, isolated surviving patches, and then gradual colonisation.

So the first "Aokigahara" after 864 is likely a patchwork:

fresh lava surfaces; kipuka-like spared islands of older vegetation; early colonising mosses/lichens; burned trunks and dead stands; new drainage/lake edges; cooling cracks and cavities; eventual seedling growth.

This is inference from geology and ecology, not a directly quoted ninth-century description. But it is the necessary material reconstruction.

17. The forest is born as an administrative problem before it becomes a cultural symbol

This is one of the deepest points.

The ninth-century record is bureaucratic-religious. Provinces report. The court orders. Ritual posts are established. Shrines are founded. Deity appeasement is required.

([sakuya.vulcania.jp](https://sakuya.vulcania.jp/koyama/public_html/Fuji/fujid/864.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Aokigahara is not born first as folklore. It is born first as:

provincial report; court knowledge; ritual failure diagnosis; state cult expansion; Asama appeasement.

This means the earliest human meaning of Aokigahara's creation is not "mysterious forest". It is governance under volcanic terror.

18. What "death" means in the ninth century

The ninth-century death relation is precise:

death as disaster, not self-destruction; death as lake ecology, fish boiled/killed; death as buried habitation, homes under lava; death as divine anger, requiring ritual pacification; death as landscape transformation, old Seno-umi broken.

It is not:

suicide; romantic disappearance; ubasute; corpse forest; Tsurumi-style manualised death; Matsumoto's quiet final page.

Those are much later accretions.

The ninth-century death is involuntary, collective, ecological and theological.

19. The first human psychology is fear of the god, not desire to vanish

The later Aokigahara psychology is "消えてしまいたい" — wanting to disappear.

The ninth-century psychology is different:

the mountain is angry / neglected / insufficiently worshipped; the god must be pacified; human beings must repair the ritual relation.

Kawaguchi Asama Shrine's history says the 864 disaster was reported by the Kai governor and that, in 865, an imperial command ordered Asama Myōjin officially enshrined in this place to calm the eruption. ([asamajinja.or.jp](https://asamajinja.or.jp/about?utm_source=chatgpt.com)) Yamanashi Shrine Agency's entry explicitly says "Sandai Jitsuroku" records the details of the eruption and the circumstances of enshrining Asama Ōkami, and frames the disaster through the need for proper public ritual. ([yamanashi-jinjacho.or.jp](https://www.yamanashi-jinjacho.or.jp/intro/search/detail/7137?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So the ninth-century affect is not private despair. It is collective fear before divine volcanic force.

20. Aokigahara's later "no return" meaning is not present — but the first unreadability is present

No suicide meaning yet. But one precursor is present: the landscape becomes unreadable.

The 864 Kai report says cloud/fog/darkness became so severe that mountain and field were hard to distinguish. ([sakuya.vulcania.jp](https://sakuya.vulcania.jp/koyama/public_html/Fuji/fujid/864.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is the first form of "lostness" in the Aokigahara story. Not a person lost in trees, but the world itself visually lost under eruption conditions.

Later, Aokigahara becomes a place where the person disappears into landscape. In 864, the landscape disappears under smoke and cloud.

That is not direct continuity, but it is the earliest structural echo.

21. The century's biggest inversion: Aokigahara later hides bodies; in the ninth century it exposes Fuji's body

Modern Aokigahara is imagined as concealment: the body vanishes under trees.

Ninth-century Aokigahara begins as exposure: Fuji's interior comes out as lava. The mountain's hidden fire becomes surface.

That is the cleanest conceptual contrast.

The future forest of invisibility is born from an eruption of absolute visibility.

22. The source hierarchy for the ninth century

For 800—899, the source hierarchy is unusually clear.

1. *Nihon Sandai Jitsuroku* entries for 864—866, via Koyama's volcanological transcription and analysis. This is the core. It gives the two provincial reports, the sensory description, lava entering Motosu and Seno-umi, boiling water, fish death, buried houses, ritual orders, and continued strange fire. ([sakuya.vulcania.jp](https://sakuya.vulcania.jp/koyama/public_html/Fuji/fujid/864.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))
2. JMA historical eruption chronology. Best official modern summary of 800—802, 826/827, and 864—866, including vent locations, deposits, lava flows, damage, and lake division. ([data.jma.go.jp](https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))
3. Shizuoka University disaster archive on Aokigahara lava and Seno-umi. Best concise geological-historical explanation that *Nihon Sandai Jitsuroku* is the only reliable written report for the Jōgan eruption, and that geological surveys confirm the old Seno-umi split. ([cnh.shizuoka.ac.jp](https://www.cnh.shizuoka.ac.jp/research/barchive/mtfuji/023-2/?utm_source=chatgpt.com))
4. Fuji City eruption-history page. Useful official synthesis connecting 800—802, 864—866, lake division, and Aokigahara lava. ([city.fuji.shizuoka.jp](https://www.city.fuji.shizuoka.jp/1004050000/p00050.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))
5. Kawaguchi Asama Shrine official history / Yamanashi Shrine Agency. Best ritual-institutional source for the 865 north-foot shrine response to the eruption. ([asamajinja.or.jp](https://asamajinja.or.jp/about?utm_source=chatgpt.com))
6. MLIT Fuji Sabo page on Jōgan eruption. Useful visual/geological summary: the Aokigahara lava lies beneath the forest and is visible around Saiko, Shōjiko and Motosuko. ([cbr.mlit.go.jp](https://www.cbr.mlit.go.jp/fujisabo/bosai/fuji_info/chisiki/a05/index.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Final ninth-century thesis

In the ninth century, Aokigahara is not a suicide forest. It is not a mysterious old woodland. It is not yet the “sea of trees”. It is born in 864—866 as a lava catastrophe.

Before 864, the later Aokigahara landscape does not exist in the form we mean. There is Motosu, Seno-umi, Fuji's north-west foot, and a volcano already known to disrupt roads and provinces. Then the Jōgan eruption opens on Fuji's north-west flank. Lava enters Motosu and Seno-umi, boils the

water, kills fish, buries homes, divides the old lake into Saiko and Shōjiko, and creates the Aokigahara lava field. The court responds not with tourism, literature or folklore, but with ritual pacification: Asama Myōjin must be worshipped on the Kai side, and Kawaguchi Asama Shrine's origin is tied to that 865 command.

The exact ninth-century answer is:

Aokigahara begins as a divine-fire scar: a new land made by lava entering water, killing lake life, burying settlement, confusing mountain and field, and forcing the state to ritualise Fuji's anger.

Its later death-imaginary is a secular inversion of that origin. Modern Aokigahara hides death in green silence. Ninth-century Aokigahara is born from red fire, boiling water, dead fish, buried homes and public terror before a god-mountain.

10th Century

Tenth century only — 900—999 — gives the first century where the Aokigahara/Fuji problem becomes genuinely strange.

The answer is not “suicide forest”. It is not even “pilgrimage forest”. The tenth century is the century in which Aokigahara is a very young post-catastrophe forest under an actively smoking, sometimes erupting Fuji, while court literature is already turning Fuji’s smoke into an emotional-symbolic image.

So the deep tenth-century structure is:

fresh lava scar below; smoking sacred volcano above; poetry converting volcanic smoke into longing; records converting eruption into omen; forest not yet culturally named as death-place.

That is the century. Not disappearance yet. Smoke. Fire. Omen. Regrowth.

1. The first hard boundary: in 900, Aokigahara is only about 36 years old

Aokigahara was created by the 864—866 Jōgan eruption. JMA records the eruption as beginning in 864, with lava from around Nagao-yama flowing across Fuji’s north-west flank, reaching Motosuko, splitting the older lake Seno-umi into Shōjiko and Saiko, burying homes and damaging fish in the lakes. JMA explicitly identifies this lava as the Aokigahara lava flow.

([\[data.jma.go.jp\]](https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com) (https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So in tenth-century terms:

900: the Aokigahara lava is roughly 36 years old. 937: roughly 73 years old. 999: roughly 135 years old.

That is crucial. The modern phrase “primeval forest” is completely wrong if projected backwards. In the tenth century, this is not an ancient forest. It is a young ecological cover forming on fresh volcanic ruin.

The Shizuoka University disaster archive says the written record of the Jōgan eruption in *Nihon Sandai Jitsuroku* is the only reliable textual report for that eruption, and explains that Aokigahara lava entered the old Seno-umi lake, splitting it into modern Shōji and Saiko.

([\[cnh.shizuoka.ac.jp\]](https://www.cnh.shizuoka.ac.jp/research/barchive/mtfuji/023-2/?utm_source=chatgpt.com) (https://www.cnh.shizuoka.ac.jp/research/barchive/mtfuji/023-2/?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So the tenth-century Aokigahara is best understood as afterland: recently destroyed lake-edge terrain becoming forest.

2. The forest’s tenth-century identity is geological, not cultural

There is no reliable tenth-century source I found that treats Aokigahara as a suicide place, a corpse place, an ubasute site, or even as the later “樹海” symbolic object.

That absence matters.

The thing that exists in the tenth century is:

lava; new forest succession; changed lakes; rough black basalt; caves/tubes; thin soil; a scarred north-west foot of Fuji.

Modern Yamanashi material describes today's forest as growing on the 864 lava, with very thin soil and tree roots spreading across lava rather than deep into earth. That modern ecology lets us infer the tenth-century starting point, but cautiously: in the tenth century the vegetation would have been much younger, patchier, and closer to raw lava than today.

([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001611.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So the tenth-century forest is not yet “the place one vanishes”. It is the place where Fuji's violence has started growing skin.

3. The tenth-century cultural protagonist is not Aokigahara. It is Fuji's smoke.

The strongest tenth-century evidence is literary and volcanic, and it centres on smoke.

A Fuji lava research chart lists 889—905 as a period of “噴煙休止” — smoke/steam interruption or cessation — with *Nihon Sandai Jitsuroku* and *Kokinshū* as references; then 918—926 as renewed smoke, with *Yamato Monogatari* as the source; 951 around *Gosen Wakashū* as smoke/possible eruption; and 969 around *Ise-shū* / family poetry as smoke. ([fujisan-yogan-kenkyu.jo.or.jp](https://www.fujisan-yogan-kenkyu.jo.or.jp/asset/1-5.pdf?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

The details matter less than the pattern: in tenth-century literary consciousness, Fuji's summit smoke is a stable cultural sign. It appears, disappears, returns, and is noticed.

That means Fuji is not yet primarily a climbable mountain or scenic postcard. It is a smoking being.

4. *Kokinshū* makes Fuji-smoke into an emotional metaphor

This is one of the most important tenth-century shifts.

Kotobank's entry for 富士の煙 says the phrase means the smoke issuing from Fuji, and that it was used as a comparison for a love-feeling that never disappears. It gives the earliest example as the *Kokin Wakashū* kana preface, dated 905—914: “ふじのけぶりによそへて人をこひ” — loving someone by comparison with Fuji's smoke. ([kotobank.jp](https://kotobank.jp/word/%E5%AF%8C%E5%A3%AB%E3%81%AE%E7%85%99-2079670?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Another Kotobank entry on 富士の嶺の says that because Fuji was understood as burning and smoking, the phrase became a pillow-word or prefatory image linked with “燃ゆ” — burning. It gives *Kokinshū* examples where Fuji's burning is used for love and unbearable longing. ([kotobank.jp](https://kotobank.jp/word/%E5%AF%8C%E5%A3%AB%E3%81%AE%E5%B6%BA%E3%81%AE-618093?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That is a serious cultural transformation. The volcano's physical smoke becomes an emotional technology.

In the tenth century, Fuji's smoke means:

unending fire; love; longing; unextinguished interior feeling; visible sign of hidden heat.

This is not Aokigahara suicide. But it is the first major poetic conversion of Fuji's volcanic body into human psychology.

5. This is the earliest deep psychological layer: not disappearance, but burning inside

The modern Aokigahara psychology is: I want to disappear.

The tenth-century Fuji psychology is: I burn inwardly, and Fuji's smoke gives that inward burning an image.

That is a completely different structure.

Modern Aokigahara is cold, mute, absorptive, downward/inward, concealment-based.

Tenth-century Fuji is hot, visible, rising, smoke-based, emotionally expressive.

So the tenth-century register is not erasure. It is combustion made visible.

This matters because the later forest is built under a mountain already culturally trained to express invisible feeling through visible natural phenomena.

6. *Takatori Monogatari*: immortality, refusal, and smoke to heaven

There is one source that has to be handled carefully: *Takatori Monogatari*.

Tokyo University's page describes *Takatori Monogatari* as an early Heian tale and explains its ending: after Kaguya-hime ascends to the moon, the emperor orders her letter and the elixir of immortality to be burned on Fuji's summit. ([1.u-tokyo.ac.jp](https://www.1.u-tokyo.ac.jp/takara/takara8.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Shinshu University quotes the famous final explanation: the emperor sends the letter and immortality medicine to the mountain in Suruga closest to heaven, orders them burned at the summit, and the smoke is said still to rise into the clouds. ([shinshu-u.ac.jp](https://www.shinshu-u.ac.jp/institution/library/matsumoto/find/tenjikotani2-01.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Date caution: *Takatori* is not pinned neatly to a single year inside 900—999. It is early Heian, plausibly overlapping the ninth/tenth-century border. So I would not use it as a clean tenth-century witness in the way *Kokinshū* is. But conceptually it belongs right on this horizon.

Why it matters: Fuji smoke becomes linked not only to love, but to immortality refused.

The emperor does not drink the medicine. He burns it. Fuji becomes the place where a human ruler rejects endless life because love/loss has made immortality unbearable.

That is an astonishingly early death/immortality layer. Not suicide. Not forest. But Fuji as the place where immortality is destroyed and smoke rises to heaven.

7. 918—926: *Yamato Monogatari* and the persistence of smoke

The Fuji lava research chronology lists 918—926 as a period of Fuji smoke, with *Yamato Monogatari* as the source. ([fujisan-yogan-kenkyujo.or.jp](https://www.fujisan-yogan-kenkyujo.or.jp/asset/1-5.pdf?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

The cautious point is this: tenth-century prose/literary tradition continues to treat Fuji's smoke as visible and meaningful. This is not a technical eruption record like JMA; it is a literary-cultural witness that Fuji's smoking remained part of the imaginative environment.

So by the early tenth century, Fuji has two simultaneous identities:

a real volcano; a literary furnace for human feeling.

Aokigahara is still only the young lava forest below.

8. 932: possible shrine-burning layer — useful but weak

The lava research chronology lists 932 / Shōhei 2 as a possible eruption, with Ōmiya Sengen Shrine burning as the note. ([fujisan-yogan-kenkyujo.or.jp](https://www.fujisan-yogan-kenkyujo.or.jp/asset/1-5.pdf?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is important but not solid enough to overbuild. It suggests that in the tenth-century record, Fuji's activity may have been associated with damage to sacred/institutional sites, but this is not as hard a source as the 937 or 999 entries.

Use it as a weak signal:

possible eruption/fire affecting shrine memory; not enough to define the century by itself.

9. 937: the most important tenth-century eruption record

The hard tenth-century volcanic centre is 937 / Shōhei 7.

JMA lists 937 as an eruption from Fuji's north flank, with scoria fall and lava flow. ([data.jma.go.jp](https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Koyama's volcanological source gives the older textual substance. *Nihon Kiryaku* says that in November 937, Kai Province reported: “駿河国富士山神火埋水海” — divine fire from Fuji buried a water/sea/lake. A similar note in *Kōfukuji Nendaiki* says Fuji “greatly buried the sea/lake”. Koyama interprets “divine fire burying water” as likely lava flowing into a lake or water body. ([sakuya.vulcania.jp](https://sakuya.vulcania.jp/koyama/public_html/Fuji/fujid/937.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is the tenth-century sentence that matters most.

“神火埋水海” is not modern scientific description. It is a cosmological description: divine fire burying water.

That phrase captures the whole century:

fire versus water; mountain versus lake; deity versus landscape; eruption as supernatural agency.

Aokigahara itself was created by the earlier 864 lava/lake event. Then, within living historical distance, a tenth-century record again describes Fuji's divine fire burying water.

So the tenth century is not “the forest where people disappear”. It is the mountain whose divine fire buries worlds of water.

10. Why 937 matters for Aokigahara specifically

The 937 eruption was not the Jōgan Aokigahara-forming eruption. We should not confuse them.

But it matters because it proves the north-side/lake-side volcanic grammar remained alive in the tenth century. Fuji had already destroyed/reorganised Seno-umi in 864. Then the 937 report again frames

Fuji's fire as entering/burying water.

This means the Aokigahara/Saiko/Shōji world in the tenth century was not sitting beneath an extinct myth. It was living under a mountain that had recently made the forest and could still produce new divine-fire events.

That gives Aokigahara's tenth-century atmosphere:

young forest below; active volcano above; lake-world twice traumatised or threatened in living cultural memory.

11. 951: smoke or possible eruption in *Gosen Wakashū*

The Fuji lava research chronology places a 951-ish smoke/possible eruption entry in relation to *Gosen Wakashū*. ([fujisan-yogan-kenkyujo.or.jp] (https://www.fujisan-yogan-kenkyujo.or.jp/asset/1-5.pdf?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

MLIT's Fuji Sabo page quotes a later *Gosen Wakashū* poem: “富士のねをよそにぞ聞きし今は我が 思いにもゆる煙なりけり” — roughly, I had only heard of Fuji's peak from afar; now its smoke burns as my own feeling. ([cbr.mlit.go.jp] (https://www.cbr.mlit.go.jp/fujisabo/bosai/fuji_info/chisiki/d02/index.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Again, this is not a suicide source. It is evidence of the Fuji-smoke metaphor continuing after *Kokinshū*. The tenth century is building an emotional semiotics around volcanic smoke.

Smoke is not only observed; it is internalised.

12. 969: smoke in *Ise-shū* / family poetry

The same lava research chart places 969-ish smoke evidence in *Ise-shū* and family poetry. ([fujisan-yogan-kenkyujo.or.jp] (https://www.fujisan-yogan-kenkyujo.or.jp/asset/1-5.pdf?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

I would not make this carry too much weight alone. But as part of the pattern, it matters: across the tenth century, Fuji smoke persists in both observational and poetic registers.

So the century has a repeated rhythm:

smoke as volcanic trace; smoke as love metaphor; smoke as active-mountain sign; smoke as something court culture knows how to read.

This is the first fully developed Fuji affect-language.

13. 993: possible eruption, but details unclear

JMA lists 993 / Shōryaku 4 as a possible eruption, with details unclear. ([data.jma.go.jp] (https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This should be used sparingly. It contributes to the pattern of tenth-century unrest, but it does not provide a strong narrative. The correct claim is:

By the late tenth century, the official volcanic chronology still registers possible Fuji activity, but the 993 entry cannot bear detailed interpretation.

14. 999: eruption as omen of war and disease

The century closes with 999 / Chōhō 1.

JMA lists 999 as an eruption on 26 March, with details unclear.

([data.jma.go.jp](https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Koyama's page gives the key historical texture. *Honchō Seiki*, compiled later from older materials, records that news reached Kyoto on 26 March 999 that Fuji — written as “不字御山” in the cited text — had burned. The account gives no scale or detailed physical description, but says divination was performed because the event was feared as a possible sign of 兵革疾疫 — war and epidemic disease. Koyama warns that the degree of social reaction to natural anomalies cannot be read straightforwardly as eruption size, because omen-thinking and historical circumstances shape reaction. ([sakuya.vulcania.jp](https://sakuya.vulcania.jp/koyama/public_html/Fuji/fujid/999.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is profound.

By 999, Fuji's eruption is not just a local geological event. It is read politically and cosmologically. It may signify war. It may signify disease. The mountain's fire is a message in the order of the realm.

So the tenth century closes not with Aokigahara as suicide place, but with Fuji as omen machine.

15. Tenth-century religion: appeasement, not pilgrimage

The official religious-history sources are very clear about the broad sequence.

Fujinomiya says ancient Japanese people regarded repeatedly erupting Fuji as terrifying and mysterious, worshipping it from afar; after the ancient state developed, Sengen shrines were built as remote worship places to pacify eruptions. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001611.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Shizuoka's official page gives the same structure: people feared Fuji as the dwelling-place of a god and built Sengen shrines at the foot to calm eruptions; only after eruption activity subsided in the late Heian period did Fuji become a Shugendō training mountain. ([pref.shizuoka.jp](https://www.pref.shizuoka.jp/kankosports/kanko/mtfuj/1002802/1020133.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

The Yamanashi World Heritage Center condenses the whole shift: in the era of repeated eruption disasters, Fuji faith took the form of 遙拜 — worship from below/from afar — and people prayed to the fire deity Asama Ōkami for quiescence; when eruptions later calmed, religious practitioners began 登拜 — climbing worship. ([fujisan-whc.jp](https://www.fujisan-whc.jp/about/feature.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

The tenth century belongs mostly to the 遙拜 / pacification side. It is not yet the full ascent/pilgrimage century. It is not yet Hitoana-underworld narrative. It is not yet Fuji-kō. It is the century of watching, fearing, poeticising and divining Fuji's fire.

16. The directionality of the tenth century: up-smoke, not in-forest

This is the cleanest distinction.

Modern Aokigahara is inward:

road → trees → concealment → non-return.

Tenth-century Fuji is upward:

lava/fire → summit smoke → clouds → omens → poetry → court imagination.

The movement is not into the forest. It is from mountain to sky. Smoke rises. Messages rise. Feelings rise. Omens reach Kyoto.

So the tenth-century grammar is:

upward visibility, not inward disappearance.

That is why we must not force later Aokigahara meanings backwards. The century's obsession is with what Fuji emits, not what the forest hides.

17. Aokigahara in 10th-century ecological terms

If we reconstruct the forest without pretending there are rich textual records:

900—930: raw young lava surface, patches of early forest succession, exposed basalt, thin organic accumulation, newly stabilising terrain. 930—970: increasingly established but still young woodland; lake-edge ecosystem still relatively close in memory to the 864 rupture. 970—999: forest perhaps more continuous, but still only 100—135 years old, nowhere near the modern visual density.

Modern Aokigahara's dense moss-root-lava surface is the later version. But the underlying structure — lava cavities, uneven rock, limited soil, roots across stone — begins here.

So, physically, tenth-century Aokigahara is already a place of difficult ground. Culturally, the record does not yet make it a place of chosen disappearance.

18. What “death” means in the tenth century

There are four death-adjacent meanings, none of them modern suicide.

First: volcanic destruction — the memory of the 864 lava burying homes and damaging lakes is still recent in dynastic time. ([data.jma.go.jp](https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Second: divine fire burying water — 937's “神火埋水海” gives a terrifying formula for Fuji's power over the lake-world. ([sakuya.vulcania.jp](https://sakuya.vulcania.jp/koyama/public_html/Fuji/fujid/937.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Third: immortality refused — *Takatori*'s Fuji smoke, if admitted as an early-Heian horizon source, links Fuji with burning the elixir of immortality rather than accepting endless life. ([shinshu-u.ac.jp](https://www.shinshu-u.ac.jp/institution/library/matsumoto/find/tenjikotani2-01.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Fourth: omen of war and disease — 999's eruption-news prompts divination about conflict and epidemic. ([sakuya.vulcania.jp](https://sakuya.vulcania.jp/koyama/public_html/Fuji/fujid/999.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

None of these means “people go into Aokigahara to die”. The tenth-century death-grammar is cosmic, volcanic, political, poetic — not personal self-erasure.

19. The tenth century's deepest psychological structure

The deepest psychological structure is this:

Fuji externalises unbearable inner heat.

Court poetry uses Fuji's smoke to make love visible. Volcanic records use Fuji's fire to make divine danger visible. Political omen-reading uses Fuji's burning to make social threat visible. *Taketori* uses Fuji's smoke to make the loss of immortality and unreachable beloved visible.

So the tenth-century Fuji does not absorb feeling. It emits it.

That is the exact opposite of modern Aokigahara.

Modern Aokigahara: feeling goes into the forest and disappears. Tenth-century Fuji: hidden fire becomes smoke and is seen by everyone.

This is the conceptual pivot.

20. Why the tenth century matters to the later Aokigahara story

It matters not because it gives an early suicide tradition. It does not.

It matters because it creates the following deep preconditions:

Aokigahara as scar: a young forest grown from recent catastrophe.

Fuji as visible fire: a mountain still smoking/erupting in historical memory.

Smoke as psychology: court poetry learns to translate volcanic activity into human longing.

Eruption as omen: the state/elite world reads Fuji's fire as a sign of disorder, disease and war.

Lake-world vulnerability: both 864 and 937 reinforce the image of fire entering and remaking water.

Later, Aokigahara's modern role will invert this entire system. Instead of fire rising from mountain to sky, the figure becomes a person descending from road into trees. Instead of visible smoke, hidden body. Instead of court poetry, newspaper report. Instead of divine omen, police file.

21. Source hierarchy for the tenth century

The best tenth-century packet is:

1. JMA historical eruption chronology. Use for the hard volcanic sequence: 937 eruption, 952 possible eruption, 993 possible eruption, 999 eruption, plus context from 864.
([data.jma.go.jp](https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))
2. Koyama's Fuji eruption-history pages. Use for textual interpretation of 937 and 999: *Nihon Kiryaku*'s “神火埋水海” and *Honchō Seiki*'s 999 omen/divination passage.
([sakuya.vulcania.jp](https://sakuya.vulcania.jp/koyama/public_html/Fuji/fujid/937.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))
3. Fuji lava research chronology. Use for the wider tenth-century smoke record: 889—905, 918—926, 951, 969, 993, 999 and the linked classical-text sources.
([fujisan-yogan-kenkyujo.or.jp](https://www.fujisan-yogan-kenkyujo.or.jp/asset/1-5.pdf?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

pt.com))

4. *Kokinshū* / Kotobank Fuji-smoke entries. Use for the literary transformation of Fuji smoke into emotional metaphor. ([kotobank.jp](https://kotobank.jp/word/%E5%AF%8C%E5%A3%AB%E3%81%AE%E7%85%99-2079670?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

5. *Takatori Monogatari* materials. Use cautiously as early-Heian / ninth-tenth horizon material for Fuji, immortality, smoke, and loss; do not overdate it. ([1.u-tokyo.ac.jp](https://www.1.u-tokyo.ac.jp/takara/takara8.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

6. Official Fuji faith-history pages. Use for the structural religious phase: eruption-fear, Sengen pacification, remote worship, and only later ascent/Shugendō. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001611.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Final tenth-century thesis

In the tenth century, Aokigahara is not yet the suicide forest, not yet the “sea of trees” as modern discourse knows it, and not yet a literary vanishing-stage. It is a young post-Jōgan lava forest: a fresh ecological skin over Fuji’s recent violence, only 36 to 135 years old during the century.

The cultural centre is Fuji’s smoke and fire. *Kokinshū* and related waka turn Fuji’s smoke into a metaphor for unending inner feeling. 937 gives the terrifying historical formula “divine fire buries water”. 999 shows Fuji’s burning read as an omen of war and epidemic. *Takatori*, on the early-Heian horizon, gives Fuji smoke as the burning of immortality itself.

So the exact answer is:

The tenth-century root of Aokigahara’s later death-imaginary is not disappearance. It is the opposite: visibility. Fuji’s hidden fire becomes smoke, poetry, omen and divine warning. Aokigahara below is still young, raw and culturally undernamed — the scar where fire once entered water. Only much later will the visible volcanic grammar be inverted into the forest grammar of invisibility, silence and non-return.

11th Century

Eleventh century only — 1000—1099 — gives a very hard answer:

Aokigahara is physically there, but culturally almost voiceless. Fuji, by contrast, is violently visible. The eleventh century is not the century of forest suicide, not even the century of fully organised Fuji pilgrimage. It is the last major century of Fuji as an active, smoking, fire-lit, eruption-threatening volcano.

That is the key. The eleventh-century root is not “death forest”. It is living volcano.

In the twelfth century, Fuji starts to become an ascetic mountain entered for religious power. In the thirteenth, Hitoana gives the cave-underworld layer. In the fourteenth and fifteenth, ascent routes, guides and pilgrimage infrastructure grow. But the eleventh century is earlier and rawer: Fuji is still a mountain that visibly smokes, glows, erupts and terrifies.

1. The first correction: Aokigahara is not yet an old forest

By the eleventh century, Aokigahara is only about 136 to 235 years old, depending where in the century we stand. It was created after the 864 Jōgan eruption, whose lava flow covered the north-west foot of Fuji and formed the lava plateau on which the forest later grew. Modern Yamanashi material describes Aokigahara as a forest that formed on the 864 lava, with only around “10-plus cm” of soil and roots spreading across lava rather than deep earth; it also says that, in forest terms, even 1,200 years is young. In the eleventh century, therefore, the forest was radically younger still.

([yamanashi-kankou.jp] (https://www.yamanashi-kankou.jp/kokuritsukoen/jp/miryoku/aokigaharajukai.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That means we must discard the idea of an ancient, timeless, primeval death-forest. In the eleventh century, the landscape was a post-eruption recovering lava field: cooling lava, rough basalt, early forest succession, caves, thin soil, moss/lichen colonisation, and young woodland developing over volcanic wreckage.

The later Aokigahara image depends on old-looking density. The eleventh-century reality is younger, harsher, more geologically naked.

2. Aokigahara is not the named protagonist; Fuji is

For 1000—1099, I find no reliable source treating Aokigahara as a suicide site, a corpse forest, an ubasute place, or a named “樹海” with later cultural meaning.

The reason is simple: the cultural and documentary energy is on Fuji’s volcanic activity, not the forest. The eleventh-century records that matter are:

1017 — possible eruption, details unclear. 1020 — smoke/fire-glow seen and recorded in *Sarashina Nikki*. 1033 — eruption with scoria fall and lava flow, north flank. 1083 — eruption, described as explosive in later summaries.

The Japan Meteorological Agency lists 1017 as uncertain, 1020 as fire-glow, 1033 as an eruption with scoria and lava flow from the northern flank, and 1083 as an eruption. Fuji Sabo’s chronology likewise gives 1020 from *Sarashina Nikki*, 1033 from *Nihon Kiryaku*, and 1083 from *Fusō Ryakki* and related records. ([data.jma.go.jp] (https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So the eleventh-century object is not “the forest where people vanish”. It is the mountain that still burns.

3. The century begins immediately after another eruption signal: 999

Strictly, 999 is outside the eleventh century. But it matters as the immediate preface. JMA lists a 999 eruption under Chōhō 1, with details unclear; Fuji Sabo says the source is *Honchō Seiki*. ([data.jma.go.jp] (https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This means the eleventh century opens not after centuries of quiet, but after renewed late-Heian volcanic activity. Aokigahara’s lava forest is already there from 864, but Fuji is still not stable. The mountain is not merely a sacred silhouette. It is a dangerous, active body.

That is the emotional condition of the century: Fuji as unstable presence.

4. 1017: possible eruption, but too thin to interpret heavily

JMA lists 1017 / 寛仁元年 as a possible eruption, with details unclear. ([data.jma.go.jp] (https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is a useful but weak data-point. It tells us that the eleventh-century Fuji record contains possible continuing volcanic activity, but not enough to build a cultural theory around that specific year. The disciplined use is:

1017 reinforces the volcanic activity pattern; it does not give us a narrative, witness, or local cultural scene.

Do not over-read it.

5. 1020: *Sarashina Nikki* is the century’s great witness

The most important eleventh-century source is 菅原孝標女 / Sugawara no Takasue’s daughter, author of *Sarashina Nikki*. Around 1020, aged about 13, she travelled from Kazusa towards Kyoto and passed through the Fuji region. Her diary describes Fuji as visually strange and extraordinary: dark blue like indigo, snow remaining on it, smoke rising from the slightly flat summit, and fire visible at evening. The volcano scholar Koyama explains that she does not report ashfall or rumbling, so this was probably not an eruption in progress, but a fire-glow phenomenon: a red-hot lava lake or very hot volcanic gas visible from the summit crater. ([sakuya.vulcania.jp] (https://sakuya.vulcania.jp/koyama/public_html/Fuji/fujid/1020.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is the eleventh-century jackpot.

It gives us a first-person literary perception of Fuji not as tourist beauty, not as pilgrimage route, not as suicide-adjacent forest, but as supernatural-looking active mountain. The mountain has snow and fire at once. It is blue-black, white, smoking, glowing. It is aesthetically beautiful and geologically alarming.

That is the deep register: beauty fused with volcanic threat.

6. The 1020 witness is female, literary, travelling, and pre-pilgrimage

This matters.

The *Sarashina Nikki* passage is not an ascetic's record, not a shrine foundation myth, not a state eruption chronicle, not a later tourist guide. It is a young aristocratic woman's retrospective literary memory of passing Fuji on the Tōkaidō.

That gives the eleventh century a specific phenomenology:

Fuji is seen from the road, not entered. It is observed as form, colour, smoke and fire. It is sublime before it is organised pilgrimage. The viewer is moving past, not climbing.

This is a completely different relation from later Fuji-kō or Aokigahara. The later pilgrim enters Fuji's sacred geography. The later suicidal visitor enters Aokigahara. The eleventh-century diarist passes by and sees the mountain burning.

7. 1020 also shows why Fuji becomes symbolically available

The mountain in *Sarashina Nikki* is already more than geology. Its form is aesthetically coded: unusual shape, deep colour, snow, smoke, evening fire. Koyama's discussion treats the passage as a volcanic observation, but its literary force is just as important. ([sakuya.vulcania.jp](https://sakuya.vulcania.jp/koyama/public_html/Fuji/fujid/1020.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is where Fuji becomes available for Japanese imagination: not because it is peaceful, but because it is visually impossible — snow and flame, blue-black surface and white summit, beauty and danger together.

Later Aokigahara inherits some of this impossible doubleness. But in the eleventh century, the doubleness belongs to Fuji itself, not the forest.

8. 1033: eruption reaches the north flank — directly relevant to the Aokigahara side

The 1033 / 長元5 or 長元6 eruption is one of the strongest eleventh-century volcanic points. JMA lists it as an eruption on 19 January 1033, with scoria fall and lava flow from the northern flank. Fuji Sabo says the old record states that lava flowed down to the mountain foot, with *Nihon Kiryaku* as the cited source. ([data.jma.go.jp](https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This matters for Aokigahara because the north flank is the broader side of Fuji that includes the later Fuji Five Lakes/Aokigahara world. It does not mean the 1033 lava created Aokigahara; Aokigahara's main lava is 864. But it does mean that, in the eleventh century, the north side of Fuji still had active eruption history.

So the Aokigahara-adjacent world was not sitting beneath a safely mythologised mountain. It was beneath a mountain still producing lava and scoria.

9. 1083: the last major eleventh-century eruption signal

JMA lists 1083 / 永保3 as an eruption on 17 April. Fuji Sabo summarises it as an explosive eruption, citing *Fusō Ryakki* and related records. ([data.jma.go.jp](https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is the end of the eleventh-century volcanic cluster. Fuji City's official page notes that the historical record has many eruptions from 781 to 1083, and that after 1083 there is then a long gap of over 400 years until the next recorded eruption in 1511.

([city.fuji.shizuoka.jp](https://www.city.fuji.shizuoka.jp/1004050000/p000050.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That makes 1083 a hinge. The eleventh century is the end of a long early-historical eruption phase. The twelfth-century shift into Shugendō and summit Buddhism becomes intelligible only after this: Fuji is moving from active terror into enterable sacred mountain.

So the eleventh century is the last century before the religious entry phase fully opens.

10. The religious status in the eleventh century: still primarily appeasement, not ascent

Official Shizuoka and Yamanashi summaries say that ancient Japanese people feared Fuji as a mountain where a god dwelt because it repeatedly erupted; Sengen shrines were established at the foot to pacify eruptions. They then say that when volcanic activity quietened in the late Heian period, Fuji became a Shugendō training mountain; the twelfth-century Matsudai Shōnin built Dainichi-ji at the summit. ([pref.shizuoka.jp](https://www.pref.shizuoka.jp/kankosports/kanko/mtfuji/1002802/1020133.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That lets us place the eleventh century precisely.

It is before Matsudai's twelfth-century summit Buddhism. It is before fourteenth-century lay pilgrimage. It is before sixteenth-century Kakugyō/Fuji-kō lake practice. It is after the 864 Aokigahara lava event. It is during active or recently active Fuji.

So the eleventh-century Fuji relation is still dominated by fear, appeasement, distant worship, and awe, not organised ascent.

11. The key cultural movement is from “遥” to “登”, but the eleventh century is still mostly before the turn

The Kitaguchi Hongū Fuji Sengen Shrine page gives a useful formula: in earlier times Fuji was worshipped at a distance; around the late Heian period, as volcanic activity settled, more practitioners began to climb and practise on the mountain, and faith shifted from 遥 — distant worship — towards 登 — climbing worship. ([sengenjinja.jp](https://www.sengenjinja.jp/fuji/index.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

The eleventh century sits on the edge of that transformation, but not yet at its full expression. Because Fuji is still smoking, fire-lit and erupting in 1020, 1033 and 1083, it remains primarily a mountain to fear and look at, not yet a fully routinised object of ascent.

This is the century's religious psychology:

Do not enter the mountain yet; see it, fear it, appease it, narrate it.

12. Aokigahara's eleventh-century condition: young, rough, not yet “the sea of trees”

If we reconstruct Aokigahara itself from geological/ecological facts:

In 1000, the 864 lava is only about 136 years old. In 1050, about 186 years old. In 1099, about 235 years old.

Modern Yamanashi says even the present 1,200-year-old forest is young in forest terms, with thin soil and roots spread across lava. ([yamanashi-kankou.jp](https://www.yamanashi-kankou.jp/kokuritsukoen/jp/miryoku/aokigaharajukai.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com)) Therefore the eleventh-century Aokigahara was not the fully developed, moss-heavy “primeval” forest of modern photography. It would have been an earlier successional landscape: lava, young woodland, patchier soil, developing vegetation, exposed rock, caves, and likely uneven colonisation.

This matters because later descriptions of Aokigahara as deep, ancient, swallowing forest cannot be projected backwards. In the eleventh century, its “death” quality, if any, would not be old-growth gloom. It would be new-earth desolation and regrowth.

13. The forest’ s meaning is probably geological before it is cultural

The eleventh-century Aokigahara is best described as a recent volcanic afterland.

The sources say the 864 lava burned the north-west foot and later cooled, allowing forest regeneration; the forest grows on thin soil over lava. ([yamanashi-kankou.jp](https://www.yamanashi-kankou.jp/kokuritsukoen/jp/miryoku/aokigaharajukai.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com)) In the eleventh century, that regeneration is still relatively young.

That means the primary eleventh-century Aokigahara relation is not “forest as hiding place” . It is:

lava that recently remade the land; a recovering surface; a reminder of Fuji’ s destructive power; a new terrain where lake, forest and rock were still consequences of catastrophe.

In other words: Aokigahara is not yet a death symbol. It is a scar.

14. What “death” means in the eleventh century

The eleventh-century death relation is not suicide and not self-erasure.

It is:

volcanic threat; burned land; lava reaching the foot; fire seen at the summit; eruption records; the need to pacify the mountain deity; awe before a dangerous natural/sacred force.

The JMA and Fuji Sabo eruption records show an eleventh century marked by possible eruption, fire glow, lava/scoria eruption and explosive eruption. ([data.jma.go.jp](https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com)) Shizuoka and Yamanashi’ s faith histories then explain that Fuji’ s repeated eruptions led to fear of the mountain as a divine dwelling and to Sengen worship to calm it. ([pref.shizuoka.jp](https://www.pref.shizuoka.jp/kankosports/kanko/mtfuji/1002802/1020133.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So the eleventh-century death-grammar is:

not “I go there to die” , but “the mountain may kill, burn, bury, or demand appeasement.”

That is fundamentally different.

15. The literary image of Fuji is not peaceful

The *Sarashina Nikki* passage is often treated as beautiful scenery, but in this context it is more disturbing. It records a mountain with snow that never disappears, smoke rising from the summit, and visible fire at evening. Koyama argues this likely reflects a high-temperature crater phenomenon rather than an eruptive disaster directly experienced by the traveller.

([sakuya.vulcania.jp](https://sakuya.vulcania.jp/koyama/public_html/Fuji/fujid/1020.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That is almost the perfect eleventh-century image:

the mountain is beautiful enough for literature; active enough for volcanology; strange enough for awe; not yet domesticated into pilgrimage.

This is the psychological foundation of later Fuji culture. Before people climb it as a sacred mountain, they see it as an impossible natural body.

16. Why this matters for the later Aokigahara story

The later Aokigahara death-image is not born in the eleventh century. But the eleventh century gives three deep preconditions.

First, Fuji is still dangerous enough to be feared as active divine nature. That gives the whole north-west foot a non-ordinary aura.

Second, Aokigahara is still visibly post-catastrophic: the young forest grows on recent lava, not timeless soil.

Third, the transition into religious entry has not yet occurred. The mountain is mostly seen, feared and appeased. The idea of entering Fuji nature for transformation only becomes clear in the twelfth century and after.

So the eleventh century is the pre-entry phase. It is the last major century of Fuji as a mountain one mainly watches, fears and ritually pacifies.

17. The century's directional logic: looking, not entering

This is the cleanest conceptual distinction.

Twelfth century: ascetics begin entering Fuji. Thirteenth century: a warrior enters Hitoana cave. Fourteenth century: pilgrims begin climbing with guides and lodgings. Twentieth century: people enter Aokigahara to disappear.

But eleventh century:

people look at Fuji.

They see smoke, fire, snow, eruption signs. The cultural movement is visual, fearful, observational. The mountain is not yet a routinised path. It is an object of awe and danger.

So the eleventh-century directionality is:

distance → sight → fear → appeasement.

Not ascent. Not cave descent. Not forest entry.

18. Aokigahara as the unspoken consequence

If Fuji is the speaking object in the eleventh century, Aokigahara is the silent consequence.

The forest exists because Fuji destroyed and remade the north-west foot in 864. It is a geological memory of volcanic violence. But the eleventh-century sources that survive prefer to register the mountain's continuing activity rather than the young forest's cultural identity.

That tells us something subtle: Aokigahara's later power partly comes from being a landscape that outlived the event that made it. The eruption becomes history; the lava becomes forest; the forest later becomes myth.

In the eleventh century, that process is incomplete. The scar has not yet become a symbol.

19. What we cannot honestly say

We cannot say Aokigahara was a suicide forest.

We cannot say it was a known death-destination.

We cannot say it had the later "body not found" discourse.

We cannot say it was already an ancient primeval forest.

We cannot say people were making Matsumoto-like associations between forest entry and disappearance.

We cannot say the Fuji-kō Inner Eight Seas structure existed in its later form.

All of that comes later.

The eleventh century gives volcanic fear, not suicide culture.

20. The best eleventh-century source hierarchy

The source hierarchy is very narrow but strong.

1. *Sarashina Nikki*, 1020 Fuji passage. This is the central witness: smoke, snow, evening fire-glow, Fuji seen from the road by an aristocratic woman travelling from the east to Kyoto. Koyama's volcanological reading treats it as high-temperature crater/fire-glow activity, not a full eruption directly experienced by her. ([sakuya.vulcania.jp] (https://sakuya.vulcania.jp/koyama/public_html/Fuji/fujid/1020.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com)))

2. JMA eruption chronology. Best official list for 1017 possible eruption, 1020 fire-glow, 1033 north-flank scoria/lava eruption, 1083 eruption. ([data.jma.go.jp] (https://www.data.jma.go.jp/vois/data/tokyo/314_Fujisan/314_history.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com)))

3. Fuji Sabo eruption-history chronology. Best old-record source summary: 1020 from *Sarashina Nikki*, 1033 from *Nihon Kiryaku*, 1083 from *Fusō Ryakki* and related sources. ([cbr.mlit.go.jp] (https://www.cbr.mlit.go.jp/fujisabo/bosai/bosairekisi/bosairekisi-funka.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com)))

4. Fuji faith-history pages from Shizuoka/Yamanashi/Fujinomiya. Best structural interpretation: repeated eruptions led to fear and Sengen worship; only when activity quietened in the late Heian/twelfth-century transition did Fuji become a Shugendō training mountain. ([pref.shizuoka.jp] (https://www.pref.shizuoka.jp/kankosports/kanko/mtfuji/1002802/1020133.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com)))

5. Aokigahara geological/ecological sources. Best for physical reconstruction: 864 lava, thin soil, young forest, lava-root ecology. ([yamanashi-kankou.jp] (https://www.yamanashi-kankou.jp/kokuritsukoen/jp/miryoku/aokigaharajukai.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com)))

Final eleventh-century thesis

In the eleventh century, Aokigahara is not yet a suicide forest, not yet a literary vanishing-place, not yet a national “sea of trees”, and not yet a mature old-growth symbol. It is a young lava forest growing over the 864 catastrophe, still physically raw in historical terms.

The cultural centre is Fuji. And eleventh-century Fuji is still active: possible eruption in 1017, smoke/fire-glow witnessed in 1020, scoria and lava in 1033, eruption again in 1083. The most vivid human witness is *Sarashina Nikki*: a young traveller sees Fuji as an impossible mountain of snow, smoke and evening fire. That is the century’s true image.

So the exact answer is:

The eleventh-century root of Aokigahara’s later death-imaginary is not forest suicide. It is post-eruption youth beneath an active sacred volcano. Aokigahara is the scar left by Fuji; Fuji is still burning above it. Only after this volcanic century recedes can the mountain become enterable as Shugendō, then narratable as cave-underworld, then climbable as pilgrimage, and much later invert into the forest of disappearance.

In one line:

Eleventh-century Aokigahara is not where people go to vanish; it is where Fuji’s violence has only recently become forest.

12th Century

Twelfth century only — 1100—1199 — gives a very tight answer:

Aokigahara is physically present, but culturally almost mute. Fuji is not mute. The decisive twelfth-century transformation is that Fuji shifts from a feared eruption-mountain worshipped from below into a mountain entered by Buddhist ascetics. The key figure is 末代上人 / Matsudai Shōnin, and the key date is 1149.

So the root is not “suicide forest”. It is:

volcanic fear → ascetic entry → summit Buddhism → Fuji Shugendō.

Aokigahara later inherits some of the atmosphere of this Fuji world, but in the twelfth century the recorded charge is upward to the summit, not inward into the forest.

1. Physical Aokigahara in the twelfth century: young lava forest, not ancient deathscape

By 1100, Aokigahara had existed for only about 235 years after the 864—866 Jōgan eruption. The Fuji Sabo Office describes that eruption as the event that produced the Aokigahara lava; it says the lava is visible under the forest and along Saiko, Shōjiko and Motosuko, and identifies the 864—866 lava as 青木ヶ原溶岩. ([cbr.mlit.go.jp](https://www.cbr.mlit.go.jp/fujisabo/bosai/fuji_info/chisiki/a05/index.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This matters because in the twelfth century Aokigahara is not “ancient primeval forest” in any absolute sense. It is a young post-eruption ecosystem growing over rough lava. Yamanashi’s own nature page says Aokigahara formed on the lava from the 864 eruption, has only around 10-plus cm of soil, and supports trees whose roots spread over the lava rather than into deep earth.

([yamanashi-kankou.jp](https://www.yamanashi-kankou.jp/kokuritsukoen/jp/miryoku/aokigaharajukai.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So the twelfth-century forest is physically capable of later “no-return” meanings — uneven lava, caves, shallow soil, dense growth — but there is no twelfth-century evidence yet that it is publicly imagined as a suicide place. The raw material exists; the later discourse does not.

2. The main cultural object is Fuji, not Aokigahara

The twelfth-century sources do not give us a rich “Aokigahara” cultural record. They give us Fuji.

That distinction is essential. In later centuries, especially the twentieth, Aokigahara becomes the named object: 樹海, suicide forest, no-return place, media site. In the twelfth century, the named and documented transformation is Fuji’s religious reclassification.

Fujinomiya’s official history says that around the twelfth century, as volcanic activity quietened, Fuji changed from a distant mountain feared for eruptions into a 修験道 training mountain, where practitioners entered the mountain to gain spiritual power.

([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001611.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com)) Shizuoka’s official page gives the same structure: in the late Heian period, after eruption activity calmed, Fuji became a Shugendō training ground combining older mountain worship with esoteric Buddhism and related religious ideas. ([pref.shizuoka.jp](https://www.pref.shizuoka.jp/kankosports/kanko/mtfuji/1002802/1020133.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That is the century's core change: Fuji becomes enterable.

Not Aokigahara as self-erasure. Fuji as ascetic access.

3. 1149: Matsudai Shōnin is the hard centre

The key twelfth-century date is 久安5年 / 1149.

The Shinshu University library exhibition summarises the *Honchō Seiki* entry: in 1149, Matsudai Shōnin built Dainichi-ji / 大日寺 on Fuji's summit and sacred scriptures copied by Emperor Toba and aristocrats were dedicated there. The same source says Matsudai's activity marks the development of Fuji as a Shugendō training mountain. ([shinshu-u.ac.jp] (https://www.shinshu-u.ac.jp/institution/library/matsumoto/find/tenjikotani2-01.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Kotobank, drawing on the older encyclopaedic tradition, identifies the *Honchō Seiki* entry for 1149, fourth month, sixteenth day as the beginning of Fuji's Buddhist element: Matsudai is said to have built Dainichi-ji at the summit and buried/dedicated the complete Buddhist canon, becoming revered as the founder of Fuji Shugendō. ([kotobank.jp] (https://kotobank.jp/word/%E6%9C%AB%E4%BB%A3%E4%B8%8A%E4%BA%BA-1419789?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That is the most important twelfth-century source node. It gives us:

Matsudai; 1149; summit; Dainichi; scripture dedication; Buddhist sacralisation of Fuji; Fuji Shugendō's beginning.

The deepest point: the twelfth-century sacred movement is vertical. Matsudai does not disappear into the forest. He ascends the mountain and installs Buddhist meaning at the summit.

4. Why Dainichi matters

Dainichi is not decorative. Dainichi Nyorai / Mahāvairocana is the cosmic Buddha central to esoteric Buddhism. Placing Dainichi-ji at the summit means Fuji is being read not merely as a kami mountain, but as a Buddhist cosmic space.

Fujinomiya's account says that under the common medieval doctrine of 本地垂迹 / honji-suijaku, the summit was understood as a Buddhist world or as a place where buddhas appear in the form of kami; as a result, reaching the summit took on major religious significance. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp] (https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001611.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So the twelfth-century turn is not just "people started climbing". It is: the top of Fuji becomes a Buddhist destination.

That is radically different from modern Aokigahara. Modern Aokigahara is not summit, temple, scripture, or return. It is forest entry, concealment, and non-return. The twelfth century is its structural opposite.

5. The mountain ceases to be only feared from below

Before this shift, Fuji's religious relation is heavily shaped by eruption fear and appeasement. Shizuoka's official page says people long feared Fuji's repeated eruptions as the dwelling of a god and established Sengen shrines at the foot to calm eruptions. ([pref.shizuoka.jp] (https://www.pref.shizuoka.jp/kankosports/kanko/mtfuji/1002802/1020133.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

By the twelfth century, that fear is not erased, but it is transformed. Once eruption activity quietens, religious specialists enter the mountain. Fujinomiya says Fuji becomes a site where Shugendō practitioners enter the mountain to perform austerities and gain spiritual power.
([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp] (https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001611.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That is the century's psychological hinge:

from appeasing danger at the foot to entering danger for power.

This is the oldest deep structure that later matters for Aokigahara. Fuji nature is not neutral scenery. It is a place where ordinary human limits are crossed.

6. The body in the twelfth century: ordeal, not erasure

The modern Aokigahara body is imagined as becoming unfindable. The twelfth-century Fuji body is different. It climbs, suffers, performs austerity, and approaches a sacred summit.

The official Yamanashi guide describes the medieval Fuji of this period as a mountain where yamabushi performed severe practices after the terrifying eruptions quietened; it frames this as a solemn, profound Fuji faith centred on Buddhist and Shugendō practitioners.
([pref.yamanashi.jp] (https://www.pref.yamanashi.jp/ebook/fujisan_guide2023/Japanese/pageindices/index21.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So if we are tracing “death” or “disappearance”, the answer is not suicide. It is bodily extremity. The body is put under strain because the mountain is religiously powerful.

The later forest of disappearance will secularise and invert this. But in the twelfth century, the point is not to stop existing. The point is to transform the body through religious ordeal.

7. The Omiya—Murayama route begins here, but is not yet the later mass route

The Omiya—Murayama route is the route-family most tied to Matsudai and early Fuji Shugendō. Yamanashi's World Heritage page says the southern Fuji ascent from the Omiya/Murayama side began from Matsudai Shōnin's activity in the twelfth century, while organised climbs by Shugendō practitioners are thought to have developed by the early fourteenth century.
([yamanashi-kankou.jp] (https://www.yamanashi-kankou.jp/kankou/spot/wh_1-2.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is a useful precision point. The twelfth century supplies the origin impulse, not yet the full medieval mass pilgrimage apparatus.

The sequence is:

twelfth century — Matsudai and summit Buddhism; thirteenth century — further cave/otherworld documentation, especially Hitoana in 1203; fourteenth century — wider lay ascent, guides, lodging and route systems; fifteenth/sixteenth centuries — fuller institutional expansion and Fuji-kō prehistory.

So the twelfth century is the ignition of ascetic Fuji, not yet the whole organised pilgrimage system.

8. Murayama: linked to Matsudai, but the hard institutional evidence is later

Murayama is important, but the dating must be kept clean.

Cultural Heritage Online says Murayama Sengen Shrine was traditionally founded by the twelfth-century ascetic Matsudai Shōnin and was known as Kōhōji / 興法寺, a syncretic religious facility; it also describes the site's Dainichi hall, goma ritual space, water-purification area and later Shugendō objects. ([online.bunka.go.jp](https://online.bunka.go.jp/special_content/component/113?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Fujinomiya's page is more cautious about the hard evidence: it says a temple is thought to have been established at Murayama in the Kamakura period by practitioners connected to Matsudai, and it notes a Dainichi Nyorai statue dated 1259, which is outside the twelfth century. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001615.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That matters. We can say:

Matsudai is the twelfth-century founding figure in the tradition. Murayama as a clearly evidenced institutional complex becomes firmer in later medieval material.

Do not overclaim a fully developed twelfth-century Murayama institution.

9. What is Aokigahara doing while this happens?

Physically, Aokigahara is sitting on the north-western lava flow. It is young, rough, forested, cave-bearing, and adjacent to the later Saiko/Shōjiko/Motosuko world. MLIT's Fuji Sabo page states the Aokigahara lava is visible under the forest and around those lake shores. ([cbr.mlit.go.jp](https://www.cbr.mlit.go.jp/fujisabo/bosai/fuji_info/chisiki/a05/index.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

But culturally, the twelfth-century record we can cite does not make Aokigahara the central object. It is not yet the place where the documentary imagination goes. The sacred energy is going to:

summit; Dainichi; scripture; Matsudai; ascent; Shugendō; Buddhist-kami fusion.

Aokigahara is the lava-foot background to a mountain that is becoming spiritually enterable.

That is the exact relation.

10. No twelfth-century suicide-site evidence

This must be said plainly.

For the twelfth century, I find no reliable accessible evidence for:

Aokigahara as a suicide destination; Aokigahara as an ubasute site; Aokigahara as a corpse forest; Aokigahara as a named “樹海” death-discourse object; people travelling there to disappear; local records of repeated deaths in the forest; a Matsumoto-like vanishing scene; a no-return public reputation.

That is not a failure of imagination. It is the evidence.

The twelfth century gives Fuji asceticism, not Aokigahara suicide.

11. The century's death-relation: salvation and Buddhist world, not private disappearance

The “death” component in the twelfth century is indirect but deep. The summit becomes a Buddhist space. Dainichi-ji and sutra dedication imply that Fuji is being drawn into a soteriological world: karmic merit, sacred ascent, Buddhist protection, cosmic order.

Fujinomiya’s source says that under honji-suijaku, the summit is recognised as a Buddhist world or a place where buddhas appear as kami, making the act of reaching the summit deeply meaningful.
([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001611.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That is death-related because Buddhism is concerned with rebirth, salvation and liberation, but it is not suicidal. It is not “I want to vanish”. It is “I enter sacred order”.

So the twelfth-century grammar is:

approach death through salvation, not disappearance.

12. Directionality: the single most important distinction

The twelfth-century sacred movement is up.

Modern Aokigahara movement is in.

That sounds simple, but it is the whole historical distinction.

Twelfth century:

foot → slope → summit → Dainichi → Buddhist/kami world.

Modern Aokigahara:

road → forest edge → pathlessness → concealment → non-return.

One is vertical religious ascent. The other is horizontal secular disappearance.

The later Aokigahara myth becomes powerful partly because it takes the old Fuji act of leaving ordinary space and reverses its meaning. Instead of climbing toward cosmic visibility, one enters into social invisibility.

13. The twelfth century’s “otherworld” is not yet the forest interior

The thirteenth century gives the Hitoana cave-underworld episode. The fourteenth and fifteenth centuries give more organised ascent. But the twelfth century’s hard source centre is summit Buddhism.

That means the twelfth-century otherworld is not yet Aokigahara’s dark interior. It is the summit-as-Buddhist-world.

Again, this matters because it prevents lazy continuity. The medieval Fuji otherworld does not map directly onto the modern suicide forest. It gives a deeper religious field, but the modern forest meaning is a later inversion.

14. What the twelfth century contributes to the later Aokigahara phenomenon

It contributes five preconditions, none of which is suicide.

First, Fuji becomes enterable. The mountain is no longer only feared from below; it becomes a space ascetics enter. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001611.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Second, Fuji's interior/topography becomes religiously charged. The summit is not just a peak; it is a Buddhist/kami world. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001611.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Third, bodily hardship becomes meaningful. The ascetic body can enter dangerous nature to obtain power, merit or transformation. ([pref.yamanashi.jp](https://www.pref.yamanashi.jp/ebook/fujisan_guide2023/Japanese/pageindices/index21.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Fourth, text and authority sacralise the mountain. Matsudai's 1149 act involves Dainichi-ji and sutra dedication, including aristocratic/imperial connection through Toba and copied scriptures. ([shinshu-u.ac.jp](https://www.shinshu-u.ac.jp/institution/library/matsumoto/find/tenjikotani2-01.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Fifth, the forest remains available as unclaimed background. Because the twelfth-century focus is summit ascent rather than Aokigahara itself, the forest is not yet saturated with a specific public meaning. Later media can capture it more easily.

That fifth point is subtle but important: sometimes a place becomes available for later myth precisely because earlier systems did not fully fix it.

15. The “0.0000000001%” source here is not lurid — it is *Honchō Seiki*

For the twelfth century, the source that matters most is not a hidden ghost tale. It is the *Honchō Seiki* entry for 1149.

It gives the earliest hard pivot: Matsudai at Fuji's summit, Dainichi-ji, sutras, and the beginning of Fuji's Buddhist/Shugendō framing. Shinshu University's exhibition notes that the entry records Matsudai building Dainichi-ji and asking Emperor Toba to copy the *Daihannya-kyō* for dedication. ([shinshu-u.ac.jp](https://www.shinshu-u.ac.jp/institution/library/matsumoto/find/tenjikotani2-01.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That is the deep source because it shows the exact moment Fuji's dangerous summit becomes a textual, Buddhist, aristocratically connected sacred space.

If we are tracing Aokigahara's later death-charge back as far as possible, this is one of the first medieval hinges: not because it mentions the forest, but because it changes what Fuji nature can mean.

16. The final twelfth-century thesis

In the twelfth century, Aokigahara is physically there but culturally secondary. It is a young lava forest on Fuji's north-west foot, formed on the 864—866 Aokigahara lava. The available twelfth-century cultural record does not treat it as a suicide place, corpse place, ubasute place, or “sea of trees” death-symbol.

The real twelfth-century transformation is Fuji's conversion into an ascetic Buddhist mountain. As eruptions quieten, practitioners enter the mountain. Matsudai Shōnin, recorded in the 1149 *Honchō Seiki* tradition, builds Dainichi-ji at the summit and connects Fuji to scripture, Dainichi, aristocratic patronage and Shugendō. The summit becomes a Buddhist/kami world. The body enters dangerous nature not to disappear, but to obtain religious power and transformation.

So the precise answer is:

The twelfth-century root of Aokigahara's later death-imaginary is not Aokigahara itself. It is the sacralisation of Fuji as enterable dangerous nature. The forest later inherits the prestige and dread of Fuji's non-ordinary terrain, but in the twelfth century the movement is vertical ascent to Dainichi, not horizontal disappearance into trees.

In one line:

Twelfth-century Fuji creates the religious grammar of entering dangerous nature; twentieth-century Aokigahara secularises that grammar into the fantasy of vanishing from society.

13th Century

Thirteenth century only — 1200—1299 — gives one genuinely major answer:

Aokigahara itself is still almost silent, but Fuji’s cave-underworld imagination becomes documentarily visible in 1203 through the Hitoana episode in **Azuma Kagami**.

That is the century’s hard centre. Not suicide. Not “樹海”. Not Matsumoto. Not modern disappearance. The thirteenth century gives us something older and stranger: Fuji as a mountain whose subterranean lava spaces are already imagined as sacred, dangerous, otherworldly, and potentially fatal.

The precise answer is:

In the thirteenth century, the later Aokigahara death-imaginary does not yet exist as such. What exists is a medieval Fuji cave-imaginary: human entry into a lava cavity, darkness, bats, an underground river, supernatural vision, sudden deaths, return from the underworld, and the identification of the cave as the dwelling-place of Sengen/Asama divinity.

That is the root. Not suicide. Underworld cave encounter.

1. The century’s source base is brutally narrow

For 1200—1299, the available evidence is not broad. There is no thirteenth-century “Aokigahara suicide forest” dossier. There is no thirteenth-century **Nami no Tō** equivalent. There is no premodern police record, no local “suicide hotspot” register, no stable public phrase “青木ヶ原樹海” doing later work.

The century gives us mainly:

1203 — the Hitoana episode in **Azuma Kagami**; the wider Kamakura-period shift of Fuji from remote volcanic deity to mountain/cave religious site; the early medieval formation of Fuji as a place of ascent and ascetic practice; later medieval/early modern reworking of the Hitoana episode into **Fuji no Hitoana Sōshi**.

So the thirteenth-century answer has to be precise: the strongest material is not Aokigahara proper, but Fuji’s west/north-west lava-cave sacred geography.

2. 1203 is the key date

The core event is recorded in **Azuma Kagami**. During Minamoto no Yoriie’s Fuji hunting excursion, Nitta/Nita Tadatsune was ordered to investigate Hitoana, a lava cave at Fuji’s western foot.

Shizuoka’s official cultural-property page says that in Ken’ nin 3, 1203, Nitta Tadatsune reported that Hitoana was extremely narrow, difficult to move through, dark, full of many bats, and that there was a great river deeper inside. The same page identifies Hitoana as a place treated as the residence of Fuji Sengen Daibosatsu. ([pref.shizuoka.jp] (https://www.pref.shizuoka.jp/kankosports/bunkageijutsu/bunkazai/1002825/1041003/1041889/1004987/1021574.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Fujinomiya’s official site gives the same structural point: **Azuma Kagami** describes the Hitoana exploration, and the story was later gathered as a Sengen/Asama Daibosatsu miracle-tale in Hitoana Sōshi; it also says **Azuma Kagami** records Hitoana as the “御在所” of Asama Daibosatsu, showing that

the cave was already connected to Fuji faith at that time.

([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp] (https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/fujisan/11ti2b0000001br3.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That is the century's hard documentary nucleus.

3. What actually happens in the Hitoana story

The compressed version is not enough. The details matter.

Kotobank's entry on Nitta Tadatsune, drawing on the older encyclopaedic account, says that on 3 June 1203, during Yoriie's Fuji hunt, Nitta Shiro Tadatsune entered Fuji's Hitoana with six men. Inside, there was an underground river with waves surging backwards; when they illuminated the far side with torches, they saw something extraordinary or uncanny. Four retainers died suddenly. Tadatsune threw into the river a sword he had received from the shogun and eventually returned the next day. The account adds that old people said the cave was the dwelling-place of Asama Daibosatsu.

([kotobank.jp] (https://kotobank.jp/word/%E6%96%B0%E7%94%B0%E5%BF%A0%E5%B8%B8-1385558?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is not a casual cave anecdote. It contains almost every component of an underworld descent:

entry into a narrow dark opening; animal signs — bats; difficulty moving forward; a river boundary; a vision across the river; fatal consequence; ritual offering or surrender of a sword; return from forbidden depth; local elders interpreting the place as divine residence.

That structure matters more than any later “suicide forest” cliché.

4. This is not Aokigahara, but it is the same deep grammar

Hitoana is on Fuji's western foot, not the later central Aokigahara/Lake Saiko suicide zone. So we must not conflate them.

But it is absolutely relevant because it proves that, by 1203, Fuji's lava-cave landscape could already be imagined as an entrance into a dangerous sacred otherworld.

The later Aokigahara imaginary also depends on entry into a non-ordinary natural space. But the 1203 grammar is different:

1203: warrior enters sacred cave → sees otherworld signs → death/terror occurs → cave is divine residence. 20th century: distressed person enters forest → seeks quiet disappearance → body may not be found.

The continuity is entry into non-ordinary Fuji nature. The discontinuity is the purpose: religious terror and divine encounter, not private self-erasure.

5. The underground river is the decisive image

The most important image is not the bats. It is the river.

A river inside a cave is not just geography in a medieval tale. It functions like a boundary between worlds. The Kotobank summary says Tadatsune and his men came to a great river with violent or backwards-surging waves, and the vision occurred beyond it.

([kotobank.jp] (https://kotobank.jp/word/%E6%96%B0%E7%94%B0%E5%BF%A0%E5%B8%B8-1385558?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That is why this source matters for the long history of Aokigahara/Fuji death-imagery. A person enters Fuji's lava interior and meets a boundary he cannot cross. Across it is something supernatural. Crossing or seeing too much is fatal.

This is a much older structure than "suicide forest":

Fuji's underground is not empty. It is guarded, sacred, dangerous, and not fully available to human knowledge.

Aokigahara's later power is partly a forest version of that: the interior is imagined as a place where ordinary social mapping fails.

6. The deaths in the story are not suicide deaths

This must be stated cleanly.

The thirteenth-century deaths are not voluntary self-killing. They are deaths caused by contact with a forbidden or sacred space. They belong to the grammar of taboo, divine danger, and otherworld trespass.

That is crucial. If you are tracing "the forest in relation to death", the thirteenth century gives death, but of the wrong kind for the modern myth.

It is not:

"I go there to die."

It is:

"To enter too far into Fuji's hidden interior may be deadly."

That is a completely different cultural mechanism.

7. The century's deepest Japanese-culture layer: Fuji is becoming more than a volcano

The Hitoana episode sits inside a larger transformation.

The Yamanashi Fujisan World Heritage Center says early Fuji faith began with fear of eruptions and distant worship, but when eruptions calmed, religious practitioners began treating Fuji as a mountain of ascetic practice. It specifically says that in the twelfth century, Matsu-dai/Shōdai — usually rendered as Matsudai — climbed Fuji more than a hundred times and founded Fuji-san Kōbōji, creating a Fuji Shugendō group; from the fourteenth century, lay believers called dōja appeared. ([fujisan-whc.jp](https://www.fujisan-whc.jp/about/feature.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

For the thirteenth century, that means we are in the intermediate zone:

older eruption-fear is not gone; ascetic/mountain practice is forming; cave and summit spaces are gaining religious intensity; lay mass pilgrimage has not yet fully arrived.

So the thirteenth-century Fuji world is not yet Edo Fuji-kō and not yet modern tourism. It is medieval sacred danger.

8. The thirteenth century's directional logic: inward/downward, not yet forest-horizontal

The thirteenth-century Hitoana story is not an ascent story in the way later Fuji pilgrimage becomes. It is a descent or inward-entry story.

That matters because the broader Fuji tradition has two axes:

vertical axis: climb the mountain, approach summit, seek salvation/rebirth; inward axis: enter cave, encounter hidden divine/underworld presence.

The fourteenth/fifteenth-century route evidence is mainly vertical ascent. The thirteenth-century Hitoana evidence is inward descent.

Aokigahara's later death-imaginary is closer to the inward axis than the summit axis. The person does not climb to salvation. They enter a dark, enclosing Fuji landscape.

But again: in 1203, the inward axis is sacred/terrifying; in modern Aokigahara, it becomes psychological/social disappearance.

9. “御在所” is a crucial word

The official Fujinomiya page says *Azuma Kagami* treats Hitoana as the 御在所 of Asama Daibosatsu. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp] (https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/fujisan/11ti2b0000001br3.html?utm_source=chagtpt.com))

That word matters. It means the cave is not merely a “scary hole”. It is a dwelling-place or seat of the deity. This is what converts landscape into sacred geography.

So the thirteenth-century thought is not:

“this cave is haunted.”

It is closer to:

“this cave is where the Fuji deity is present.”

The danger is not random horror. It is proximity to divine power.

10. Why this is not yet Aokigahara

Aokigahara, as later imagined, requires several things that are not present here:

a named “tree sea” reputation; a public no-return forest label; a modern media system; transport from urban centres; a secular psychology of self-erasure; newspaper contagion; Matsumoto's vanishing scene; Tsurumi/manual/internet afterlives; modern police/rescue infrastructure.

None of that belongs to the thirteenth century.

The thirteenth-century material is not a primitive version of the same thing. It is a different religious structure that later can be re-used.

11. What is Aokigahara itself doing in the thirteenth century?

Physically, the forest is there. By 1200, the Jōgan lava flow is more than three centuries old. The later Saiko/Shōji lake configuration already exists. The lava forest is growing over rough basalt, with caves, moss, shallow soil, and difficult footing.

But source-wise, Aokigahara itself is mostly background. The named thirteenth-century evidence clusters at Hitoana and the Fuji sacred complex, not at the Saiko/Aokigahara forest interior.

So the correct sentence is:

In the thirteenth century, Aokigahara exists as part of the Fuji lava-foot environment, but the surviving cultural record names the cave and mountain system more clearly than the forest.

That is why any answer pretending to give a rich thirteenth-century Aokigahara social history would be overclaiming.

12. The later *Fuji no Hitoana Sōshi* proves the 1203 story had afterlife

The 1203 Hitoana episode did not just sit inert in *Azuma Kagami*. It became literary/religious material.

Kotobank's entry on Fuji no Hitoana Sōshi says it is an otogizōshi tale, probably already formed by the fifteenth century because a 1527 diary entry mentions “fuji no hitoana no monogatari”. It says the work uses the *Azuma Kagami* entries about cave explorations and turns them into a story of otherworld visitation and hell-circuit narrative, probably used in Fuji faith preaching. ([kotobank.jp](https://kotobank.jp/word/%E5%AF%8C%E5%A3%AB%E3%81%AE%E4%BA%BA%E7%A9%B4%E8%8D%89%E5%AD%90-1585962?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

NDL's bibliographic record for a 1661 printed *Fuji no Hitoana Sōshi* says the story has Nitta Shiro Tadatsuna enter Hitoana, be guided by Fuji Sengen Daigongen through hell and paradise, receive a scroll, and return with a warning about speaking of what he saw. ([ndlsearch.ndl.go.jp](https://ndlsearch.ndl.go.jp/books/R100000002-I000007314996?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This matters because it shows how the 1203 cave report was metabolised. It was not remembered merely as exploration. It became underworld literature.

But again, that afterlife is later than the thirteenth century. Use it as reception-history, not as direct 1203 evidence.

13. The thirteenth-century core is not “forest”; it is “cave”

This is the cleanest formulation.

The later Aokigahara discourse is arboreal: trees, roots, moss, bodies lost in woods, forest paths, no return.

The thirteenth-century Fuji death/otherworld discourse is speleological: cave, darkness, bats, subterranean river, supernatural sight, sudden death, divine residence.

So the century's grammar is:

穴, not 樹海. Cave, not tree sea. Underworld opening, not forest maze.

That is a major historical distinction.

14. The 1203 event as “controlled transgression”

The Hitoana entry is also politically interesting.

Tadatsune does not enter because he is a pilgrim seeking salvation or a despairing person seeking death. He enters because the shogun orders an exploration during a hunting event. That gives the episode a worldly, warrior-aristocratic frame.

So the structure is:

elite command; warrior obedience; penetration of forbidden terrain; failure of normal military masculinity before sacred geography; return with supernatural knowledge.

This is not a suicide script. It is a Kamakura warrior encounter with a sacred limit.

That is probably the deepest social meaning of the source: the military regime can command entry into terrain, but cannot master the otherworld inside Fuji.

15. How this relates to Japanese people/discourse at the deepest level

For the thirteenth century, the key Japanese cultural relation is not “the forest attracts suicidal people”. It is:

Fuji’s hidden spaces are not inert nature. They are inhabited, morally charged, and dangerous to penetrate.

This is a wider medieval Japanese pattern: mountains, caves, springs and remote interiors are not neutral scenic objects. They are contact zones with kami, buddhas, spirits, hells, Pure Lands, or taboo forces. Hitoana is a precise Fuji example.

Aokigahara later inherits some of this because it is not a normal forest. It sits on Fuji lava, near caves, beside old lake-worlds, under a mountain already saturated with sacred fear.

But the thirteenth-century “death” is contact with the sacred, not modern self-destruction.

16. The decisive negative finding

No reliable accessible thirteenth-century material I found says:

Aokigahara was used for suicide; Aokigahara was a corpse forest; Aokigahara was an ubasute place; people travelled there to disappear; locals treated the forest as a death destination; the phrase “樹海” had the later modern suicide meaning.

So the answer must not pretend otherwise.

The thirteenth century gives underworld cave genealogy, not suicide-site genealogy.

17. What the thirteenth century contributes to the later Aokigahara myth

It contributes three elements.

First, Fuji lava interiors can be otherworld gates. Hitoana proves that in a thirteenth-century text. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp] (https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/fujisan/11ti2b0000001br3.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Second, entry can be fatal or spiritually dangerous. Tadatsune’s retainers die; the cave is not ordinary terrain. ([kotobank.jp] (https://kotobank.jp/word/%E6%96%B0%E7%94%B0%E5%BF%A0%E5%B8%B8-1385558?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Third, the hidden interior is narratable. The 1203 episode later becomes **Hitoana Sōshi**, a preaching/otherworld tale. ([kotobank.jp] (https://kotobank.jp/word/%E5%AF%8C%E5%A3%AB%E3%81%AE%E4%BA%BA%E7%A9%B4%E8%8D%89%E5%AD%90-1585962?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Those are deep preconditions. They do not explain modern suicide by themselves. But they show why Fuji's hidden interiors could carry more weight than mere geography.

18. The exact thirteenth-century source hierarchy

For 1200—1299, the sources rank like this.

1. **Azuma Kagami**, 1203 Hitoana episode — the core source. Preserved/quoted in official cultural-property summaries and encyclopaedic entries; it gives the cave, bats, underground river, deaths, return, and divine-residence interpretation. ([pref.shizuoka.jp] (https://www.pref.shizuoka.jp/kankosports/bunkageijutsu/bunkazai/1002825/1041003/1041889/1004987/1021574.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))
2. Fujinomiya official Hitoana Fuji-kō site page — best concise official interpretation: **Azuma Kagami** → Hitoana as Asama Daibosatsu's residence → later Hitoana Sōshi and Fuji-kō spread. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp] (https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/fujisan/11ti2b0000001br3.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))
3. Yamanashi/Fuji World Heritage faith-history pages — best broader frame: Fuji shifts from eruption-fear/distant worship into ascetic mountain practice, with lay ascent developing later. ([fujisan-whc.jp] (https://www.fujisan-whc.jp/about/feature.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))
4. **Fuji no Hitoana Sōshi** reception materials — not thirteenth-century evidence directly, but proof that the 1203 episode became a major medieval/early modern underworld narrative. ([kotobank.jp] (https://kotobank.jp/word/%E5%AF%8C%E5%A3%AB%E3%81%AE%E4%BA%BA%E7%A9%B4%E8%8D%89%E5%AD%90-1585962?utm_source=chatgpt.com))
5. Aokigahara geological/lake background — necessary physical setting, but not thirteenth-century cultural evidence for suicide or death. Use only as background.

Final thirteenth-century thesis

In the thirteenth century, Aokigahara is not yet the death forest. It is not yet the “sea of trees” as modern Japanese discourse knows it. The forest exists physically, but the surviving cultural record gives the power to Fuji's cave-world, especially Hitoana.

The century's decisive event is the 1203 **Azuma Kagami** Hitoana exploration: a Kamakura warrior enters Fuji's lava cave under shogunal command, meets darkness, bats, an underground river, supernatural terror, deaths among his companions, and the cave's identification as the dwelling-place of Asama/Sengen divinity. That is the earliest strong documentary layer for Fuji's hidden interior as a sacred and deadly threshold.

So the precise answer is:

The thirteenth-century root of Aokigahara's later death-imaginary is not suicide. It is the medieval Fuji cave-underworld: the idea that entering Fuji's hidden lava interior means crossing into a space where ordinary human mastery fails, the divine is present, and return is uncertain.

Later Aokigahara will secularise and forest-translate that structure. The cave becomes the forest. Divine danger becomes psychological disappearance. Warrior descent becomes solitary entry. Otherworld river becomes no-return woodland. But in the thirteenth century itself, the grammar is still sacred,

not suicidal; cave, not tree sea; forbidden encounter, not self-erasure.

14th Century

Fourteenth century only — 1300—1399 — gives a very specific answer:

Aokigahara itself is still culturally silent. Fuji is not.

That is the decisive distinction. In the fourteenth century, the later “suicide forest” does not exist as a recorded cultural object. The dominant record is not about entering Aokigahara; it is about ascending Fuji, organising routes, lodging pilgrims, and converting a formerly terrifying volcano into a climbable sacred mountain. The forest is physically there, but the named religious and social energy is concentrated on routes, lakes, shrines, Shugendō, lodging, and the summit.

So the fourteenth-century root is not “death forest”. It is:

from remote worship to managed ascent.

1. The forest exists, but the sources do not yet make it the protagonist

By 1300, Aokigahara had existed for roughly 430 years after the 864 Jōgan eruption. The old Seno-umi lake had already been split and partly buried by lava, producing the later Saiko/Shōjiko configuration and the lava ground on which the forest grew. Yamanashi’s guide describes the 864 Aokigahara lava flow as burying much of old Seno-umi and creating Saiko and Shōjiko; it also frames Aokigahara as a forest grown on that lava surface. ([pref.yamanashi.jp] (https://www.pref.yamanashi.jp/ebook/fujisan_guide2023/Japanese/pageindices/index9.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

But in fourteenth-century cultural terms, the forest is background terrain. It is not yet “樹海” as the later national death-symbol. It is the dark, rough, lava-grown north-western foot of Fuji, bordering the lake-world. The record we can actually stand on is about Fuji worship, not Aokigahara suicide.

That absence is itself evidence. If Aokigahara had already been a famous fourteenth-century suicide/death destination, we would expect some trace in pilgrimage, shrine, road, temple, or later local-historical summaries. The accessible record instead points to Fuji ascent and sacred-route formation.

2. The fourteenth-century transformation: Fuji becomes climbable for non-specialists

The single most important fourteenth-century development is that Fuji worship moves beyond elite ascetics and becomes more accessible to lay believers.

The Fujisan World Heritage Center says that from the fourteenth century onward, lay believers called 道者 appeared among ordinary people, climbing Fuji in the hope of rebirth in the Pure Land; it also says 御師 — religious guides/lodging-providers — became active in guiding and caring for them. ([fujisan-whc.jp] (https://www.fujisan-whc.jp/about/feature.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is the century’s deep psychological fact.

The relevant emotional grammar is not “I want to vanish into the trees.” It is:

I want salvation. I want rebirth. I climb the sacred mountain. I move through a guided religious route.

That is a completely different death relation from modern Aokigahara. Fourteenth-century death is about afterlife hope, not private disappearance.

3. The word-world is 道者, 御師, 宿坊 — not 樹海

The fourteenth-century vocabulary matters.

The later Aokigahara world is dominated by words like 樹海, 自殺, 行方不明, 発見, 声かけ, パトロール.

The fourteenth-century Fuji world is dominated by:

道者 — pilgrims/believers; 御師 — guides, ritual mediators, lodging-providers; 宿坊 — pilgrim lodgings; 登 — devotional ascent; 極淨土 — Pure Land rebirth; 修験 — mountain ascetic practice.

This matters because the fourteenth-century structure is still social. Pilgrims are not trying to become unfindable. They are being guided, housed, ritually handled, and placed inside a recognised salvation route.

4. Late fourteenth century: Yoshida route infrastructure emerges

The north-side Yoshida route is crucial because it is the Fuji-access system geographically closest to the later Aokigahara/Saiko/Kawaguchiko world.

Fujiyoshida's official World Heritage page says the Yoshida-guchi climbing route starts at Kitaguchi Hongū Fuji Sengen Shrine and aims for the summit; by the late fourteenth century, lodgings for pilgrims had begun to appear, and facilities for large numbers of climbers were being prepared. ([city.fujiyoshida.yamanashi.jp](https://www.city.fujiyoshida.yamanashi.jp/page/1095.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is a hard fourteenth-century hinge. By the late 1300s, Fuji is no longer only a distant sacred cone or an ascetic mountain. It is becoming an organised climb.

That matters for Aokigahara because it tells us what “entering Fuji nature” meant in this century. It meant:

route; guide; lodging; ascent; summit; religious goal; return.

Not lone disappearance.

5. The north-foot is moving towards managed pilgrimage, not anti-social exit

This is the key inversion.

The later Aokigahara script is:

road → forest edge → off-path → disappearance.

The late-fourteenth-century Yoshida script is:

shrine → lodging → guide → climbing route → summit → salvation/rebirth.

That is why the fourteenth century is so important. It gives the opposite of the modern suicide-forest structure. It gives managed entry into sacred nature, not unmanaged exit from society.

The forest will later become powerful precisely because it sits off that script. But in the fourteenth century, the script itself is still being built.

6. Southern Fuji: Murayama Shugendō is already gathering ascetics in the early 1300s

The southern side gives the other major fourteenth-century religious infrastructure.

Fujinomiya's page on the Ōmiya/Murayama route says that by the early fourteenth century, Shugendō practitioners training on Fuji are thought to have gathered around Murayama as a base. It also says that in the medieval period, many pilgrims climbed under the guidance of ascetics and 先達; later visual materials such as the Fuji Mandala show pilgrims ascending from the Ōmiya/Murayama route. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/fujisan/11ti2b0000001q06.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is huge because it means that, in the early fourteenth century, Fuji is being institutionalised from below by ascetic bases. The mountain is not a blank wilderness. It is being organised by religious specialists.

Again, this cuts against later Aokigahara mythology. The medieval sacred mountain is not “go in and get lost.” It is “enter through the proper religious gate.”

7. Fourteenth-century Fuji is still a Buddhist-Shugendō mountain

Fujinomiya's broader faith-history page says that once eruptions had quietened from around the twelfth century, Fuji became a Shugendō mountain, combining older Japanese mountain worship with esoteric Buddhism and Daoist/immortality currents. The summit was understood, through honji-suijaku thought, as a Buddhist world or a place where Buddhist beings appeared in kami form. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001611.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is another important correction. The fourteenth-century Fuji world is not yet Edo-period Fuji-kō in the full sense, and it is not modern sightseeing. It is still strongly Buddhist-Shugendō.

So the death relation is Buddhist. People climb with concern for rebirth, salvation, karmic purification, and access to a sacred summit. The later forest of self-erasure is not present.

8. 1384: the Subashiri hanging Buddha is the century's sharpest material object

The most precise fourteenth-century artefact is the 1384 kakebotoke / 懸仏 from the Subashiri route.

Yamanashi tourism material says a hanging Buddha dated 1384 was found along the Subashiri route, and describes it as the oldest surviving example of an offering to Fuji. ([yamanashi-kankou.jp](https://www.yamanashi-kankou.jp/kankou/spot/wh_1-4.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com)) Fuji-san World Heritage Center likewise notes that a kakebotoke with a 1384 inscription was excavated from the seventh station area of the Subashiri route. ([fujisan-whc.jp](https://www.fujisan-whc.jp/about/parts/index.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is one of the most important pieces of evidence because it is not just a later story about pilgrimage. It is a material devotional deposit.

What does it say?

It says that by 1384, someone was making or depositing Buddhist-style votive material on Fuji's climbing route. The mountain was not merely seen; it was offered to. It had become a ritual field where objects, bodies and hopes were placed into a sacred vertical route.

Again, the direction is vertical ascent, not horizontal forest disappearance.

9. 1384 also tells us where the named energy is not

The kakebotoke was from the Subashiri route, not Aokigahara. That matters.

The fourteenth-century evidence clusters around:

Subashiri route; Yoshida route; Murayama route; Kitaguchi Hongū Fuji Sengen Shrine; Murayama ascetic base; pilgrim lodging; mountain ascent.

It does not cluster around Aokigahara as a named death-place.

This is why a strict fourteenth-century answer cannot be “Aokigahara was already death-haunted.” The evidence says the opposite: the sacred infrastructure is being built around ways up Fuji, not ways into the forest.

10. The Aokigahara lake-margin is still present, but thinly documented for this century

Saiko, Shōji and Motosu are physically there. The lava flow had already split the old lake system centuries earlier. These lakes will later become crucial in Fuji-kō's Inner Eight Seas pilgrimage world, and modern World Heritage material identifies Shōji and Motosu as Inner Eight Seas pilgrimage sites for Fuji-kō believers. ([fujisan-whc.jp](https://www.fujisan-whc.jp/about/parts/index.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

But we have to be exact: that does not prove a named fourteenth-century Aokigahara lake pilgrimage system in the same form. The strong documentary link to Kakugyō's water-practice lake list comes in 1580, outside this century. ([town.minobu.lg.jp](https://www.town.minobu.lg.jp/bunka/rekishi/2023-1206-1036-32.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So for the fourteenth century, the safest formulation is:

The Saiko—Shōji—Motosu lake world existed beside Aokigahara, but the clearly evidenced fourteenth-century religious energy is centred on Fuji ascent routes, not on Aokigahara or the later Inner Eight Seas system.

That restraint matters. Otherwise we contaminate the century with later Fuji-kō material.

11. What “death” means in the fourteenth century

This is the deepest point.

Fourteenth-century Fuji is absolutely death-adjacent, but not in the Aokigahara way.

The World Heritage Center says lay believers from the fourteenth century climbed hoping for 極浄土への往生 — rebirth in the Pure Land. ([fujisan-whc.jp](https://www.fujisan-whc.jp/about/feature.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That is death-related, but it is not suicide. It is not self-erasure. It is not hiding the body. It is a religious technology for facing death through salvation.

So the fourteenth-century death grammar is:

death as karmic problem; death as afterlife transition; mountain ascent as salvation route; summit as Buddhist/kami realm; pilgrimage as embodied hope for rebirth.

Modern Aokigahara death grammar is:

death as exit; forest as concealment; body as unfindable; social self as erased; others as spared or abandoned.

Those are profoundly different structures.

12. Fourteenth-century “otherworld” is above, not inside

This is the cleanest conceptual distinction.

In modern Aokigahara, the otherworld is inward: you enter the trees, the forest closes, the path is lost, the person disappears.

In fourteenth-century Fuji, the otherworld is upward: you climb from the foot through a route system to a summit understood as sacred/Buddhist/kami space. Fujinomiya’s faith-history page says the summit was recognised as a Buddhist world or as a place where Buddhas appeared as kami.

([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001611.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So the directionality is different:

fourteenth century: ascent to salvation; twentieth century: lateral entry into disappearance.

This is not a small difference. It is the whole history.

13. The century’s social form: guided, housed, collective

Fourteenth-century Fuji ascent is not primarily solitary.

The sources repeatedly imply mediation: 道者, 御師, 宿坊, 修験者, 先達. The Fujisan World Heritage Center says ordinary believers called 道者 appeared from the fourteenth century, while 御師 guided and cared for them. ([fujisan-whc.jp](https://www.fujisan-whc.jp/about/feature.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com)) Fujiyoshida says pilgrim lodgings began to appear on the Yoshida route by the late fourteenth century. ([city.fujiyoshida.yamanashi.jp](https://www.city.fujiyoshida.yamanashi.jp/page/1095.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com)) Fujinomiya says pilgrims climbed under the guidance of ascetics and sendatsu in the medieval period. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/fujisan/11ti2b0000001q06.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is decisive.

The later Aokigahara image is solitary. The fourteenth-century Fuji ascent is mediated and collective. The person is not trying to drop out of society. They are entering a religious society of movement.

14. The local north-foot settlement layer is still mostly just outside the century

For Shōji, Motosu, Saiko, and the Kuisiki world, our clearest local documentary hooks begin in the sixteenth century: 1545 Motosu in diplomatic travel, 1554 Shōji mortuary record, 1577 Shōji commercial

exemption, 1597 Saiko/Nishi-no-umi runaway-peasant recall. Those are valuable, but notfourteenth-century evidence.

So the honest fourteenth-century answer must say:

For Aokigahara-adjacent village life specifically, the open source record is much thinner in 1300—1399 than in 1500—1599. The century's solid evidence is Fuji ascent infrastructure, not Aokigahara village documentation.

That is not a weakness. It is what the source horizon says.

15. What Aokigahara is, by negative reconstruction

If we reconstruct only what is safe:

By the fourteenth century, Aokigahara is:

a several-hundred-year-old lava forest; beside the already-formed Saiko/Shōjiko lake system; near the north-western Fuji foot; outside the main named ascent infrastructure; physically difficult, forested, cave/lava terrain; not yet a documented suicide place; not yet a documented national “tree sea” death-image.

Its cultural status is best described as peripheral sacred terrain: not central enough to dominate records, but inside the larger Fuji world that is becoming intensely religiously organised.

16. What the fourteenth century contributes to later Aokigahara

It contributes contrast, not direct origin.

Later Aokigahara takes the old Fuji pattern of leaving ordinary space and inverts it.

Fourteenth-century pattern:

leave ordinary life; enter guided pilgrimage; climb; seek salvation/rebirth; return or complete religious merit.

Modern Aokigahara pattern:

leave ordinary life; avoid guidance; enter unguided forest; seek disappearance; do not return.

The modern forest is powerful partly because it is an anti-pilgrimage: the movement into Fuji's sacred nature remains, but the salvific structure collapses.

17. The best fourteenth-century source hierarchy

For this century, the ranked source base is:

1. Yoshida-guchi route / late-fourteenth-century lodgings. Best north-foot evidence for organised pilgrimage infrastructure emerging near the later Aokigahara world.

([city.fujiyoshida.yamanashi.jp] (https://www.city.fujiyoshida.yamanashi.jp/page/1095.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

2. Fujisan World Heritage Center on fourteenth-century 道者 and 御師. Best concise statement that ordinary believers appear from the fourteenth century, climbing for Pure Land rebirth, with guides/caretakers active. ([fujisan-whc.jp] (https://www.fujisan-whc.jp/about/feature.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

atgpt.com))

3. Subashiri 1384 kakebotoke. Best material object from the century: a dated Buddhist offering to Fuji. ([yamanashi-kankou.jp] (https://www.yamanashi-kankou.jp/kankou/spot/wh_1-4.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

4. Murayama route early-fourteenth-century Shugendō gathering. Best evidence for the southern ascetic base and medieval guided pilgrimage pattern. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp] (https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/fujisan/11ti2b0000001q06.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

5. Fujinomiya faith-history page on summit Buddhist/kami world and route formation. Best synthesis of the religious directionality: Fuji as Shugendō mountain, summit as Buddhist/kami realm, routes opening in the fourteenth–fifteenth centuries. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp] (https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001611.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

6. Geological/lake formation material. Necessary background for Aokigahara’s physical existence, but not evidence of fourteenth-century death discourse. ([pref.yamanashi.jp] (https://www.pref.yamanashi.jp/ebook/fujisan_guide2023/Japanese/pageindices/index9.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Final fourteenth-century thesis

In the fourteenth century, Aokigahara is not a suicide forest and not yet the main object of cultural meaning. It is the forested lava margin of a Fuji world whose central transformation is the rise of organised devotional ascent.

The century’s key facts are: ordinary believers called 道者 begin climbing Fuji for Pure Land rebirth; 御師 and 宿坊 begin to support them; the Yoshida route develops pilgrim lodging by the late fourteenth century; Murayama gathers ascetics by the early fourteenth century; and the 1384 Subashiri kakebotoke proves devotional offering on Fuji routes. The “death” present in this century is not self-erasure but salvation: death faced through rebirth, Buddhist-kami summit cosmology, and embodied ascent.

So the exact answer is:

Fourteenth-century Fuji gives ascent, not disappearance. It gives Pure Land hope, not quiet self-erasure. It gives guided pilgrimage, not solitary vanishing. Aokigahara’s later power comes partly from inverting that medieval structure: the old movement out of ordinary life remains, but the route, guide, lodging, summit and salvation are removed, leaving only entry into hard nature and non-return.

15th Century

Fifteenth century only — 1400—1499 — gives a hard, almost anti-climactic but important answer:

Aokigahara is not yet a suicide forest, not yet a “sea of trees” discourse-object in the modern sense, and not yet the protagonist of its own cultural history. In the fifteenth century, the real historical object is Fuji’s north-western foot as a threshold zone between mountain worship, lake-edge settlement, pilgrimage infrastructure, Shugendō, roads, and marginal forest/lava terrain.

The deepest fifteenth-century insight is this:

Before Aokigahara became a forest of disappearance, Fuji became a mountain of ascent.

That is the axis of the century. The fifteenth-century world is not “enter the forest and vanish” ; it is “approach Fuji, lodge, purify, ascend, worship, return” .

1. The first rule: do not smuggle the twentieth century backwards

For 1400—1499, I found no reliable evidence that Aokigahara was a recognised suicide site, a literary death-place, or a public “no-return” destination. The later association with suicide belongs to the twentieth-century chain; even the strongest pre-Matsumoto candidate is the 1928 Shōjiko double-suicide layer, not the fifteenth century. So the honest fifteenth-century answer has to be built from absence plus adjacent structures.

That absence is not empty. It tells us what Aokigahara was *not* yet. It was not yet a media object. It was not yet a police/clinical object. It was not yet a dark-tourist object. It was not yet Matsumoto’s vanishing-stage. It was a difficult lava forest sitting beside lake settlements and Fuji religious routes.

2. The physical forest existed, but the cultural centre was not the forest

By 1400, the Aokigahara lava forest had existed for more than five centuries after the 864 Jōgan eruption. The modern JTB resource describes the Aokigahara lava flow as having devastated Fuji’s north-west foot and then allowed a new forest to regenerate on thin soil over cooled lava, creating the distinctive moss, roots, conifers and lava-cave ecology. That physical world is already there in the fifteenth century. But the available fifteenth-century cultural evidence does not treat “Aokigahara” as the central named symbolic object. It treats Fuji, its routes, its shrines, its caves, its lakes, and its pilgrim infrastructure as the meaningful objects.
([tabi.jtb.or.jp](https://tabi.jtb.or.jp/res/190572-?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So: the forest is physically mature but culturally backgrounded.

That is crucial. The later imagination makes the trees central. The fifteenth century still makes Fuji central.

3. The fifteenth-century transformation: Fuji becomes mass-climbable

The strongest fifteenth-century fact is the spread and institutionalisation of Fuji ascent.

Fujinomiya's official history says that from around the twelfth century, Fuji's eruptions quietened and the mountain changed from a distant deity-mountain into a Shugendō training mountain. It then says that in the fifteenth to sixteenth centuries, faith-ascent by groups guided by religious practitioners became widespread, and that the climbing routes were opened in roughly the fourteenth to late fifteenth centuries; lodging facilities for pilgrims also began to appear. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001611.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That means the fifteenth-century “deep structure” is not death. It is access.

Fuji is being converted from a mountain to be worshipped from below into a mountain ordinary people can approach, climb, and ritually experience.

This is the absolute opposite of Aokigahara's later meaning. Later: one enters nature to leave society. Fifteenth century: one enters sacred nature through organised religious infrastructure.

4. The north-side route: 吉田口 is being prepared for mass pilgrimage

The north-side evidence matters because it is geographically closer to the Aokigahara/Fuji Five Lakes world than the southern Murayama route.

Fujiyoshida's official World Heritage page says the Yoshida ascent route / 吉田口登山道 starts at Kitaguchi Hongū Fuji Sengen Shrine and goes to the summit; by the late fourteenth century, lodging for pilgrims had begun to appear, and the infrastructure for large numbers of climbers developed. Yamanashi's official World Heritage material says essentially the same: by the late fourteenth century, shukubō were appearing for pilgrims and facilities were being prepared for many people to climb. ([city.fujiyoshida.yamanashi.jp](https://www.city.fujiyoshida.yamanashi.jp/page/1095.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That is slightly earlier than the fifteenth century, but it is the immediate inherited condition of the fifteenth century. In 1400—1499, the north foot is no longer just wild approach-ground. It is becoming pilgrimage logistics: shrine, route, lodging, ascent, guides, religious traffic.

So the Aokigahara-adjacent world is being pulled into a Fuji ascent economy, not into a forest-death economy.

5. The southern religious centre: Murayama is the big fifteenth-century Fuji institution

For the fifteenth century, Murayama is more documentarily visible than Aokigahara.

Murayama Sengen Shrine / Murayama Kōbōji was the centre of Fuji Shugendō. Fujinomiya's official page says Murayama had become a centre of Fuji mountain practice, that Dōkō of Shōgo-in visited in 1486, and that by this period Murayama seems to have become part of the Honzan-ha Shugendō network; by the early Sengoku period, under Imagawa patronage, religious practitioners and pilgrims gathered and lodging houses or temple quarters stood around it. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001615.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This matters because fifteenth-century Fuji is institutionally being organised through Shugendō houses, guides, lodging, temple-shrine complexes and ascent practice.

Aokigahara is not the named centre. Murayama is.

That tells us how fifteenth-century religious space worked: people did not simply wander into “nature” for private dissolution. They passed through religious nodes.

6. 1486: Dōkō's passage is the century's best elite witness

The key fifteenth-century witness is Dōkō / 道興, Shōgo-in monzeki, born 1430 and died 1501. He travelled from Kyoto in 1486 and wrote the travel work 廻国記 / Kaikoku Zakki. Kotobank describes the text as a late-Muromachi travel record from 1486–1487, mixing brief entries with waka, haikai, Chinese poems and linked verse. It also notes that the text is valuable for understanding religious-mountain movement, even though it is literary as much as documentary.

([kotobank.jp](https://kotobank.jp/word/%E9%81%93%E8%88%88-1188858?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

The Fujinomiya source says Dōkō visited Murayama in Bunmei 18 / 1486. That visit matters because Dōkō was not a random tourist. He was a high-status Shōgo-in figure moving through a network of sacred mountains, Shugendō institutions and poetic geography.

([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001615.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is the closest thing to a fifteenth-century “deep perspective”: not a suicide account, not a local ghost tale, but an elite Shugendō/literary traveller encountering Fuji's religious landscape.

The emotional grammar is not horror. It is pilgrimage, poetry, route, shrine, mountain, autumn, snow, sacred ascent.

7. 1486 also shows what is *not* happening

This is important. Dōkō's world gives us sacred Fuji, Murayama, travel poetry and mountain religious movement. It does not give us Aokigahara as suicide forest.

That absence is not proof that nobody ever died or got lost in the lava forest. Of course people could die in mountain/forest terrain. But it means there is no fifteenth-century evidence of a socially recognised Aokigahara death-destination comparable to the modern one.

The cultural focus is elsewhere: Murayama, ascent, shrine-temple complexes, Shugendō, route-making.

8. The fifteenth-century image-system: Fuji Mandala, not Aokigahara deathscape

The key visual object is the Fuji Mandala / 富士曼荼羅 tradition.

The national cultural-property database describes the important 絹本著色富士曼荼羅図 as a Muromachi-period painting showing the scene of Fuji ascent worship: pilgrims visiting Fuji Hongū Sengen Taisha, Murayama Sengen Shrine, halls and shrines at the foot, and then ascending Fuji; Buddhas and bodhisattvas appear at the summit, showing the syncretic Shinto-Buddhist belief structure. The database says it is important as a precursor to later pilgrimage mandalas and that the depicted shrine layout gives a terminus before Tokugawa Ieyasu's 1604 reconstruction.

([kunishitei.bunka.go.jp](https://kunishitei.bunka.go.jp/heritage/detail/201/2482?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Fujinomiya's page identifies the same mandala as a late-Muromachi work, associated with the Kanō school, and says it depicts pilgrims visiting foot-shrines and then climbing Fuji, with Buddhist figures at the summit. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001611.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is essential. The fifteenth-century/late-Muromachi visual imagination of Fuji is not a forest that swallows people. It is a vertical sacred itinerary:

foot shrine → Murayama → halls → ascent → summit → buddhas.

Modern Aokigahara is horizontal disappearance. Fifteenth-century Fuji mandala is vertical revelation.

9. The forest is therefore a periphery to an ascent diagram

If you put the mandala logic together with the route/lodging evidence, Aokigahara's position in the fifteenth century becomes clearer.

It is not absent because it does not physically exist. It is absent because it is not the focal sacred diagram. The sacred diagram is Fuji as mountain-body. The relevant movement is upwards.

Aokigahara sits on the north-west foot, beside the lake system, but the central cultural image is not “enter the trees”. It is “ascend the mountain”.

That means the later death-image did not grow from a fifteenth-century forest cult. It grew much later by detaching the forest from the ascent system and making the horizontal entry into trees itself the meaningful act.

10. The roads and lake settlements: documentary visibility is weaker for the fifteenth century

For the north-west foot specifically — Shōji, Motosu, Saiko/Nishi-no-umi, Kuisiki — the hard open-web documentary record becomes much clearer in the sixteenth century, not the fifteenth.

For example, Motosu appears concretely in 1545 in *Kōhokusai-ki*, as a stop in Takeda—Imagawa—Hōjō diplomacy; Shōji appears in 1554 in a mortuary record and 1577 in a Takeda document;

Saiko/Nishi-no-umi appears in a 1597 document about recalling runaway peasants. These are not fifteenth-century facts, so I am not using them as fifteenth-century proof. I'm using them as a warning: the source horizon for the Aokigahara-adjacent villages becomes much more visible only just after the fifteenth century. ([kotobank.jp] (https://kotobank.jp/word/%E6%9C%AC%E6%A0%96%E9%83%B7-3057457?utm_source=chatgpt.com)))

That means we have to be disciplined. For 1400—1499, we can say the region is almost certainly part of the older road/lake/mountain world, but the explicit local documentary hooks available in open sources mostly begin later.

So the most precise statement is:

The fifteenth century gives strong Fuji-pilgrimage evidence, but thinner Aokigahara-village evidence.

11. The likely road-world: Naka-michi exists as the later spine, but fifteenth-century proof is thin

The Naka-michi Ōkan / 中道往還 later runs from Kōfu south through the Kuisiki region, past Shōji and to Motosu, linking Kai and Suruga. Kotobank describes its route clearly: through Ubaguchi, Furuseki, over Anan-zaka, with Lake Shōji to the side, reaching Motosu.

([kotobank.jp] (https://kotobank.jp/word/%E4%B8%AD%E9%81%93%E5%BE%80%E9%82%84-1382467?utm_source=chatgpt.com)))

For the fifteenth century specifically, the open sources I found do not give a neat dated 1400s Aokigahara road document. But structurally, by the sixteenth century this corridor is already strategic. That makes it likely the road-world was already forming earlier, but the disciplined claim

is weaker:

By the fifteenth century, Fuji ascent routes and lodging are documentarily visible; the Aokigahara-adjacent Kai—Suruga road system is best documented from the following century.

That matters because the fifteenth-century answer should not pretend certainty where the source record thins.

12. The wrong model: “wilderness outside society”

The fifteenth-century material does not support “Aokigahara as empty cursed wilderness” .

Even where Aokigahara itself is not richly named, the surrounding Fuji world is visibly structured by:

pilgrimage routes; lodging for pilgrims; Shugendō institutions; Murayama temple-shrine complexes; elite religious travel; visual mandalas of ascent; shrines and foot-of-mountain ritual nodes.

The forest may have been difficult, dark, and locally dangerous. But the wider region is not outside society. It is being ritually and logistically organised.

13. The psychological register of the fifteenth century

This is the key contrast.

The modern Aokigahara register is:

I want to disappear. I want not to be found. I want to exit the human ledger. The forest absorbs me.

The fifteenth-century Fuji register is:

I want to approach the sacred mountain. I pass through religious nodes. I purify and ascend. The mountain transforms me.

These are not the same. But they share one deep structure: leaving ordinary space for a charged natural threshold.

That is the continuity. The discontinuity is the outcome.

Fifteenth century: return transformed. Twentieth century: vanish unreturned.

14. The “death” layer in the fifteenth century is not Aokigahara suicide

If we are strict, the fifteenth-century death layer is mostly indirect.

Fuji is a sacred mountain under Buddhist-Shinto syncretic reading; its summit can be figured with buddhas and bodhisattvas in mandala imagery. Ascetic practice and Shugendō always involve bodily danger, suffering and symbolic death/rebirth. But I found no fifteenth-century source making Aokigahara itself into a chosen death-place.

So the phrase should be:

fifteenth-century death-adjacency = sacred mountain ordeal, not forest self-erasure.

That is the cleanest possible distinction.

15. What the fifteenth century contributes to the later Aokigahara myth

It contributes five ingredients, but not the myth itself.

First, Fuji is no longer only distant deity; it is approached and climbed. This creates the habit of entering dangerous Fuji nature for transformation. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001611.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Second, routes and lodgings create managed access. Sacred nature becomes reachable through human systems. ([city.fujiyoshida.yamanashi.jp](https://www.city.fujiyoshida.yamanashi.jp/page/1095.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Third, Murayama establishes a powerful Shugendō frame. Fuji is interpreted through guide-priests, temple-shrine complexes, halls, practices and ascent. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001615.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Fourth, visual mandala culture turns Fuji into an itinerary-image. The mountain is mapped spiritually: foot, shrine, ascent, summit, Buddhist world. ([kunishitei.bunka.go.jp](https://kunishitei.bunka.go.jp/heritage/detail/201/2482?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Fifth, Aokigahara remains background terrain. Its later charge partly comes from being the non-itinerary zone: not the shrine path, not the guided ascent, not the return route — later it becomes meaningful precisely as the place off the script.

That last point is the most important.

The fifteenth century gives Fuji a script. The later suicide forest is powerful because it is the anti-script.

16. Century-specific source hierarchy

For 1400—1499, the sources rank like this.

1. Dōkō's *Kaikoku Zakki* / 1486 Murayama visit. Best single fifteenth-century witness to Fuji's sacred-travel world. It gives elite Shugendō/literary movement through Fuji-Murayama, not Aokigahara death. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001615.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))
2. Murayama Sengen Shrine / Kōbōji history. Best institutional source for fifteenth-century Fuji Shugendō: Murayama as centre, Dōkō's 1486 visit, likely Honzan-ha absorption, later Sengoku patronage. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001615.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))
3. Yoshida route / shukubō evidence. Best north-side route evidence: by late fourteenth century lodgings appear and infrastructure for mass ascent develops into the fifteenth-century world. ([city.fujiyoshida.yamanashi.jp](https://www.city.fujiyoshida.yamanashi.jp/page/1095.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))
4. Fuji Mandala tradition. Best visual source-family for late-Muromachi Fuji: ascent, syncretic shrine-temple practice, summit Buddhism, pilgrimage itinerary. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001611.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))
5. Later place-name entries for Shōji/Motosu/Saiko/Kuisiki. Useful only as control evidence showing that the Aokigahara-adjacent villages become explicit in sixteenth-century documents; not enough to

fill the fifteenth century with invented detail. ([kotobank.jp](https://kotobank.jp/word/%E6%9C%AC%E6%A0%96%E9%83%B7-3057457?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Final fifteenth-century thesis

In the fifteenth century, Aokigahara is not yet the death forest. It is the dark, lava-grown north-western margin of a Fuji world whose main movement is not disappearance but ascent.

The named and visible fifteenth-century systems are Fuji Shugendō, Murayama, Dōkō's 1486 sacred travel, the development of pilgrim lodgings, the Yoshida ascent route, and the Fuji Mandala imagination of foot-shrine-to-summit ascent. The Aokigahara-adjacent lake/road villages are not yet richly exposed in the accessible fifteenth-century record; they become much clearer in sixteenth-century documents. So the honest answer is that the forest itself is still culturally peripheral, while Fuji's religious infrastructure is becoming central.

The deepest formulation is:

The fifteenth century does not create Aokigahara as a place to vanish. It creates Fuji as a place to approach.

That is the historical root. Later Aokigahara will invert that system. Instead of guided ascent, it becomes unguided entry. Instead of purification, erasure. Instead of pilgrimage infrastructure, anti-infrastructure. Instead of returning transformed, not returning at all.

16th Century

Sixteenth century only — 1500—1599 — gives a very different and much harder answer.

There is still no honest evidence for “Aokigahara as suicide forest”. The sixteenth-century material points somewhere else entirely: Aokigahara sits inside a Sengoku border-world of roads, lakes, military movement, poor mountain villages, wood/commerce privileges, Fuji asceticism, cave practice, water purification, and early Fuji-kō formation.

The modern death-forest is not there yet. But the century creates a deep precondition: Aokigahara’s surrounding world becomes a charged threshold between ordinary society and non-ordinary terrain — not for suicide, but for crossing, purification, military passage, hard subsistence, and religious ordeal.

1. The sixteenth-century object is not “青木ヶ原樹海” ; it is the Fuji north-west foot

For this century, the wrong move is to search for the later object, “青木ヶ原樹海”, as if it already carried the same meaning. It does not. The sixteenth-century documentary object is a regional system:

九一色□; 精進 / Shōji; 本栖 / Motosu; 西湖 / Nishi-no-umi; 中道往還; 本栖城 and checkpoints; 富士登□; 長谷川角行; 人穴; 内八海.

Aokigahara is there physically — the lava forest is already several centuries old — but culturally it is not yet the protagonist. It is the forested, lava-ground medium between lake villages, roads and Fuji sacred geography.

That distinction matters. In the twentieth century, the forest becomes the named symbolic centre. In the sixteenth century, the named centres are villages, routes, lakes, border posts, caves and Fuji itself.

2. The local geography is not void; it is 九一色□

The key territorial unit is 九一色□ / Kuisiki-gō. Kotobank’s historical-place entry says this was the Sengoku-period name for the Fuji north-west foot and western Misaka mountain/Ashigawa valley region, including places such as 精進, 本栖 and 西湖. It lay on the strategic road between Kai and Suruga, and its residents included local warrior/landholder groups called 九一色衆. The entry also says the area was poor mountain land with bad conditions for grain production, so local livelihood was tied to timber cutting and woodwork; one etymology derives 九一色 from 工一色, associated with woodworkers. ([kotobank.jp] (<https://kotobank.jp/word/%E4%B9%9D%E4%B8%80%E8%89%B2%E9%83%B7-830407>))

That gives the first microscopic correction:

Sixteenth-century Aokigahara is not outside society. It is inside a marginal mountain society whose survival depends on wood, road movement, trade, military service and privilege.

This is a hard, poor, forest-adjacent world. But it is not empty.

3. The forest-edge is administratively and militarily legible

The same 九一色 source says the area was a 要衝 — a strategic point — on the road between Kai and Suruga. It identifies several sub-groups within the 九一色衆, including a Motosu-centred group and a Saiko-centred group. It also says the Takeda used the area’s local elites for border defence and

timber-service duties, granting privileges such as exemptions and free passage; after the Takeda collapse, Tokugawa Ieyasu confirmed privileges in 1582.

([kotobank.jp] (<https://kotobank.jp/word/%E4%B9%9D%E4%B8%80%E8%89%B2%E9%83%B7-830407>))

That is the inverse of later Aokigahara mythology.

Later image: a place beyond the ledger. Sixteenth-century evidence: a place heavily bound into the ledger — military road, border, privilege, duty, passage, exemption, service.

So the deep sixteenth-century irony is this:

The place that later symbolises disappearance was, in the Sengoku period, a place of surveillance, passage rights and state/military utility.

4. 1540: free-passage privilege around 西之海

The 九一色 entry gives a very specific early sixteenth-century document: a 1540 Takeda Nobutora document in the Saiko district archive recognising a free-passage privilege at the Furuseki checkpoint, with wording referring to 西之海. ([kotobank.jp] (<https://kotobank.jp/word/%E4%B9%9D%E4%B8%80%E8%89%B2%E9%83%B7-830407>))

This is small but important. 西之海 is the older name-world around Saiko. It shows the Aokigahara-adjacent lake settlement not as a death-stage, but as a community with documented road/checkpoint privilege.

In other words, sixteenth-century Saiko/Nishi-no-umi is not “mysterious forest edge”. It is a rights-bearing community in a controlled road system.

5. 1545: Motosu is a diplomatic/military node

The entry for 本栖 / Motosu-gō is one of the most concrete sixteenth-century sources. It says that in the *Kōhokusai-ki* entry for 1545, the place appears as 本須, when Takeda Harunobu’s close associate Komai Kōhokusai and Nukui/Tanba-no-kami stopped at Motosu en route to Suruga for alliance negotiations involving Takeda Harunobu, Imagawa Yoshimoto and Hōjō Ujiyasu. It also says the area was important as a transport point near the Kai—Suruga border on the Naka-michi route, with Motosu Castle and a barrier/checkpoint. ([kotobank.jp] (https://kotobank.jp/word/%E6%9C%AC%E6%A0%96%E9%83%B7-3057457?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That is a major find.

In 1545, the Aokigahara-adjacent Motosu world is not obscure. It is on a diplomatic-military route connecting the great Sengoku powers: Takeda, Imagawa, Hōjō.

So the sixteenth-century Aokigahara perimeter is not marginal in the sense of irrelevant. It is marginal in the sense of border-critical.

6. The 中道往還 is the spine

The 中道往還 / Naka-michi Ōkan is the spine of the sixteenth-century landscape. Kotobank describes it as one of the roads connecting Kai and Suruga, running from Kōfu southwards, over the Ubaguchi/Anan-saka area, passing with Lake Shōji to the side, and reaching Motosu. ([kotobank.jp] (https://kotobank.jp/word/%E4%B8%AD%E9%81%93%E5%BE%80%E9%82%84-1382467?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This road explains why the lake/forest edge mattered. It was not merely a scenic approach to Fuji. It was a military and trade route through mountain country.

A Fuji City source on the “salt road” says the Naka-michi route carried goods from Suruga into Kai, including fish and salt, and also had military value. It notes that Takeda Shingen used the roads into Suruga, including the Naka-michi route, during the 1568 invasion of Suruga.
([city.fuji.shizuoka.jp](https://www.city.fuji.shizuoka.jp/archive/kouhou/kiji/100630920_0488_13.htm?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That gives you the sixteenth-century sensory world more accurately than any “suicide forest” cliché: pack animals; salt and fish; border guards; mountain passes; military dispatches; diplomatic movement; timber service; lake settlements; checkpoint privilege.

That is the Aokigahara perimeter in the sixteenth century.

7. 1554: Shōji gives us a named local person and death-adjacent ritual — but not suicide

The entry for 精進 / Shōji-gō gives a precise 1554 item: according to 武田家日坏帳, on 21 April 1554, a 逆修供養 was performed for the son of Watanabe Kunaizaemon of Mukōyama-gō/Shōji village.
([kotobank.jp](https://kotobank.jp/word/%E7%B2%BE%E9%80%B2%E9%83%B7-3057455?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is death-adjacent, but not in the modern Aokigahara sense. 逆修供養 is a Buddhist memorial rite performed for oneself or someone before death, or as a pre-emptive/anticipatory memorial practice. The important point is not that Aokigahara was a suicide site. It is that the sixteenth-century local record contains ordinary religious-mortuary practice tied to named village people.

So: death appears in the sixteenth-century record as ritual memorial culture, not as self-erasure in the forest.

That is a crucial distinction.

8. 1577: Shōji is inside a commercial-privilege system

The same Shōji-gō source says a 1577 Takeda document refers to 精進 and grants exemptions from various duties to the nine Kuisiki villages, connected to commercial levies on their trade. It also says that in 1582 Tokugawa Ieyasu continued the Takeda-period exemption for 九一色諸商売役.
([kotobank.jp](https://kotobank.jp/word/%E7%B2%BE%E9%80%B2%E9%83%B7-3057455?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is one of the clearest pieces of evidence for the actual sixteenth-century social character of the place.

Aokigahara’s adjacent communities are not merely “remote villages”. They are commercial actors with trade privileges, exemptions and recognised legal-economic status.

The later fantasy says: leave society and vanish. The sixteenth-century document says: you are part of a taxed/exempted trade network.

9. 1582: collapse of Takeda power and Tokugawa reordering

The year 1582 is pivotal. The Kuisiki source says that after the Takeda collapse, the Kuisiki people helped Tokugawa Ieyasu enter Kai, and Ieyasu confirmed their privileges in the same year.
([kotobank.jp](https://kotobank.jp/word/%E4%B9%9D%E4%B8%80%E8%89%B2%E9%83%B7-830407))

Fujinomiya City's account of Ieyasu in the Tenshō period gives the wider frame: the Takeda were destroyed in 1582, Ieyasu came to rule Suruga and then acquired Kai and Shinano; road and lodging systems mattered for movement, transport, information and military movement; Ieyasu reworked the Naka-michi transport system. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/3010400000/p003594.html))

So the Aokigahara perimeter in the late sixteenth century is a transition zone between regimes: Takeda → Oda/Tokugawa → Ieyasu administrative consolidation.

This matters because it makes the landscape politically legible. Again, not outside society — deeply inside the process by which society is being rebuilt after Sengoku violence.

10. 1597: Saiko/Nishi-no-umi and the runaway-peasant document

The 西湖村 / Nishi-no-umi/Saiko village entry gives a sharp 1597 document. It says a letter dated 11 July 1597 refers to 九一色内西海, addressed to the village headman and peasants, ordering runaway peasants to be called back on condition of half tax. ([kotobank.jp](https://kotobank.jp/word/%E8%A5%BF%E6%B9%96%E6%9D%91-3041090?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is, psychologically, one of the most interesting sixteenth-century facts.

The modern Aokigahara fantasy is “disappear from the ledger”.

The 1597 Saiko document is literally about people who have left the village being ordered back into the ledger, with tax terms adjusted.

That is the opposite of the later myth.

It proves the late-sixteenth-century forest/lake community was not culturally organised around untraceable disappearance. It was organised around keeping taxable bodies attached to village order.

This may be the single best sixteenth-century contrast.

11. Shōji as a thriving transmit/post settlement, not a death hamlet

The 精進村 / Shōji village entry says Shōji lay south of Furuseki, on the north-west foot of Fuji, in the Aokigahara and mountain zone, with Lake Shōji. It was a post station on the Naka-michi route, seven ri from Kōfu, twenty from Sunpu, two from Motosu. It also says that around the Tenshō period — 1573—1592 — it flourished as a 伝馬宿, with 350 houses forming a town called 背地町 according to *Kainokuni-shi*. ([kotobank.jp](https://kotobank.jp/word/%E7%B2%BE%E9%80%B2%E6%9D%91-3057454?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That is extraordinary because it completely breaks the image of a deserted forest margin.

Around the late sixteenth century, the Shōji side of the Aokigahara world is presented as a substantial traffic settlement: horses, messages, goods, lodging, houses, townscape.

This is not the setting of later solitary death. It is a communications node.

12. The religious pivot: Hasegawa Kakugyō enters the Fuji world

Now the second half of the century brings the religious transformation.

Hasegawa Kakugyō, traditionally dated 1541—1646, appears in the Sengoku period as the figure later treated as founder of Fuji-kō. The Kitaguchi Hongū Fuji Sengen Shrine page says he appeared in the

Sengoku period, performed severe austerities at places including Hitoana and the standing-practice stone on the shrine approach, obtained spiritual power, and helped common people through healing prayers. It says he made his first Fuji ascent by the north/Yoshida route in 1572.
([sengenjinja.jp](https://www.sengenjinja.jp/fujikou/?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

The source is obviously Fuji-kō tradition, not neutral contemporary reportage. But for cultural history, that is precisely the point: the later Fuji-kō world remembers the sixteenth century as the century in which Kakugyō enters Fuji and makes Fuji into a commoner-accessible religious system.

So the late-sixteenth-century religious object is not Aokigahara-as-suicide; it is Fuji as the site of commoner salvation practice.

13. 1572: Kakugyō's first north-route ascent

The 1572 detail matters because the north/Yoshida route links Kakugyō's Fuji practice to the Yamanashi/north-foot world, not only the Shizuoka side. Kitaguchi Hongū says that in Genki 3 / 1572, Kakugyō made his first Fuji ascent from the north entrance, the Yoshida route.
([sengenjinja.jp](https://www.sengenjinja.jp/fujikou/?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This does not put him in Aokigahara directly. But it puts him in the same north-foot Fuji universe that includes the later Inner Eight Seas and the lake/forest perimeter.

In other words, the late sixteenth century gives the first clear religious bridge between ordinary commoner movement and Fuji's non-ordinary natural spaces.

14. 1580: the critical document — Kakugyō's lake list

The most important sixteenth-century religious source for the Aokigahara-adjacent world is the 1580 / Tenshō 8 document attributed to Kakugyō.

Minobu Town's page on the Inner-Eight-Seas memorial says the basis of the 内八海巡り was the pilgrimage to places where Kakugyō performed water practice, and that in a 1580 document in Kakugyō's own hand, the lake names listed include ふなつ, 山中, 西, しやうじ, もとす, おふみ, 浮島沼, はこね.
([town.minobu.lg.jp](https://www.town.minobu.lg.jp/bunka/rekishi/2023-1206-1036-32.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is the sixteenth-century jackpot.

Three of those names — 西, しやうじ, もとす — correspond to Saiko/Nishi-no-umi, Shōji and Motosu: the lakes bordering the Aokigahara world.

So, in 1580, the Aokigahara perimeter is not yet a suicide forest. It is written into a water-practice map.

The named sacred object is not “the trees”. It is the lake circuit.

This is the essential transformation:

Before 樹海, there is 八海. Before forest-disappearance, there is water-purification.

15. Sixteenth-century “Aokigahara” is a lake-edge religious ecology, not a forest-centred one

The 1580 lake list means we should stop looking for sixteenth-century “forest meaning” in the modern sense. The sacred geography is watery.

The modern keyword is 樹海 — sea of trees. The sixteenth-century sacred keyword is 八海 — eight waters/seas/lakes.

That difference is enormous.

In the sixteenth century, the forest is present as terrain. But the spiritually named route runs through lakes and water austerity. The human body is not imagined disappearing into trees; it is imagined being purified by water.

This is the deepest sixteenth-century inversion.

16. Hitoana: cave austerity, but only partly pinned to the sixteenth century

Hitoana is not Aokigahara proper, but it is the strongest lava-cave analogue.

Cultural Heritage Online says Fuji-kō documents present Hitoana as the place where, in the sixteenth to seventeenth centuries, Kakugyō performed austerities such as standing for 1,000 days on the cut end of a squared timber and received revelation from Asama Ōkami. It also says he called Hitoana a Pure Land / Pure Land gate according to tradition. ([online.bunka.go.jp](https://online.bunka.go.jp/special_content/component/132?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is powerful, but we must be precise. The source says 16th—17th centuries, not a fully dated sixteenth-century episode. So it belongs in this answer as a late-sixteenth/early-seventeenth transitional tradition, not as hard 1500s event proof.

Still, its conceptual value is huge: Fuji lava caves could be treated as sites of ordeal, revelation and passage to a sacred beyond. That is the cave grammar later Aokigahara can inherit.

17. White Thread Falls: water austerity again, not forest death

Fujinomiya’s page on Shiraito Falls says that from the late Sengoku period to early Edo period, Kakugyō is said to have performed practice there, and it became a pilgrimage/training site for Fuji-kō. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001607.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Again, the date range straddles the boundary, but it confirms the pattern: Kakugyō’s remembered sacred geography is not “go into the forest and disappear”. It is water, cave, mountain, austerity, purification.

That is what the sixteenth century contributes.

18. What “death” means in the sixteenth-century record

There is no suicide-site death layer.

There are four death-adjacent or body-extremity layers:

First, the 1554 Shōji reverse memorial, which is religious memorial practice, not suicide. ([kotobank.jp](https://kotobank.jp/word/%E7%B2%BE%E9%80%B2%E9%83%B7-3057455?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Second, Sengoku military pressure: Motosu as strategic border/castle/checkpoint and the wider Takeda—Imagawa—Hōjō/Tokugawa world. ([kotobank.jp](https://kotobank.jp/word/%E6%9C%AC%E6%A0%96%E9%83%))

B7-3057457?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Third, Kakugyō's austerity tradition: bodily ordeal in caves, waterfalls and on Fuji.
([online.bunka.go.jp](https://online.bunka.go.jp/special_content/component/132?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Fourth, the implied danger of routes and mountains — but not yet the later “body not found in the forest” script.

So the sixteenth-century death grammar is:

war, memorial, austerity, risk — not self-erasure.

That distinction is non-negotiable.

19. The century's deepest psychological meaning

If the twentieth-century Aokigahara fantasy is “I can leave the social ledger and become unfindable”, the sixteenth-century world is almost the opposite:

the road counts you; the checkpoint watches you; the village calls you back; the lord grants or withholds exemption; the post-station moves you onward; the religious route purifies you; the cave tests you; the lake cleanses you; Fuji receives ascent.

So the sixteenth-century Aokigahara perimeter is not a place of disappearance. It is a place of regulated crossing.

That is the deepest answer.

The later death-forest is made by converting one older structure into its opposite:

older structure: cross into hard nature, be purified, return or continue; later structure: cross into hard nature, vanish, do not return.

20. The sixteenth-century final thesis

Here is the answer in the most compressed accurate form:

In the sixteenth century, Aokigahara was not a suicide forest and not yet a forest-centred cultural symbol. It was the lava-forest margin of a Sengoku border system and an emerging Fuji-kō sacred geography. Its surrounding villages — Shōji, Motosu and Saiko/Nishi-no-umi — were road, post, trade and checkpoint communities inside 九一色. Motosu was strategically important by 1545; Shōji appears in 1554 mortuary practice and 1577 commercial exemption; Saiko/Nishi-no-umi appears in a 1597 document about recalling runaway peasants. Meanwhile, Hasegawa Kakugyō's late-sixteenth-century Fuji practice — especially his 1572 north-route ascent and 1580 lake list including Nishi, Shōji and Motosu — placed the Aokigahara-adjacent lakes inside a water-purification system.

So the sixteenth-century root is not death. It is border + water + cave + road + austerity + hard subsistence.

The later forest of self-erasure was built on a place whose sixteenth-century meaning was almost the reverse: a place where bodies were routed, purified, taxed, exempted, recalled, guarded, and moved through.

17th Century

The seventeenth-century answer is much harsher than the later ones: if we stay honestly inside 1600—1699, Aokigahara is not yet a “suicide forest”, not yet a Matsumoto-type vanishing-stage, and not yet even the main named sacred object. It is a forested lava margin inside a wider Fuji system: villages, roads, lakes, caves, purification, Fuji-kō formation, border control, forest use, and sacred cave practice.

The main seventeenth-century finding is therefore negative but important:

The seventeenth century does not give us Aokigahara-as-death-destination. It gives us the machinery that later made Aokigahara available for death-meaning: cave as otherworld, lake as purification, forest as difficult margin, Fuji as cosmic centre, and commoner pilgrimage as an emerging mass form.

1. The evidence problem: “Aokigahara” is not yet the modern object

For the seventeenth century, the source record does not behave like the twentieth-century record. You do not get “青木ヶ原樹海” as a stable cultural object loaded with suicide meaning. The relevant materials mostly point sideways: 西湖, 精進湖, 本栖湖, 人穴, 龍宮洞穴, 剱海神社, 内八海, 中道往還, 富士講, 長谷川角行, 村落 geography.

That matters. If one tries to search “青木ヶ原 17世紀 自殺”, almost nothing reliable emerges because that is the wrong historical object. The seventeenth-century object is not “the suicide forest”; it is the Fuji north-west foot: lake-edge settlements, lava caves, sacred waters and emerging Fuji-kō pilgrimage.

So the strict conclusion is:

No accessible seventeenth-century source I found supports Aokigahara as a suicide site. The seventeenth-century record supports Aokigahara as liminal sacred/working terrain.

2. 1600s physical base: the lava forest is already mature, but not ancient

By 1600, the Aokigahara lava flow is roughly 735 years old, formed after the 864 Jōgan eruption. That matters because the forest is old enough by the seventeenth century to be dense and locally meaningful, but it is not ancient in the sense that later “primeval forest” rhetoric implies.

The relevant point is this: in the seventeenth century, the forest already possesses the physical affordances that will later matter — lava irregularity, caves, dense growth, low agricultural suitability, difficult ground. But those affordances have not yet been converted into the twentieth-century “suicide forest” script.

This is the first layer: the body of the later myth exists, but the later meaning has not yet arrived.

3. The village frame: Saiko, Shōji and Motosu are the real seventeenth-century anchors

The seventeenth-century Aokigahara cannot be understood by staring into the trees. You have to stand at the villages and lakes around it.

The historical place-name entry for 西湖村 / Saiko village says the village lay around Lake Saiko, with the main settlement on the north-east shore and the branch settlement 根場 / Neba on the north-west shore; it also says the area was known as 西海 / 西之海 and belonged to the old 九一色-related world. A 1597 document, just before the seventeenth century, already mentions 九一色内西海 and orders runaway peasants to return on condition of half tax; I am not counting that as seventeenth-century evidence, but it shows the immediate pre-Edo administrative frame into which the seventeenth-century village enters. ([kotobank.jp](https://kotobank.jp/word/%E8%A5%BF%E6%B9%96%E6%9D%91-3041090?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

The entry for 精進村 / Shōji village is even more important. It says Shōji lay south of Furuseki, at the north-west foot of Fuji, in the Aokigahara/mountain zone, with Lake Shōji; it was a 宿場 / post-station on the 中道往還 / Naka-michi road, seven ri from Kōfu, twenty ri from Sunpu, and two ri from Motosu. It also preserves the purification-name tradition: En no Ozunu supposedly bathed in the lake and purified himself before ascending Fuji. ([kotobank.jp](https://kotobank.jp/word/%E7%B2%BE%E9%80%B2%E6%9D%91-3057454?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

The entry for 本栖村 / Motosu village places it south of Shōji, on the Kai—Suruga border, by Aokigahara and surrounding mountains, with a 口留番所 / checkpoint on the Naka-michi road. ([kotobank.jp](https://kotobank.jp/word/%E6%9C%AC%E6%A0%96%E6%9D%91-3057456?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That gives the first microscopic seventeenth-century reconstruction:

Aokigahara was not an isolated psychic void. It was bordered by villages, lake settlements, a road corridor, a post-station, and a border-checkpoint system.

This is vital because the modern myth depends on Aokigahara as “outside society”. In the seventeenth-century record, it is beside society: road, village, checkpoint, lodging, taxation, movement.

4. The road layer: the forest is beside a controlled passage between Kai and Suruga

The 中道往還 is one of the most important seventeenth-century structures. It linked Kai and Suruga, and the Shōji/Motosu area sat on or near this route. The broader 九一色 entry says the area was on a strategic route between Kai and Suruga, and that the inhabitants were historically connected to woodwork, trade and border functions. It also says 九一色 villagers received privileges from Tokugawa Ieyasu after 1582 and remained privileged traders through the early modern period, handling goods including tobacco, tea, fish and salt across neighbouring provinces. ([kotobank.jp](https://kotobank.jp/word/%E4%B9%9D%E4%B8%80%E8%89%B2%E9%83%B7-830407?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This makes the seventeenth-century Aokigahara perimeter commercial and administrative, not simply haunted.

The road does three things:

It links the forest-edge to military and border control.

It brings travellers, goods, post-station duties and information through the area.

It gives the lake/forest villages a function beyond subsistence.

That means the seventeenth-century forest was near a movement-machine. Later, Aokigahara will become a place imagined as social exit. But in the seventeenth century, the surrounding system is about passage, not disappearance.

5. The 九一色 layer: poor mountain ecology, woodwork and trading identity

The 九一色 source is unusually useful because it explains why this geography was not simply rice-field village Japan. It says the region lay in mountain land with poor climate and thin agricultural conditions, and that one explanation of “九一色” derives from 工一色, linked to woodworkers or woodcraft communities. It also says the area became tied to trade because of the Naka-michi road. ([kotobank.jp](https://kotobank.jp/word/%E4%B9%9D%E4%B8%80%E8%89%B2%E9%83%B7-830407?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is a deep precondition for Aokigahara’s later symbolic distinctiveness. The forest-edge villages were not ordinary rice-centred plains villages. They were mountain/road/forest/lake communities, economically tied to:

wood; craft; border movement; transport; trade; non-rice resources; mountain conditions.

So the seventeenth-century social ecology is marginal but not empty. It is hard country, not death country.

That distinction matters.

6. The sacred-water layer: seventeenth-century meaning points to purification, not suicide

The Shōji place-name tradition says the lake name derives from ritual purification before Fuji ascent: bathing, purification and self-discipline. ([kotobank.jp](https://kotobank.jp/word/%E7%B2%BE%E9%80%B2%E6%9D%91-3057454?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is one of the most important seventeenth-century interpretive controls. The surrounding lakes are not merely scenic. They are tied to water practice / 水行 / 水垢離 and Fuji ascent.

Yamanashi’s Fuji-faith guide says the 内八海 / Inner Eight Seas tradition is based on Hasegawa Kakugyō’s water practice at eight lakes and ponds around Fuji; the usual list includes 西湖, 精進湖 and 本栖湖, all bordering or adjacent to the Aokigahara world. ([pref.yamanashi.jp](https://www.pref.yamanashi.jp/documents/82948/zentaiban-omote.pdf?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

The Fuji World Heritage Center guide also states that the Inner Eight Seas were the waters where Kakugyō was said to have performed water austerities, and that they became objects of faith for Fuji-kō believers after Fuji ascent. ([fujiguide.pref.yamanashi.jp](https://fujiguide.pref.yamanashi.jp/guide/16/?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So, in seventeenth-century logic, the lake-world beside Aokigahara is not yet about death. It is about cleansing, discipline, approach to Fuji, and bodily preparation.

The later “disappearance into trees” is horizontal and anti-social. The seventeenth-century water practice is ritualised, communal and purificatory.

7. The key seventeenth-century person: Hasegawa Kakugyō

The central seventeenth-century figure is 長谷川角行 / Hasegawa Kakugyō, generally dated 1541—1646. North Fuji Sengen Shrine describes him as the founder figure of Fuji-kō, saying he practised austerities at Fuji’s Hitoana cave and other places, gained religious power, healed illnesses and spread Fuji faith across social ranks. It also gives his death date as 3 June 1646. ([sengenjinja.jp](https://www.sengenjinja.jp/fujikou/?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Fujinomiya's official page gives the broader historical frame: in the first half of the seventeenth century, after long domestic warfare ended and the Tokugawa order stabilised society and the economy, more people aimed for Fuji. In that context, Kakugyō, who practised in the Fuji body and surrounding wind caves, especially 人穴 / Hitoana, formed the basis of what later became Fuji-kō.
([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001611.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is the seventeenth-century breakthrough. Fuji becomes increasingly available to commoners not only as mountain, but as organised religious system: austerity, healing, pilgrimage, worldly benefit, purification, guides, routes, cave sanctuaries.

Kakugyō is not an Aokigahara suicide figure. But he is indispensable because the later Aokigahara field lies inside the Fuji-kō world he helped generate.

8. Hitoana: the cave-as-otherworld grammar is active in the seventeenth century

Hitoana is not Aokigahara proper. But it is the most important seventeenth-century analogue because it shows how Fuji lava caves were spiritually read.

Cultural Heritage Online describes 人穴富士講遺跡 as centred on the wind cave where Kakugyō is said to have died after austerities. It says *Azuma Kagami* already treated Hitoana as a place of spiritual experience in the thirteenth century; then, according to Fuji-kō documents, Kakugyō practised there in the sixteenth to seventeenth centuries, including severe austerities, and received divine revelation. Crucially, it says Kakugyō called Hitoana a 浄土 / 浄土門, and that followers later visited it for worship and practice. ([online.bunka.go.jp](https://online.bunka.go.jp/special_content/component/132?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

MLIT's multilingual cultural note is even clearer for sensory texture: Hitoana is a quiet, mysterious cave, high enough to stand in, with water at the bottom; in the early seventeenth century Kakugyō is said to have spent a thousand days there in meditation.
([mlit.go.jp](https://www.mlit.go.jp/tagengo-db/common/001556224.pdf?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is the seventeenth-century death/otherworld layer — but note the difference from modern suicide.

Hitoana is not “I want to vanish”. It is:

a cave; a holy aperture; a Pure Land gate; a place of austerity; a place where the body is disciplined; a place associated with revelation and religious death.

The later Aokigahara imaginary will also turn on entry into dark lava terrain. But in the seventeenth century, the structure is religious entry, not private erasure.

9. The direct seventeenth-century material trace: 1664 and 1673 stone Buddhas inside Hitoana

This is one of the most important hard pieces of seventeenth-century evidence.

Cultural Heritage Online says that inside Hitoana there are stone Buddhas with inscriptions dated 1664 and 1673, dedicated by figures identified as Kakugyō's third- and fourth-generation disciples.
([online.bunka.go.jp](https://online.bunka.go.jp/special_content/component/132?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That matters because it gives a material seventeenth-century trace after Kakugyō's death. It shows that the cave was not just later legend. By the 1660s and 1670s, there was already disciple-line material devotion around Kakugyō and Hitoana.

This is the strongest seventeenth-century evidence for a Fuji-cave devotional continuum.

The implication for Aokigahara is indirect but powerful: the Fuji lava/cave landscape had become a medium for religious memory. Caves were not inert geology. They could preserve lineage, death, sanctity and initiation.

10. Ryūgū cave and Senoumi Shrine: the Aokigahara-edge cave-water complex

For Aokigahara proper, the best seventeenth-century-adjacent site is 龍宮洞穴 / Ryūgū cave and 剱海神社 / Senoumi Shrine at Saiko.

The Yamanashi Shrine Agency says Senoumi Shrine was founded by enshrining Toyotama-hime at a lava-cave entrance in 913 during famine, for fair weather and good harvest; it adds that in the Edo period Asama deity worship was added, and that the shrine was a Fuji-kō Eight-Seas pilgrimage site as the 青木龍神 / Aoki dragon deity. ([yamanashi-jinjacho.or.jp](https://www.yamanashi-jinjacho.or.jp/intro/search/detail/7156?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Yamanashi's tourism page says the shrine's main sanctuary is inside Ryūgū cave, a national natural monument; it repeats that Asama Ōkami was added in the Edo period and that the cave/shrine functioned as the Aoki dragon-god sacred place in Fuji-kō Eight-Seas pilgrimage. ([yamanashi-kankou.jp](https://www.yamanashi-kankou.jp/rekitabi/jisha/spot/196.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

The limitation: "Edo period" is not exactly "seventeenth century". It could be seventeenth, eighteenth or nineteenth century unless the underlying shrine record fixes a date. So we cannot say with certainty that the Asama merger happened in the 1600s. But for a seventeenth-century reconstruction, Ryūgū/Senoumi remains crucial because it shows what kind of Aokigahara-edge sacred object existed in the early modern system: cave, water, dragon, rain, harvest, Asama/Fuji, pilgrimage.

This is the most Aokigahara-specific sacred structure available.

11. The seventeenth-century Aokigahara is a perimeter, not a centre

This is the most important conceptual correction.

In the seventeenth century, the named charge sits mostly at the perimeter:

Saiko; Shōji; Motosu; Ryūgū cave; Senoumi Shrine; Hitoana; Naka-michi road; Fuji ascent routes; Inner Eight Seas.

Aokigahara itself is the forested lava mass between/around these named things. It is not yet the protagonist. It is the medium: the dark ground through which cave, water, village, road and mountain relate.

So the seventeenth-century structure is not:

"people go into Aokigahara to die."

It is:

"people move around Aokigahara's lakes, roads and caves to trade, purify, cross borders, approach Fuji, and participate in a growing Fuji-kō religious world."

That is the cleanest seventeenth-century answer.

12. The state/order layer: the forest-edge becomes legible to Tokugawa administration

Seventeenth-century Japan is not just religion. It is also the Tokugawa state making roads, villages, taxation and borders legible.

The Motosu entry's mention of a 口留番所 on the Kai—Suruga border is important because a checkpoint is a state-reading device: who is moving, what goods cross, what route is controlled.

([kotobank.jp] (https://kotobank.jp/word/%E6%9C%AC%E6%A0%96%E6%9D%91-3057456?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

The broader 九一色 entry says the region's people were historically tied to trade and enjoyed privileges recognised by Tokugawa Ieyasu, becoming early-modern privileged merchants across neighbouring provinces. ([kotobank.jp] (https://kotobank.jp/word/%E4%B9%9D%E4%B8%80%E8%89%B2%E9%83%B7-830407?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This means that the seventeenth-century Aokigahara perimeter is not “outside government”. It is a border/road economy under early-modern ordering.

The later fantasy is to enter the forest and escape the social ledger. The seventeenth-century reality is almost the opposite: roads, checkpoints, village responsibility and privileges tie the area into the ledger.

13. The Narusawa evidence: local village chronology, disaster, temple and boundaries

Narusawa village's official chronology gives several seventeenth-century-adjacent and seventeenth-century points: a 1591 land survey in Narusawa/Otawa just before the century; a 1616 major fire that burned Tsugenji; and later, in 1702 just after the century, a dispute with Suruga over rights to construction timber. ([vill.narusawa.yamanashi.jp] (https://www.vill.narusawa.yamanashi.jp/gyo-sei/soshikikarasagasu/kikakuka/narusawamuranogaiyo/2/466.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Strictly, only the 1616 fire is inside the seventeenth century. But the sequence still shows what kind of historical world surrounds Aokigahara: village temples, surveys, fire, forest-resource disputes, border/resource conflicts.

This is again anti-gothic. The forest is not a metaphysical death-zone in the seventeenth-century local record. It is part of a village-resource-border world.

14. The working-forest implication: wood, forest rights, non-rice subsistence

The 九一色 entry's explanation of poor agricultural conditions and woodworker/trader identity, combined with Narusawa's later timber-rights dispute, shows the likely early-modern logic: forest resources mattered. ([kotobank.jp] (https://kotobank.jp/word/%E4%B9%9D%E4%B8%80%E8%89%B2%E9%83%B7-830407?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

We must not overclaim beyond the cited records. I cannot give a fully sourced seventeenth-century inventory of Aokigahara extraction from the open material alone. But the structural evidence is strong enough to say:

The Aokigahara perimeter belonged to a mountain economy where wood, trade, transport and non-rice resources were central.

This again matters for the later myth because “untouched suicide forest” is a twentieth-century overcoding. The seventeenth-century landscape is worked, crossed, controlled, prayed through and used.

15. The sensory seventeenth-century Aokigahara

If we reconstruct carefully from the source types, the seventeenth-century sensory world is not Matsumoto's final page. It is something like this:

a lava forest old enough to be dense, uneven and cave-ridden; lake water at Saiko, Shōji and Motosu used in sacred geography; cold, dark lava caves associated with dragon/water deity or Fuji revelation; mountain villages under poor agricultural conditions; post-station movement on the Naka-michi; border checkpoints; Fuji-kō austerity and water practice; roadside lodging and trade; wood and forest products; temples/shrines and village fire/disaster records.

That is a much more concrete world than “mysterious forest”.

The emotional register is not suicide. It is:

awe; danger; purification; difficult passage; cold cave sanctity; borderland; bodily discipline; Fuji's cosmic centrality; resource hardship.

16. What is “death” in the seventeenth-century layer?

There are three death-adjacent themes, but none equals modern suicide.

First: Kakugyō's death /入滅 at Hitoana, traditionally dated 1646 and associated with the cave as a Pure Land gate. This gives the seventeenth century a real cave-death sacred layer, but it is religiously framed, not despair-suicide. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp] (https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/fujisan/11ti2b0000001br3.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Second: caves as otherworld openings. Hitoana had older underworld/Pure Land associations, and Kakugyō's Hitoana practice intensified the religious cave grammar. ([online.bunka.go.jp] (https://online.bunka.go.jp/special_content/component/132?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Third: bodily extremity. Kakugyō's austerities and water practices create a model where the body enters natural hardship to reach revelation, purification or salvation. ([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp] (https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001611.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That is the seventeenth-century death-grammar:

not self-erasure, but sacred bodily extremity.

17. The deepest distinction from the twentieth century

The twentieth-century Aokigahara script is:

leave society → enter forest → disappear → body may not be found.

The seventeenth-century Fuji/Aokigahara-perimeter script is:

leave ordinary impurity → perform water/cave/mountain practice → approach Fuji → return with purification, power, healing or religious status.

One is anti-social severance.

The other is ritual transformation.

Both require entry into non-ordinary nature. That is the continuity. But their meaning is completely different.

This is why it would be historically wrong to say the seventeenth century “already had” the suicide forest. It had something deeper and older: the ritual technology of crossing into hard nature and coming back changed.

18. Why this matters for the later suicide reputation

The seventeenth century contributes five structural elements to the later reputation.

First, it gives the area a Fuji-kō sacred infrastructure: Kakugyō, water practice, Inner Eight Seas, Hitoana, caves, pilgrim routes.

Second, it gives the forest-edge a cave/threshold grammar: Ryūgū, Senoumi, Hitoana, dragon-water, Pure Land gate, divine revelation.

Third, it gives the landscape a bodily discipline grammar: water austerity, cave austerity, mountain ascent, purification.

Fourth, it gives the perimeter a road/border/village system: Shōji post-station, Motosu checkpoint, Naka-michi movement.

Fifth, it gives the local world a hard mountain economy: poor agriculture, wood/craft/trade orientation, forest-resource significance.

The later suicide image will detach one element — entering non-ordinary forest/cave terrain — from its older communal-religious-return structure. It turns sacred passage into social disappearance.

19. The exact seventeenth-century source hierarchy

The best seventeenth-century source packet is:

1. Hasegawa Kakugyō / Fuji-kō official sources. Use for the formation of Fuji-kō in the seventeenth century, Kakugyō's dates, Hitoana austerities, healing/worldly benefit and commoner orientation. ([sengenjinja.jp] (https://www.sengenjinja.jp/fujikou/?utm_source=chatgpt.com))
2. Hitoana Fuji-kō site material. Use for cave-as-Pure-Land-gate, Kakugyō's 16th—17th century practice, 1646 death tradition, and the hard material dates of 1664/1673 disciple stone Buddhas. ([online.bunka.go.jp] (https://online.bunka.go.jp/special_content/component/132?utm_source=chatgpt.com))
3. Inner Eight Seas / water-practice sources. Use for Saiko, Shōji and Motosu as Fuji-kō sacred waters linked to Kakugyō's water austerities. ([pref.yamanashi.jp] (https://www.pref.yamanashi.jp/documents/82948/zentaiban-omote.pdf?utm_source=chatgpt.com))
4. Senoumi Shrine / Ryūgū cave. Use for Aokigahara-edge cave-water-dragon-Fuji cultic geography; be cautious because “Edo period” is broader than the seventeenth century. ([yamanashi-kankou.jp] (https://www.yamanashi-kankou.jp/rekitabi/jisha/spot/196.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))
5. Place-name / road sources for Shōji, Motosu, Saiko and 九一色. Use for village, road, post-station, checkpoint, mountain-trade and purification-name geography. ([kotobank.jp] (https://kotobank.jp/word/%E7%B2%BE%E9%80%B2%E6%9D%91-3057454?utm_source=chatgpt.com))
6. Narusawa local chronology. Use sparingly for seventeenth-century village events such as the 1616 fire and the broader early-modern village/forest-resource frame.

([vill.narusawa.yamanashi.jp](https://www.vill.narusawa.yamanashi.jp/gyosei/soshikikarasagasu/kikakuka/narusawamuranogaiyo/2/466.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Final seventeenth-century thesis

In the seventeenth century, Aokigahara was not a suicide forest. It was not even the main named protagonist of its own landscape. It was the forested lava medium between villages, lakes, caves, roads and Fuji.

Its deepest seventeenth-century meaning comes from the birth of Fuji-kō under Hasegawa Kakugyō: Fuji becomes a commoner-accessible religious system of water purification, cave austerity, healing, ascent, worldly benefit and sacred geography. Saiko, Shōji and Motosu enter that system as Inner Eight Seas. Hitoana proves that Fuji lava caves could be read as Pure Land gates and sites of bodily extremity. Ryūgū cave/Senoumi Shrine shows the Aokigahara edge as water-dragon-cave-Fuji terrain. Shōji and Motosu show the forest-edge as road, post-station and checkpoint. 九一色 shows hard mountain economy, craft and trade.

So the seventeenth-century Aokigahara is best defined as:

a liminal Fuji-foot working-sacred perimeter — hard, cold, cave-ridden, lake-bound, road-adjacent, purification-oriented, and increasingly folded into commoner Fuji faith.

The later “suicide forest” is not present. But the necessary preconditions are: a landscape where entering hard nature can mean crossing a boundary; where caves are not mere holes but sacred thresholds; where lakes cleanse the body before Fuji; where ordinary people come for transformation; and where the forest sits between society and a non-ordinary natural order.

That is the seventeenth-century root. Not death-as-despair. Threshold-as-transformation.

18th Century

Yes. Eighteenth century only gives a different answer. It does not give “Aokigahara as suicide forest”. It gives the layer beneath that: Aokigahara as part of a Fuji-water-cave pilgrimage system, organised around purification, sacred danger, route-making, dragon/water deities, and one major act of religious self-death elsewhere on Fuji.

The core conclusion is blunt:

In the eighteenth century, Aokigahara was not yet a modern death-destination. It was a liminal sacred margin: lava forest beside Saiko, Shōji and Motosu; cave-shrine terrain; part of the Fuji-kō “inner eight seas” pilgrimage world; and adjacent to a religious movement transformed in 1733 by Jikigyō Miroku’s death on Fuji.

So the eighteenth-century significance is not “people went into Aokigahara to die”. I found no reliable accessible evidence for that. The eighteenth-century significance is that the forest-edge became embedded in a system where water, mountain, cave, bodily purification, suffering, salvation and sacred withdrawal were already fused. That is the precondition later suicide-discourse could exploit.

1. The eighteenth century opens under the shadow of the 1707 Hōei eruption

Strictly, the 1707 Hōei eruption did not create Aokigahara. Aokigahara comes from the 864 Jōgan lava flow. But the 1707 eruption matters because it made Fuji freshly catastrophic in eighteenth-century consciousness.

The Cabinet Office disaster-history report says the Hōei eruption caused no recorded direct human deaths in the first-order event, but falling volcanic material caused building collapse, farmland becoming uncultivable, devastation of mountain/grassland areas, road obstruction, and later flooding from remobilised ash, producing long and wide damage to agriculture and economic activity. It also says the eruption caused great anxiety not only locally but beyond the region.
([bousai.go.jp](https://www.bousai.go.jp/kyoiku/kyokun/kyoukunnokeishou/rep/1707_houe_i_fujiisan_funka/index.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That matters because early eighteenth-century Fuji is not just “beautiful Fuji” or “pilgrimage Fuji”. It is also disaster Fuji: unstable, punitive, economically destructive, capable of covering regions in ash. The later Fuji-kō intensification occurs in a world where Fuji’s sacredness and Fuji’s violence are not separable.

But this is not Aokigahara-specific death evidence. It is context: the century begins with Fuji as a living, feared volcano.

2. The real eighteenth-century centre is Fuji-kō, not Aokigahara suicide

The main eighteenth-century development is the expansion and consolidation of Fuji-kō: lay pilgrimage/religious associations centred on Fuji.

Fujinomiya’s official history says that after the early modern stabilisation of society and economy, more people aimed for Fuji; Hasegawa Kakugyō’s Fuji faith, rooted partly in practice around Fuji and wind caves such as Hitoana, developed into what became Fuji-kō; and two figures, Murakami Kōsei and Jikigyō Miroku, were especially important for later Fuji-kō development.

([city.fujinomiya.lg.jp](https://www.city.fujinomiya.lg.jp/1015150000/p001611.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is the correct eighteenth-century frame. Aokigahara sits at the foot of Fuji, but in the eighteenth century the primary cultural machine is not “forest death”. It is pilgrimage religion: routes, lakes, caves, water practice, ascent, purification, group organisation, and charismatic religious lineages.

So: if later Aokigahara becomes a “place to disappear”, the eighteenth-century precursor is not suicide. It is withdrawal into a sacred geography.

3. 1733 is the key date: Jikigyō Miroku’s death transforms Fuji-kō

The crucial eighteenth-century event is 1733, not 1928 or 1960.

Jikigyō Miroku, born in 1671, is described by Fuji-san Net as the “reviver” or major energising figure of Fuji-kō. In July 1733, he died at Ebōshi-iwa on Fuji after a religious fast, and his oral teachings during that period were written down by Tanabe Jūrōemon as the “Thirty-One Days Scroll” / 三十一日の巻, later treated as one of Fuji-kō’s scriptures.

([fujisan-net.jp](https://www.fujisan-net.jp/post_detail/2000240?utm_source=chatgpt.com)) (https://www.fujisan-net.jp/post_detail/2000240?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

The MLIT Fuji Sabo page gives the broader social effect: Miroku’s teaching stressed that wealth and status were temporary; after his death, Fuji-kō believers increased greatly, and by late Edo there were said to be so many groups in Edo that people spoke of “Edo eight hundred and eight kō”.

([cbr.mlit.go.jp](https://www.cbr.mlit.go.jp/fujisabo/bosai/fuji_info/chisiki/d01/index.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com)) (https://www.cbr.mlit.go.jp/fujisabo/bosai/fuji_info/chisiki/d01/index.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is the eighteenth-century death layer. But it is not Aokigahara suicide. It is religious self-death on Fuji as public doctrine.

The distinction matters. Miroku’s death is not a private modern suicide in a forest. It is a consciously staged act of Fuji-kō religious meaning, linked to “world-renewal”, salvation of suffering commoners, and transmission of doctrine. Ōtani Masayuki’s J-STAGE article treats Miroku’s final text, the Soegaki / 添書, as a message to emperor and shogun and as advance notice of his self-death; the article frames Miroku’s path as shaped by dissatisfaction with the absence of divine manifestation and with commoners’ suffering. ([[jstage.jst.go.jp](https://www.jstage.jst.go.jp/article/rsjars/92/3/92_25/_article/-char/ja)]) (https://www.jstage.jst.go.jp/article/rsjars/92/3/92_25/_article/-char/ja))

That gives the eighteenth century its deepest psychological register: suffering commoners, failed worldly order, religious impatience, bodily extremity, and Fuji as the place where a person could turn suffering into cosmological meaning.

Later Aokigahara suicide discourse is not the same thing. But it inherits a Fuji-region grammar in which death/withdrawal can be more than an accident.

4. The “Thirty-One Days Scroll” puts Saiko, Shōji and Motosu inside the eighteenth-century sacred route system

This is the most important Aokigahara-adjacent fact.

The Fuji World Heritage comprehensive preservation plan says that Saiko, Shōjiko and Motosuko are volcanic dammed lakes and that, based on traditions of Hasegawa Kakugyō’s water practice, Fuji-kō believers established the practice of going round eight lakes called Inner Eight Seas pilgrimage / 内八海巡り. It then says that in the 1733 “Thirty-One Days Scroll”, Miroku listed eight lakes as pilgrimage sites, and that among those lakes the Fuji Five Lakes, including Saiko, Shōji and Motosu, remained constant water-practice pilgrimage objects. ([[fujisan-3776.jp](https://www.fujisan-3776.jp/info-lib/documents/cmpm_maindocument.pdf)]) (https://www.fujisan-3776.jp/info-lib/documents/cmpm_maindocument.pdf))

This is the exact eighteenth-century hinge.

Aokigahara itself is not yet being singled out as “the death forest”. But its bordering waters — Saiko, Shōji and Motosu — are explicitly present in the 1733 Fuji-kō textual world. The forest enters the eighteenth-century sacred imagination by its margins: lake-edge, cave-edge, pilgrimage route, water practice.

That is more precise than saying “Aokigahara was sacred”. The better formulation is:

In 1733, the Aokigahara-adjacent lake system is canonised inside Fuji-kō pilgrimage geography. The forest itself is still peripheral; the waters and cave-thresholds carry the named sacred function.

5. The eighteenth-century “Aokigahara” is therefore a perimeter object, not a centre object

This is a key correction.

When you search the eighteenth century, the forest does not yet appear as a modern named symbolic centre in the way it does after Matsumoto. The named sacred objects are the lakes, caves, shrines, pilgrimage routes and Fuji ascent points.

That means the eighteenth-century Aokigahara is best understood as a perimeter field:

Saiko on one side; Shōji on another; Motosu further west; Ryūgū cave / Senoumi shrine in the lava-cave system; Fuji-kō inner-eight-seas practice crossing the lake world; Fuji itself above everything.

The forest’s later symbolic force is already physically present — lava, caves, dense growth, no easy road-world — but the eighteenth-century documentary charge is not “go into the forest”. It is “circle the sacred waters; purify; ascend; encounter Fuji through lake/cave/water”.

This is why the suicide-origin story cannot be pushed back honestly into the eighteenth century. The eighteenth-century record gives liminality, not suicide-site identity.

6. Ryūgū cave / Senoumi Shrine: the most Aokigahara-specific eighteenth-century religious layer

The best Aokigahara-proper eighteenth-century seam is Ryūgū cave / 龍宮洞穴 and Senoumi Shrine / 剱海神社.

Yamanashi’s historical tourism page says Senoumi Shrine is enshrined inside Ryūgū cave; Toyotama-hime was enshrined at the lava-cave entrance in 913 in response to famine/weather/agricultural concerns; Asama Ōkami was added in the Edo period; and the site was a Fuji-kō Eight Seas pilgrimage sacred place as the Aoki dragon deity / 青木龍神. It also preserves the memory that before the Jōgan eruption, Saiko and Shōji were part of the large old lake called Seno-umi.
([yamanashi-kankou.jp](https://www.yamanashi-kankou.jp/rekitabi/jisha/spot/196.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is microscopic and important.

The cave is not just “a cave”. It is:

a lava cave inside or at the edge of Aokigahara; a water/dragon deity site; a famine/rain/agriculture petition site; a shrine inside a geological wound; an Edo-period Asama/Fuji-kō site; a remembered remnant of the destroyed Seno-umi lake-world.

That is the real eighteenth-century Aokigahara: not a suicide forest, but a cave-mouth where lava, vanished lake, dragon-water deity, agriculture and Fuji worship meet.

This is probably the closest eighteenth-century source-family to the later emotional power of the forest, because it already treats the lava cave as an entrance to something more than ordinary terrain.

7. The lake circuit is not sightseeing; it is bodily purification

Modern accounts can make “Fuji Five Lakes” sound scenic and touristy, but the eighteenth-century frame is bodily and religious.

The Fuji World Heritage Center says Shōji and Motosu are among the Fuji Five Lakes and were pilgrimage sites for Fuji-kō believers who performed water practice in the Inner Eight Seas pilgrimage. ([fujisan-whc.jp](https://www.fujisan-whc.jp/about/parts/index.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com)) The official cultural-property database similarly says the Fuji Five Lakes were historically incorporated into Fuji-kō’s Eight Seas pilgrimage and became sacred places within Fuji faith; its detailed explanation says the Fuji Five Lakes were the core of the “inner” pilgrimage among lakes near Fuji. ([kunishitei.bunka.go.jp](https://kunishitei.bunka.go.jp/heritage/detail/401/00003723?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

The crucial point: the eighteenth-century lake circuit is not merely movement through landscape. It is body-work: water practice, purification, cleansing pollution, preparing or completing religious relation to Fuji.

This helps explain the later psychological resonance. Aokigahara’s surroundings were already part of a system where the body is transformed by entering cold, sacred, non-ordinary natural places. Later, modern suicide discourse will invert this from purification into erasure. But the older grammar is purification.

8. Saiko before roads: the lake world was not easily terrestrial

A later MLIT multilingual database note says that before the 1960s there was no road around Saiko and even movement between lakeside settlements used boats; it adds that researchers think many Eight Seas pilgrims probably crossed Saiko by boat. It also describes Ryūgū cave on Saiko’s south shore as a lava cave linked to a dragon-shaped water deity and as an existing sacred place incorporated by Fuji-kō. ([mlit.go.jp](https://www.mlit.go.jp/tagengo-db/R2-00090.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This source is modern, but it preserves a structural fact relevant to the eighteenth-century landscape: Saiko’s religious geography was not simply road-walking. It was shore, boat, lake, cave, south-bank lava forest.

That matters because it means the Aokigahara edge was not experienced like a modern roadside trail. The eighteenth-century sensorium would be much more elemental: lake crossing, forested shore, cave-mouth, shrine, cold/damp air, Fuji overhead, water deity, limited route infrastructure.

That is the atmosphere — not “suicide forest”, but difficult sacred perimeter.

9. 1707 and 1733 together give the century its emotional logic

Put the two major eighteenth-century events side by side:

1707: Fuji erupts, damaging agriculture, transport and regional life, creating anxiety far beyond the immediate area. ([bousai.go.jp](https://www.bousai.go.jp/kyoiku/kyokun/kyoukunnokeishou/rep/1707_houei_fujisan_funka/index.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com)) 1733: Jikigyō Miroku dies on Fuji in a religious act

that later energises Fuji-kō, with his teaching stressing impermanence of wealth/status and appeal to suffering commoners. ([cbr.mlit.go.jp](https://www.cbr.mlit.go.jp/fujisabo/bosai/fuji_info/chisiki/d01/index.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That pair matters more than any supposed “Aokigahara death legend” .

The eighteenth-century Fuji world is shaped by:

volcanic disaster; economic vulnerability; commoner suffering; religious search for renewal; Fuji as both destroyer and saviour; water practice around its lakes; caves as sacred thresholds; self-denial as a religious technology.

So the later Aokigahara death-reputation does not emerge from nowhere. But the eighteenth-century material points to salvation through purification and bodily extremity, not modern private suicide.

10. What eighteenth-century Aokigahara was not

This is as important as what it was.

I found no reliable accessible eighteenth-century evidence that Aokigahara was already a recognised suicide destination.

I found no eighteenth-century “suicide forest” discourse.

I found no eighteenth-century equivalent of the 1928 Shōjiko double-suicide press layer.

I found no eighteenth-century Matsumoto-like literary vanishing scene.

I found no eighteenth-century evidence that “樹海” as later mass death-symbol was already doing that work.

What we have instead is:

Fuji-kō pilgrimage; Saiko/Shōji/Motosu as sacred waters; Ryūgū cave / Senoumi Shrine as Aokigahara-edge sacred cave; Edo-period addition of Asama deity worship at the cave-shrine; Jikigyō Miroku’ s 1733 religious self-death on Fuji; the 1707 Hōei eruption as disaster background; the transformation of Fuji into a major commoner religious system.

That is the honest eighteenth-century record.

11. The “death” in the eighteenth century is vertical, not horizontal

This is the cleanest conceptual distinction.

Later Aokigahara death is horizontal: a person leaves the road, enters the trees, vanishes into the lateral forest.

Eighteenth-century Fuji-kō death is vertical: a person ascends the mountain, disciplines the body, enters sacred extremity, and makes death doctrinally meaningful.

Miroku’ s 1733 death happens on Fuji, not in Aokigahara. It belongs to ascent, doctrine, public religious meaning, and Fuji-kō institutional memory. The later Aokigahara imaginary belongs to descent/entry, silence, concealment, non-recovery.

That distinction prevents a lot of nonsense. The eighteenth century is not “same thing earlier” . It is a different death-grammar.

12. The cave complicates the vertical/horizontal split

Ryūgū cave is the bridge between those grammars.

The mountain ascent is vertical. The lake circuit is horizontal. The cave is an opening downward/inward. Senoumi Shrine's placement inside Ryūgū cave means the Aokigahara edge was already structured as an entrance: into rock, water-deity space, dragon palace imagery, rain-making, and Fuji-kō pilgrimage. ([yamanashi-kankou.jp] (https://www.yamanashi-kankou.jp/rekitabi/jisha/spot/196.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is probably the most important eighteenth-century psychological precursor.

The later person enters the forest to disappear.

The earlier pilgrim approaches the cave/water to purify and petition.

Both are movements into a non-ordinary natural threshold, but the older one is communal, ritualised and cosmologically legible; the later one is private, socially severing and often anti-ritual.

13. The eighteenth-century word-world is “八海”, not “樹海”

This is critical.

The later keyword is 樹海 — sea of trees.

The eighteenth-century sacred keyword is 八海 — eight seas/lakes.

That shift is enormous.

Eighteenth-century discourse organises the area through water: lakes, water practice, dragon deities, purification, pilgrimage circuits. The forest is present as lava/shore/cave terrain, but the named sacred structure is watery.

Modern discourse organises the area through trees: the sea of trees, the no-return forest, the body not found.

So one can almost chart the transformation:

18th century: 八海 = sacred waters around Fuji. 20th century: 樹海 = absorptive forest of disappearance.

That is the best microscopic insight from this century-specific cut.

14. Where Aokigahara sits in eighteenth-century Japanese culture

In eighteenth-century Japanese culture, Aokigahara's area belongs to the world of Fuji as sacred total landscape, not to the world of gothic forest horror.

It sits inside:

Kakugyō-derived Fuji-kō tradition; Miroku's 1733 doctrinal death; water purification at the Inner Eight Seas; Saiko/Shōji/Motosu as persistent sacred lakes; Ryūgū cave and Senoumi Shrine as a cave-water-dragon site; Asama deity incorporation in the Edo period; the memory of old Seno-umi divided by volcanic catastrophe; Fuji's renewed eighteenth-century disaster power after Hōei.

The emotional atmosphere is therefore:

awe, purification, fear of natural power, bodily discipline, petition for rain/harvest, sacred route, commoner suffering, world-renewal, and threshold-crossing.

Not suicide. Not “industrial death forest”. Not yet.

15. The strongest eighteenth-century thesis

Here is the answer, cleanly:

In the eighteenth century, Aokigahara was not a suicide site. It was the dark forested margin of Fuji’s sacred water system. Its real eighteenth-century importance lies in the Fuji-kō consolidation of Saiko, Shōji and Motosu as Inner Eight Seas pilgrimage waters, the Ryūgū cave/Senoumi Shrine complex as an Aokigahara-edge water-dragon-Fuji shrine, and the 1733 death of Jikigyō Miroku, which turned Fuji-kō into a mass commoner religion of suffering, purification and world-renewal.

The later suicide forest could take root there because the eighteenth century had already made the terrain liminal: cave, lake, lava, sacred water, dragon, purification, bodily extremity, and Fuji’s terrible/saving power.

But the eighteenth-century forest itself was not yet the modern “place to vanish”. It was part of a ritual landscape where people went not to disappear from the social ledger, but to cleanse, petition, endure, circulate, and place themselves under Fuji.

That is the precise historical difference.

19th Century

The nineteenth century answer is much colder and more revealing than the suicide-history answer:

In the 1800s, Aokigahara was not yet “the suicide forest”. The available nineteenth-century record shows something almost opposite: a difficult but used lava-forest, embedded in pilgrimage routes, village economies, cave refrigeration, charcoal/timber extraction, sericulture, mountain traffic, and early international scenic tourism. Its later death-reputation was not present as a stable public identity. What the nineteenth century created was the precondition: a place already legible as no-ordinary-ground — cold, cave-ridden, difficult, sacred-adjacent, economically useful, and then suddenly aestheticised for outsiders.

That is the real nineteenth-century structure.

0. Boundary: what counts as nineteenth century here

I am taking “nineteenth century” strictly: 1800—1899. That means excluding Matsumoto, Tsurumi, the 1928 Shōjiko double-suicide, Taishō guidebooks, 1905 Fuji guidebooks, 1925 *富士山の自然界*, and all later “suicide forest” material except where a later source preserves nineteenth-century facts.

The hard conclusion is: I do not see a reliable nineteenth-century suicide-site layer in the accessible sources. The nineteenth-century Aokigahara record is about use, route, cave, shrine, forest product, pilgrimage, sericulture, and landscape discovery — not organised suicide.

That absence matters. It means the later “death forest” was not the survival of a nineteenth-century suicide tradition. It was built later on top of a different nineteenth-century landscape.

1. Early nineteenth century: Aokigahara is not a void; it is embedded in village geography

The essential early nineteenth-century source is 『甲斐国志』, completed in 1814. The National Archives catalogue describes it as a 123-volume chorography of Kai Province, compiled from 1806 to 1814 under Matsudaira Sadayoshi, using local village submissions and organised into sections on law, villages, mountains/rivers, old sites, shrines, religious practitioners, people and commoners. ([digital.archives.go.jp](https://www.digital.archives.go.jp/file/1257083))

This matters methodologically. If we want pre-modern/early nineteenth-century Aokigahara, we should not start with “suicide” or “haunting”. We start with 地誌 — local gazetteer knowledge.

The relevant settlement is 精進村 / Shōji village. The historical place-name entry says Shōji lay south of Furuseki, on the north-west foot of Fuji, in the Aokigahara/mountain zone, with Lake Shōji; it was on the Naka-michi Ōkan / 中道往還, a road linking Kai and Suruga; and *Kainokuni-shi* says the name was associated with En no Ozunu purifying himself in the lake before Fuji ascent. ([kotobank.jp](https://kotobank.jp/word/%E7%B2%BE%E9%80%B2%E6%9D%91-3057454?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That gives the first microscopic point: in the nineteenth-century documentary imagination, the forest-edge was not “trackless death”. It was attached to village, lake, road, purification, and route.

2. The road layer: Aokigahara’s western/northern edge sits beside a traffic corridor

The Naka-michi Ōkan is crucial. It ran from Kōfu southwards, over the Ubaguchi/Anan-saka area, past Lake Shōji and towards Motosu and Suruga. A historical place-name entry describes it as one of the roads connecting Kai and Suruga, normally called Naka-michi because it lay between the Wakihiko route and the Kawachi route. ([kotobank.jp](https://kotobank.jp/word/%E4%B8%AD%E9%81%93%E5%BE%80%E9%82%84-1382467?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Shōji was therefore not pure wilderness. It was a road-and-lake settlement on a through-route. Another entry says Motosu village lay by Aokigahara and the surrounding mountains, on the Kai—Suruga border of the Naka-michi, with a 口留番所 checkpoint. ([kotobank.jp](https://kotobank.jp/word/%E6%9C%AC%E6%A0%96%E6%9D%91-3057456?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That changes the whole feel of the nineteenth-century landscape. The forest was peripheral and difficult, yes, but it was adjacent to movement: pilgrims, traders, road users, post-town functions, border control, lake settlements, Fuji routes.

The later myth says: enter and vanish.

The nineteenth-century road system says: pass through, carry, trade, lodge, police the border.

Those are different worlds.

3. The religious-water layer: Shōji and Saiko were purification space before they were death-space

The name 精進 itself is not neutral. The Shōji place-name tradition links it to 精進潔 — ritual purification before Fuji ascent. The Fuji Five Lakes pilgrimage material similarly describes Shōji as one of the places linked to Fuji-kō water practice and the 内八海巡り, the circuit of sacred waters around Fuji. ([fujiguide.fujisan-sengen.jp](https://www.fujiguide.fujisan-sengen.jp/navi/39/?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is not death evidence. It is purification evidence.

That distinction is vital. In the nineteenth century, the cultural grammar around Shōji/Saiko/Aokigahara is not “go there to die”; it is “water, mountain, pilgrimage, purification, route, cave, deity”.

A later culture can turn liminality into death. But the nineteenth-century layer itself is broader: sacred water and movement around Fuji.

4. 1848: the most death-adjacent nineteenth-century source is not suicide, but pilgrimage memorial

The strongest nineteenth-century death-adjacent object I found is the 根子の内八海道供養碑, built in 1848. Minobu town describes it as a Fuji-faith monument connected to 内八海巡り, the pilgrimage circuit around Fuji's lakes/waters. It says the monument likely related to safe passage on the route from Motosu towards Shibireko and/or to the memorialisation of pilgrims who unfortunately died on the route. ([town.minobu.lg.jp](https://www.town.minobu.lg.jp/page/1803.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is very important.

It gives us a nineteenth-century death relation, but not the modern one. The deaths are not framed as suicide. They are framed as pilgrimage-route vulnerability: road, mountain, lake, safety, memorial, prayer.

So if we are being exact:

Nineteenth-century death around the Aokigahara-adjacent Fuji-water network appears as pilgrimage danger and memorialisation, not as voluntary self-erasure.

That is a clean distinction.

5. The cave-shrine layer: Ryūgū cave and Senoumi Shrine sit inside the forest' s sacred geography

The nineteenth century inherits an older cave-shrine system. Senoumi Shrine is now associated with Ryūgū cave at Saiko/Aokigahara. Yamanashi Shrine Agency says Toyotama-hime was enshrined at a lava-cave entrance in 913 during famine, that Asama deity worship was added in the Edo period, and that it was a Fuji-kō Eight-Seas pilgrimage sacred place as the Aoki dragon-god.

([yamanashi-jinjacho.or.jp] (https://www.yamanashi-jinjacho.or.jp/intro/search/detail/7156?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Yamanashi' s tourism page similarly says Senoumi Shrine is enshrined in Ryūgū cave, that the cave was a Fuji-kō Eight-Seas pilgrimage site, and that the old Senoumi lake was divided by the Jōgan eruption into Motosu, Shōji and Saiko. ([yamanashi-kankou.jp] (https://www.yamanashi-kankou.jp/rekitabi/jisha/spott/196.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

What this gives us for the nineteenth century is not a suicide tradition, but a cave-water-dragon-rain-pilgrimage complex.

The cave is cold, dark, sacred, associated with water, dragon, weather, Fuji-kō, and the vanished Seno-umi lake. This is the nineteenth-century symbolic substrate. It is not “death forest” ; it is threshold forest.

6. The working-forest layer: charcoal, timber, tools, fuel

The next layer is anti-gothic. Aokigahara was useful.

A modern source drawing on *Kainokuni-shi* notes that the forest' s charcoal was regarded as good, and that nearby villagers entered, cut, and obtained fuelwood/charcoal material. This is secondary, so I would not over-weight it without checking the manuscript page, but it fits with the wider record of local use. ([note.com] (https://note.com/aokigahara/n/n059ab9d775c7?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Fuji-san Net' s Shōji entry also says that until early Shōwa, natural hinoki from Aokigahara was cut and used for objects such as silk-reeling frames, carrying poles, hoe handles, chopsticks and geta; that is later than our nineteenth-century boundary, but it preserves the older practical-use pattern. ([fujisan-net.jp] (https://www.fujisan-net.jp/?p=2000175&utm_source=chatgpt.com))

The important point: the nineteenth-century forest was not merely an object of dread. It was a resource field.

It produced:

charcoal; fuelwood; hinoki timber; tool material; possibly roof/forest products; routes; cold caves; pilgrimage sites.

That is the local Aokigahara before the outsider death image.

7. 1879—1880: the forest' s cold caves become Meiji industrial technology

This is probably the single most important nineteenth-century transformation.

The Yamanashi Digital Archive entry for 『富士風穴略』 says that silkworm eggs were stored in wind caves; this technique began with silkworm-seed traders in Matsumoto; in Yamanashi, Mimori Chūzaemon of Higashiyamanashi began wind-cave storage for autumn silkworm eggs in 1879; and Fuji Wind Cave was discovered in 1880. The same entry says Fuji Wind Cave had especially suitable meteorological conditions and large scale, later coming under Hatta Tatsuya's management.
([digi.lib.pref.yamanashi.jp](https://digi.lib.pref.yamanashi.jp/da/detail?tilcod=0000000021-YMNS0121473&utm_source=chatgpt.com))

That is enormous.

Aokigahara's nineteenth-century caves were not just sacred or uncanny; they became part of Japan's export-oriented silk economy. Natural cold air became a biological clock-control technology. By delaying silkworm egg hatching, cave storage helped make autumn silkworm rearing possible.

The KAKEN summary of modern Japanese silkworm-seed storage wind caves explains the broader system: from Meiji through Taishō, natural cold-air caves were used as cooling devices for silkworm eggs, supporting multi-season sericulture and increased cocoon/raw-silk production; Yamanashi and Gunma later developed large-scale wind-cave facilities using central technical/human support.
([kaken.nii.ac.jp](https://kaken.nii.ac.jp/grant/KAKENHI-PROJECT-22904007/?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So the nineteenth-century forest becomes not “the place outside modernity”, but a strange engine inside modernity: lava cave as industrial refrigerator.

That is a genuinely revelatory inversion.

8. The Hatta Tatsuya complication: sources disagree on the exact institutional date

There is a date problem, and it matters.

One Fuji-san Net page says Hatta Tatsuya noticed Fuji Wind Cave's low temperature and planned silkworm-seed storage, establishing/opening Hattatsukan / 八達館 in 1892.
([fujisan-net.jp](https://www.fujisan-net.jp/?p=2000175&utm_source=chatgpt.com))

The Yamanashi Digital Archive says Fuji Wind Cave was discovered in 1880 and later came to be managed by Hatta Tatsuya. ([digi.lib.pref.yamanashi.jp](https://digi.lib.pref.yamanashi.jp/da/detail?tilcod=00000021-YMNS0121473&utm_source=chatgpt.com))

A Yamanashi prefectural “Fureai” feature says Hatta brought the Fuji Wind Cave silkworm-seed storage facility under Hattatsukan in 1900, just outside our nineteenth-century boundary.
([pref.yamanashi.jp](https://www.pref.yamanashi.jp/ebook/fureai/vol155_2/pageindices/index19.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is not a contradiction if we distinguish stages:

1879: Yamanashi begins wind-cave storage for autumn silkworm eggs elsewhere. 1880: Fuji Wind Cave is discovered. 1892: one source places Hatta's opening/planning of Hattatsukan-related Fuji Wind Cave operations here. 1900: another source places formal incorporation under Hattatsukan here.

The safe conclusion is: by the final decades of the nineteenth century, Aokigahara's cold caves were being converted from natural/sacred spaces into sericultural infrastructure; the exact corporate formalisation needs archival checking.

That is the kind of precision this needs.

9. The sericulture meaning: Aokigahara as anti-death, life-timing machinery

This is the most important interpretive turn.

If later Aokigahara becomes a place of self-erasure, nineteenth-century Fuji Wind Cave is almost the opposite: a place for suspended life.

Silkworm eggs are not dead. They are paused. The cold cave delays hatching. The lava cave becomes a controlled environment where biological emergence is postponed until the right season.

That is symbolically extraordinary, but it is also materially exact. The Meiji state and local entrepreneurs were obsessed with silk production because raw silk was a major export industry. The KAKEN summary frames the wind-cave system as part of the modernisation of sericulture, increased cocoon production and export silk support. ([kaken.nii.ac.jp](https://kaken.nii.ac.jp/grant/KAKENHI-PROJECT-22904007/?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So nineteenth-century Aokigahara is not “death forest”. It is:

cold storage; delayed hatching; controlled emergence; rural stabilisation; export economy; biological timing.

Later culture says: the forest makes people disappear.

The nineteenth-century cave economy says: the forest lets life wait.

That is a serious finding.

10. 1895: the foreign scenic gaze arrives — Shōji Hotel and “Oriental Switzerland”

The second major late nineteenth-century transformation is tourism.

Fuji-san Net says that in 1895, the naturalised British man Harry Stewart Whitworth, known as Hoshino Yoshiharu, built Yamanashi’s first Western-style hotel, Shōji Hotel, after being moved by the beauty of Lake Shōji and Fuji; it helped introduce Shōji internationally. ([fujisan-net.jp](https://www.fujisan-net.jp/post_detail/2001604?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Another Fuji-san Net page says he built the hotel in 1895 and promoted the area overseas, with foreign tourists reportedly outnumbering Japanese visitors at that time. ([fujisan-net.jp](https://www.fujisan-net.jp/?p=2000175&utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Tabi-mag describes the same 1895 development and says Whitworth promoted Shōji as “Oriental Switzerland” and “Japan Shoji”, choosing the site for its view of Fuji with Ōmuro-yama in front — the “child-holding Fuji” view. ([tabi-mag.jp](https://tabi-mag.jp/yn0087/?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

This is a second inversion.

Aokigahara is not yet suicide-brand; it becomes scenic backdrop. From Shōji, the forest lies between viewer and Fuji, producing the “zero artificial objects” view that modern articles still praise. ([tabi-mag.jp](https://tabi-mag.jp/japan-shoji/?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So by the end of the nineteenth century, Aokigahara is being aestheticised in two directions:

local/industrial: cold cave, silkworm eggs, forest products; foreign/touristic: sublime green foreground beneath Fuji.

The later “forest of death” will parasitise that already-made scenic intensity.

11. The nineteenth-century forest is not “untrodden”

This is one of the most important corrections.

Later twentieth-century discourse will exaggerate Aokigahara as “human-untrodden” or “mysterious labyrinth”. But the nineteenth-century record shows repeated forms of entry and use:

road traffic around Shōji/Motosu; Fuji-kō pilgrimage/water circuit; Ryūgū cave worship; charcoal/timber extraction; silkworm-seed cave storage; hotel/tourism development; local village adjacency.

Even the route entries show Shōji and Motosu as parts of a road network, not isolated voids. ([kotobank.jp] (https://kotobank.jp/word/%E7%B2%BE%E9%80%B2%E6%9D%91-3057454?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

So the nineteenth-century Aokigahara was difficult, not unentered.

That difference matters because later “suicide forest” mythology needs unenteredness. The nineteenth century does not give it. It gives a more interesting object: a dangerous, cold, sacred-adjacent, useful forest people knew how to use.

12. What about “death” in the nineteenth century?

Strictly, I find three death-adjacent nineteenth-century layers:

First, pilgrimage danger and memorialisation, especially the 1848 Inner-Eight-Seas road memorial. That is death on the road, not suicide. ([town.minobu.lg.jp] (https://www.town.minobu.lg.jp/page/1803.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Second, Fuji-kō sacred extremity, inherited from earlier practices and still active in nineteenth-century religious geography. The Ryūgū/Senoumi complex remains a Fuji-kō pilgrimage site; Hitoana also undergoes Meiji transformation after the early-Meiji separation of Shinto and Buddhism. ([yamanashi-jinjacho.or.jp] (https://www.yamanashi-jinjacho.or.jp/intro/search/detail/7156?utm_source=chatgpt.com))

Third, the natural affordance of disorientation, which must have existed physically, but I do not see a nineteenth-century source converting it into a suicide destination. That conversion appears later.

So the nineteenth-century death relation is:

danger, memorial, cave-otherworld, purification, route vulnerability — not suicide-place identity.

That is the most important negative finding.

13. What the nineteenth century contributes to the later suicide forest

The nineteenth century creates five preconditions.

One: terrain credibility. The lava forest and cave system make no-return imagery physically plausible.

Two: sacred thresholding. Water, cave, dragon, Fuji-kō, purification and pilgrimage make the forest-edge liminal.

Three: local practical familiarity. The forest is not empty; villagers use it. This later allows outsider mythology to misrepresent it.

Four: industrial coldness. The caves become refrigeration technology for silkworm eggs — a bizarrely modern use of the underworld-like landscape.

Five: scenic outsider gaze. The 1895 Shōji Hotel transforms the forest/lake/Fuji configuration into international picturesque space.

Only after these layers exist can twentieth-century media turn Aokigahara into “the forest where one disappears”.

14. The most important nineteenth-century source list

Here is the core pre-1900 packet, ranked.

1. 『甲斐国志』, completed 1814. Use for early nineteenth-century administrative/local geography: villages, roads, mountains, shrines, place-name traditions, local uses. The National Archives confirms its compilation context and structure. ([digital.archives.go.jp] (<https://www.digital.archives.go.jp/file/1257083>))
2. 精進村 / 本栖村 historical place-name entries. Use for Shōji/Motosu's position in Aokigahara/mountain geography, Naka-michi road, post-town/checkpoint functions, and the purification-name tradition. ([kotobank.jp] (https://kotobank.jp/word/%E7%B2%BE%E9%80%B2%E6%9D%91-3057454?utm_source=chatgpt.com))
3. 中道往還 records. Use for the road system: Kai—Suruga movement, Shōji/Motosu as through-corridor, not wilderness. ([kotobank.jp] (https://kotobank.jp/word/%E4%B8%AD%E9%81%93%E5%BE%80%E9%82%84-1382467?utm_source=chatgpt.com))
4. 根子の内八海道供養碑, 1848. Use for Inner-Eight-Seas pilgrimage-route death/memorial/safety, the closest serious nineteenth-century death-adjacent material. ([town.minobu.lg.jp] (https://www.town.minobu.lg.jp/page/1803.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com))
5. 剱海神社 / 龍宮洞穴 material. Use for cave-water-dragon-Fuji-kō sacred geography inherited into the nineteenth century. ([yamanashi-jinjacho.or.jp] (https://www.yamanashi-jinjacho.or.jp/intro/search/detail/7156?utm_source=chatgpt.com))
6. 『富士風穴略』 / Yamanashi Digital Archive. Use for wind-cave silkworm-seed storage: 1879 Yamanashi beginning, 1880 Fuji Wind Cave discovery, later Hatta management. ([digi.lib.pref.yamanashi.jp] (https://digi.lib.pref.yamanashi.jp/da/detail?tilcod=0000000021-YMNS0121473&utm_source=chatgpt.com))
7. Hatta Tatsuya / Hattatsukan material. Use for the late-Meiji institutionalisation of Fuji Wind Cave sericulture; be careful about 1892 versus 1900 dating. ([fujisan-net.jp] (https://www.fujisan-net.jp/?p=2000175&utm_source=chatgpt.com))
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Final thesis: nineteenth century only

In the nineteenth century, Aokigahara was not primarily a death-site.

It was a liminal working landscape.

At its edges were Shōji and Motosu: road villages, pilgrimage water-sites, traffic points between Kai and Suruga. Within and around it were lava caves: sacred to Fuji-kō, useful for rain/water worship, and then converted into Meiji sericultural cold-storage technology. Its trees and charcoal mattered to villagers. Its lake-and-Fuji views became international scenic capital after Shōji Hotel opened in 1895. Its danger was real, but it was not yet the public script. Its no-return quality existed as terrain and perhaps local warning, but had not yet become the modern suicide identity.

So if the question is “what does the nineteenth century reveal at the deepest level?” , the answer is:

The nineteenth-century forest was a place where life was routed, purified, stored, delayed, traded, worshipped, cooled, cut, carried and viewed. Later, the twentieth century turned that same landscape into a place where life was imagined as disappearing.

That is the revelation. The suicide forest was made from a much older and stranger nineteenth-century object: a cold, sacred, economically useful lava-forest on the edge of roads and lakes, already powerful enough to become myth, but not yet captured by death.